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The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

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Happening today

● **MERA YUVA BHARAT**, under the Ministry of Youth Affairs & Sports, will organise the 'Youth for Viksit Bharat – MY Bharat Youth Convention' in Delhi. It is expected to bring together over 6,000 young participants.

TRACK THIS AND MORE ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

CJP founder Dipke lands in Delhi today, police prepare for protest

Mahender Singh Manral & Jatin Anand
New Delhi, June 5

DELHI POLICE has issued a series of instructions to its personnel for the planned protest by supporters of the online satirical platform 'Cockroach Janta Party' (CJP) at Jantar Mantar on Saturday.

The 2,000-odd personnel who will be deployed in the New Delhi district have been directed to avoid confrontation with the protesters and to try to keep them calm through persuasion, sources said.

The district will be divided into 12 zones, each of which will be headed by a DCP-rank officer.

Police will step up deployment outside the homes of VIPs including Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Home Minister Amit Shah, and Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

FIIs HOLD Rs 3.75 LAKH CRORE, OR 3.34%, OF Rs 112 LAKH CRORE GOVT DEBT

To draw funds, prop rupee, Govt scraps FII capital gains, withholding tax on bonds

Re under pressure, BoP deficit likely to be around \$50-60 bn, move expected to result in good foreign fund inflows

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, June 5

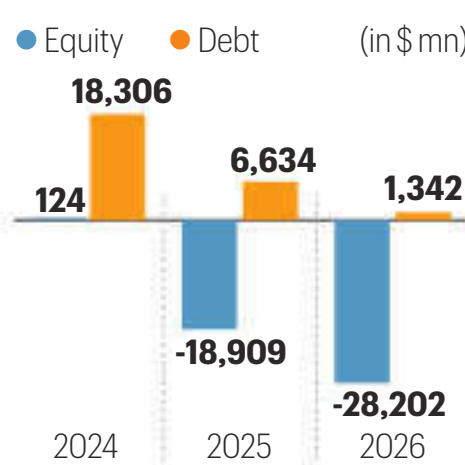
AMID PRESSURE to attract foreign funds and also stabilise the rupee, the Centre on Friday scrapped the capital gains tax, both long-term and short-term, on investment by Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) in government bonds as well as the withholding tax they must pay on their interest income from these debt instruments. At present, FIIs pay 12.5% tax on long-term capital gains, 30% on short-term capital gains, and around 20% withholding tax on interest income.

The decision, taken after at least two months of internal discussions, is expected to bring tens of billions of dollars in foreign fund into government debt over the coming years, and bridge to some extent the looming balance of payments (BoP) deficit that economists estimate could even touch \$60 billion in 2026-27.

In an ordinance promulgated to amend the Income Tax Act, 2025, after President

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Foreign investment in debt positive, but falling



NOTE: FPI INVESTMENT IN DEBT INCLUDES GENERAL, VOLUNTARY RETENTION, AND FULLY ACCESSIBLE ROUTES; SOURCE: NSDL

E. EXPLAINED

Addressing concerns

To assuage global investors, the government and the RBI have in unison announced a string of decisions to attract foreign money. In the last couple of years, heavy pull-out by FPIs from equities and poor net FDI inflows have exerted pressure on the rupee.

FY26 growth estimate raised to 7.7 per cent; momentum strong: PM

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, June 5

THE INDIAN economy ended 2025-26 on an unexpectedly strong note, with the GDP estimated to have grown 7.7% on the back of higher growth in investments, the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) said on Friday.

GDP growth in the last quarter of the year, or January-March 2026, declined slightly to 7.8% from 8% in October-December 2025 — revised upwards from 7.8% — despite the West Asia war overlapping with the final month.

Marginal revisions were also made to the GDP growth

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

RBI eases norms for PSUs, banks to get foreign fund inflows

George Mathew
Mumbai, June 5

TO ENCOURAGE foreign capital inflows, the Reserve Bank of India on Friday eased norms for state-owned enterprises to borrow overseas and for banks to mobilise foreign current deposits. The move complements the government's decision to

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Owner of B&B where 21 died was held last yr in fake passport case

Police: Bajaj took money to let Bangla nationals use his Delhi home address

Mahender Singh Manral & Alok Singh
New Delhi, June 5

LAVKESH BAJAJ, the 60-year-old owner of Flourish Stays B&B in South Delhi's Hauz Rani, where 21 people died in a fire Wednesday morning, was first arrested by Delhi Police last year in a fake passport case involving Bangladeshi nationals in central Delhi. He was chargesheeted in the case and subsequently granted bail, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

THE BIG PICTURE

A neighbourhood called Hauz Rani
PAGE 15

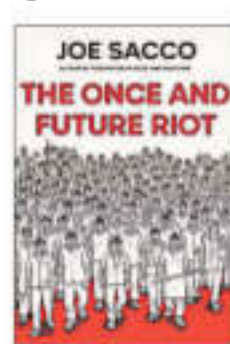
Bajaj was arrested Wednesday evening by a team led by Assistant Commissioner of Police Ritu Raj. On Thursday, the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Penguin pulls plug on Joe Sacco's book on Muzaffarnagar riots

Ritu Sarin
New Delhi, June 5

JOE SACCO, the acclaimed graphic novelist whose illustrated dispatches from Gaza, Palestine, and the Balkans have explored new facets in war journalism and comics reporting, turned his unflinching eye on India in his latest work, *The Once and Future Riot*. In 135



Inaccurate map of India, no response to questions on content, claims publisher

pages, it chronicles the 2013 Muzaffarnagar communal

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Differential rates on deposits beyond RBI norms not acceptable, says Governor

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, June 5

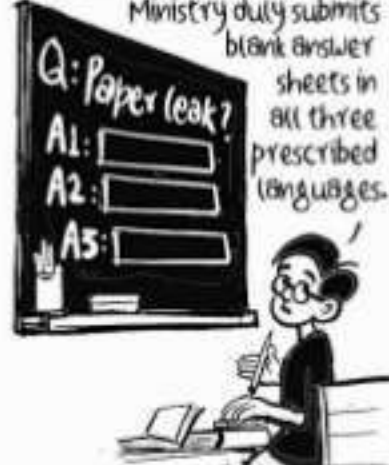
RBI GOVERNOR Sanjay Malhotra said Friday that banks are permitted to provide differential interest rates on deposits in certain cases like senior citizens, but the central bank has very clear policies and conditions for such instances. He said banks must be transparent by clearly displaying rates to everyone, and offering undisclosed preferential rates is "certainly not acceptable".

"We have a very consistent and very clear policy on deposits, as to when they can have differential rates. I think for certain categories of people like senior citizens, or depending on tenure... (in such cases) then you can have differential rates," Malhotra said at the post monetary policy press conference.

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By EP UNNY



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A spiritual visit

Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar visits a monastery in Dharamshala on Friday. PTI

Amarnath Yatra security boost: QR-based IDs for pony operators, fire audits

Naveed Iqbal & Arun Sharma
Jammu, Srinagar, June 5

SPECIALISED SECURITY teams, fire safety audits of hotels and guest houses, QR-based IDs for guides and pony operators, and expanded CCTV coverage are among the measures being planned for the Amarnath Yatra, scheduled to begin on July 3.

With the annual pilgrimage set to start next month, extensive security arrangements are being put in place for yatris. Senior security officials said 140 companies of CAPF will be deployed along the route alongside the J&K Police and other forces. SSP, Anantnag, Amod Nagpure said Friday that J&K Police have begun area domination and preventive action exercises in the district. “Specialised teams of the J&K Police such as Markhors, Snow Leopards and Mountain Rescue Teams among others are involved in providing security to the pilgrims travelling to the cave,” he said. Police pickets have been established along the route to the cave. The number of elevated police checkpoints has also been increased, while CCTV coverage is being expanded.

Among the key measures is a fire safety audit of all hotels and guest houses across Jammu

province — a move that assumes significance after 21 people died in a fire at a ground-plus-five-storeyed bed-and-breakfast establishment in Delhi’s Malviya Nagar. Officials, citing an order from the office of the Divisional Commissioner, Jammu, said the audit will be conducted in all 10 districts of Jammu province. The panel, comprising a magistrate, officials from tourism, fire and emergency services and the public works (R&B) department, besides an SDRF representative, will submit daily reports.

“In view of the prevailing heat-wave conditions and recent fire incidents, and keeping in mind the safety of pilgrims/tourists, all Deputy Commissioners of Jammu division are directed to constitute a committee in the district under their respective jurisdiction for conducting safety audits of Hotels/ Guest Houses etc, with special emphasis on fire audit,” the order said. Police will also introduce QR-based identification for service providers like pony operators and guides through a mobile app called “Pehchan”. RFID will also be issued to every registered pilgrim. The Amarnath Yatra, which draws lakhs of pilgrims every year, will run for 57 days this year from July 3-August 28. Last year, it lasted around 38 days.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

FII capital gains, withholding tax

Droupadi Murmu gave her assent, the government said the changes will come into effect from April 1, 2026. FII investment in government bonds stands at Rs 3.75 lakh crore, or just 3.34% of the available amount of Rs 112.42 lakh crore, under the so-called General Route and Fully Accessible Route (FAR). These are the two ways in which foreign investors invest in Indian government securities.

According to Axis Bank economists, no tax on FII investment in government debt could lead to \$45-50 billion inflows over two years.

A BoP deficit exerts pressure on the rupee to weaken. While the rupee has gained some ground since nearly breaching the 97-per-dollar mark last month, it is down 5% since the war began on February 27 and has slumped 10.3% in the last one year. After closing at 95.79 per dollar on Thursday, it ended sharply higher at 94.94 on Friday. Meanwhile, yields on government bonds declined.

The tax exemption on “any interest on Government security, and any capital gains arising

from the sale, exchange or transfer of such Government security” applies to FIIs as well as the Bank for International Settlements. The BIS is an organisation of central banks from around the world. It is yet to invest in India.

Until now, while foreign investors had to pay a long-term capital gains tax of 12.5% on listed stocks and bonds that they hold for more than 12 months, they also had to pay a withholding tax – akin to a tax deducted at source – on interest income from their holding of bonds. Non-residents paid a withholding tax of about 20% on their interest income from government bonds – one of the highest in the world – after a concessional rate of 5% ended in 2023. The tax on short-term capital gains was 30%.

Investors from countries with which India has double taxation avoidance agreements pay lower rates. Meanwhile, investors who don’t have an Indian tax residency are at a further disadvantage because the withholding tax must be paid on the gross amount and losses can’t be set off against past gains.

The Indian Express had reported on May 15 the government and the Reserve Bank of India were considering multiple measures to attract foreign investment inflows, including a cut in the withholding tax rate on government bonds, if not completely eliminating it.

Timing with tax elimination, the RBI too said Friday it was “expanding the universe” of government securities that fall in the so-called Fully Accessible Route (FAR) to include all new issuances of 15-, 30- and 40-year bonds.

“In addition, limits pertaining to short-term investment, concentration and individual securities on FPI investment under the General Route are being removed. These measures along with the tax benefits provided by the government this morning should help attract foreign capital for government borrowing,” Governor Sanjay Malhotra said while announcing a raft of other measures to boost foreign inflows into the country. While he did not specify how much foreign money could come into India because of the steps that have been taken, he

said the hope was that a healthy amount would do so.

“The combined impact of these could help bridge the \$40-50 billion gap in the Balance of Payments that we had estimated for FY27. We see an appreciation bias likely for the rupee over the coming months as the actual flows on account of these measures start trickling in,” Sakshi Gupta, Chief Economist at HDFC Bank, said.

Experts have long warned that the withholding tax is an obstacle to stronger foreign inflows, with Ananth Narayan, former Whole Time Member at the Securities and Exchange Board of India, saying last month the tax is the source of a lot of “friction”. “I am not saying that if you solve this tomorrow, money will come in. But this is definitely a barrier for money to come into the country,” he had said.

As such, the removal of the two taxes on Indian government bonds could boost inflows at a time when Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) have pulled out \$28 billion from Indian stock markets so far in 2026.

“The whole world is fixated on foreign portfolio flows into equities, but FPI debt inflows are not insignificant,” DSP Mutual Fund said on Thursday.

FY26 growth estimate

estimates for April-June 2025 (6.7% to 6.8%) and July-September 2025 (8.4% to 8.3%).

The full-year GDP growth figure of 7.7% released Friday, called the provisional estimate, is higher than MoSPI’s second advance estimate of 7.6% announced in February. India’s GDP had grown by 7.1% in 2024-25.

“India’s growth momentum remains strong!” Prime Minister Narendra Modi said in a post on X. “GDP growth rate of 7.7% in FY 2025-26 and 7.8% in Q4 of FY 2025-26 reflect the inherent strength of our economy, the success of reforms and the hard work of 140 crore Indians. We shall leave no stone unturned to further ‘Ease of Living,’ ‘Ease of Doing Business’ and increase opportunities for our youth.”

While growth in the Gross Value Added (GVA) by the agriculture sector eased to 3% in 2025-26 from 4.2% the previous year, the manufacturing sector expanded at a double-digit rate of 10.7%, up from 9.3% in 2024-25.

The services sector also grew at a faster clip last year, with the category of trade, hotels, transport, communication and services related to broadcasting and storage growing 11% as against 6.6% in 2024-25, “reflecting the trend of higher mobility in the economy and higher travel and tourism activity”, said Madan

Sabnavis, Chief Economist at Bank of Baroda.

Meanwhile, financial, real estate, IT and professional services saw their GVA increase 10.4%, up from 10%.

On the whole, real GVA growth in 2025-26 rose to 7.9% from 7.3% the previous year.

GVA measures the value addition, or the difference in value of output produced and the value of input used. It is also calculated by subtracting net product taxes from the GDP.

“The fact that GVA growth at 7.9% outpaced GDP growth suggests that India’s expansion was not solely demand-driven but also backed by strong production momentum,” said Rumki Majumdar, Economist at Deloitte India. “Performance across services, manufacturing and construction indicates that the economy has entered a period of global uncertainty from a position of strength, which should help it better absorb potential supply-side shocks.”

Last year, Private Final Consumption Expenditure increased 7.7%, sharply higher than the 5.8% growth recorded in 2024-25. Gross Fixed Capital Formation – a proxy for investments – also rose at a faster rate of 8.2% as against 6.4%. Investment growth was particularly strong in the January-March 2026 quarter, rising to a 13-quarter high of 10.8%.

• GDP growth improved in FY26		
	2024-25	2025-26
Agriculture	4.2%	3.0%
Mining	11.7%	5.2%
Manufacturing	9.3%	10.7%
Electricity, other utility services	2.9%	1.7%
Construction	7.3%	7.4%
Trade, hotels, transport	6.6%	11.0%
Financial, real estate, IT	10.0%	10.4%
Public administration, defence, other services	5.0%	5.0%
Gross Value Added	7.3%	7.9%
GDP	7.1%	7.7%

NOTE: GROWTH RATES ARE IN REAL TERMS; SOURCE: MOSPI

The latest GDP data came hours after the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) cut its forecast for 2026-27 to 6.6% from 6.9%, with Governor Sanjay Malhotra warning that while domestic demand remains resilient and manufacturing and services sectors activity continue to expand, “there are incipient signs of moderation in some sectors”.

As per the central bank’s latest forecast, growth is seen at 6.6% in April-June 2026, 6.3% in July-September 2026, 6.5% in October-December 2026, and 6.8% in January-March 2027. In April, the central bank had expected the country’s GDP to increase by 6.8%, 6.7%, 7%, and 7.2% in the four quarters of 2026-27.

While the Indian economy entered the West Asia war on a strong footing, economists widely expect growth to slow down meaningfully in the

coming months – as indicated by RBI’s own forecasts.

According to Devendra Kumar Pant, Chief Economist at India Ratings & Research, the higher energy prices and weak rupee due to the conflict as well as weaker rainfall because of El Nino “is likely to have an impact on India’s growth-inflation dynamics”. Pant expects GDP growth to slow down to 6.7% in 2026-27 and inflation to increase to 5%, broadly in line with what the RBI has predicted.

“Markets are likely to move on from the backward-looking data and focus on potential spill-over risks into FY27, particularly given the prospect of a prolonged disruption in the supply of critical inputs to downstream industries, higher energy as well as food costs impacting purchasing power and tighter financial conditions,” said Radhika Rao, Senior Economist at DBS Bank.

RBI eases norms

do away with capital gains tax and withholding tax on FII investment in government bonds.

The RBI will provide a concessional foreign exchange swap facility until September 30, 2026 to encourage external commercial borrowings (ECBs) by public sector firms. At the core, the RBI is effectively lowering the hedging and funding cost of borrowing in foreign currency by PSUs, enabling them to raise cheaper funds abroad. This move has come at a time when investment in new projects has become sluggish and growth has declined.

A swap facility allows PSUs to convert rupee liabilities into foreign currency exposure, or vice versa, at more favourable terms than market-based hedging. By making this “concessional” and time-bound (until September 30), the central bank is explicitly nudging them to tap cheaper overseas capital. Big oil, power and infrastructure PSUs have traditionally relied on ECBs. However, in recent years, many shifted to domestic bonds, sovereign-backed financing, or multilateral loans, as the ECB route turned riskier due to foreign exchange exposure.

The RBI said a similar facility, covering the full hedging cost, will be available to authorised dealer banks raising fresh three- to five-year FCNR(B) deposits until September 2026. The facility effectively changes the economics of long-tenor foreign currency borrowing for banks since the hedging costs are usually one of the biggest deterrents when banks try to attract non-resident inflows.

A Foreign Currency Non-Resident Bank account is a fixed

deposit held in India by NRIs or Overseas Citizens of India (OCIs). Unlike typical rupee accounts, it allows you to park your overseas earnings directly in foreign currencies (like USD, GBP, EUR, or CAD) to entirely avoid currency fluctuation risks.

Banks can now offer more competitive interest rates without worrying about expensive forward cover or swap costs eating into margins, and this typically results in a stronger pipeline of stable, medium-term foreign currency inflows into the banking system. This can help smoothen foreign exchange liquidity conditions and support external account stability because higher FCNR(B) inflows increase dollar availability with banks.

Banks raised just \$946 million in FY26 under the FCNR (B) route as against \$7 billion in FY25, according to RBI data.

In 2013, when the rupee was under pressure, banks were given a special swap window with the RBI, allowing them to raise FCNR (B) deposits from NRIs and swap those foreign currency funds (mainly US dollars) with the central bank at a predetermined rate for a fixed tenure, typically three to five years. Banks raised close to \$30 billion through this scheme in 2013.

“The decision to provide full hedging support to authorized dealer banks for mobilizing 3-5 year FCNR(B) deposits, along with concessional forex swap facilities to incentivise ECB borrowings by PSUs, is likely to attract meaningful dollar inflows into the system,” said Shobit Gupta, Chief Investment Officer, Generali Central Life Insurance.

Deposit rates

Declining to comment on any specific entity, he said, “But they (banks) have to be transparent at the same time. You have to display them (the rates) to everyone clearly, and any differential rate beyond that, if someone is giving, is certainly not acceptable.”

Malhotra’s remarks were in response to questions on the legality of banks providing loans with differential interest rates after *The Indian Express* reported last week that HDFC Bank’s internal records showed the bank had made interest payments of Rs 45 crore to the Maharashtra State Road Development Corporation (MSRDC) for 2023-24 and 2024-25.

Internal investigations in the bank, which took place just six days before then chairman

Atanu Chakraborty had resigned citing certain practices within the bank not being congruent to his personal values, showed that these payments were meant as “differential interest” to MSRDC, i.e., interest on deposits over and above the specified rate. However, these payments were routed through the bank’s marketing department.

In its exchange filing, the bank said, “...we wish to state that in line with the highest corporate governance standards of the Bank, the Internal Audit function conducts reviews, identifies and presents its observations from time to time. As such, the observations of Internal Audit function are comprehensively addressed by the Bank and that applies to the matter in question.”

B&B owner

South District police sought his custody before a Delhi court to ascertain and verify the details of all workers, employees and others engaged in the operation of Flourish Stays, and to trace and apprehend Jay Mishra, the accountant of the establishment, and Rakesh, the manager of the hotel.

Bajaj, who is in police custody for four days, is being questioned. Police are conducting raids to nab Mishra and a team has been sent to his hometown in Bihar.

According to a senior police officer, Bajaj had been arrested last year after an FIR was registered at Paharganj police station. “The case was registered in January, and he was arrested

months later after police found his connivance during the investigation. He was sent to Tihar Jail and was released on bail after 15 days,” the officer said, adding that the matter is still sub judice.

Sharing details of the case, police said three Bangladeshi nationals – Sweeti Sarkar, her daughter Pushpo Sarkar and Pushpo’s minor son – were living illegally at a house in Paharganj, using forged Indian identity documents, including Aadhaar cards and an Indian passport.

The FIR stated that on January 29, 2025, police visited the house and found the two women and the minor boy. They failed to produce valid identity documents and, during a search of the house, police allegedly recovered two Bangladeshi passports, an Indian passport, Aadhaar cards, and several

Dipke

who has been targeted by the protesters.

Abhijeet Dipke, who started the ‘Cockroach Janta Party’ Instagram and X handles that became a phenomenon within days of their launch last month, is expected to arrive in Delhi from the United States on Saturday morning.

On Friday evening, spokespersons for the “youth pressure group” gave a call for a protest at Jantar Mantar to demand the resignation of Pradhan. “6 June, 9 am...Get ready to swarm the streets of Delhi with peaceful and loving dissent,” they posted on X.

The Indian Express has learnt that police have issued an internal communication to all district and unit DCPs, alerting them of possible heavy mobilisation, traffic disruption and law-and-order issues in parts of the capital on Saturday.

Until Friday night, the BJP had not officially sought permission from the police to hold the protest at Jantar Mantar. However, police were open to granting permission even on Saturday, sources said.

“There is a possibility that they will seek permission on Saturday morning, and it has been decided so far to give them permission after taking a proper undertaking. All districts, especially North, Central, South-east, Southwest, have been asked to provide smooth facilitation to all students who are coming to join the protest,” a source said.

Police officers have been told to carry out videography, photography and drone surveillance at protest sites, the sources said.

According to the BJP, Dipke, who has been in Boston, is expected to land in Delhi at 8 am, and travel from the airport to Parliament Street police station to seek permission for the protest. He is expected to be accompanied by his colleagues and activists including Sonam Wangchuk of Ladakh.

“On my way to India...Leaving my fate in the hands of the Constitution. #JaiBhim,” Dipke posted on X on Friday morning.

In the evening, spokespersons for the group Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka issued a list of Do’s and Don’ts to potential participants in the protest “to ensure the movement remains peaceful, disciplined, and respectful of public order”.

They asked participants to carry the Tricolour and a book, record the proceedings of the protest, and report miscreants to the police. They were told to offer flowers to police personnel, and to not engage with “trolls or provocateurs”.

“Tomorrow, we reset the education system of this country...make sure that our voices can’t be ignored anymore...we reclaim this democracy and this beautiful nation of ours,” Ranka said.

Das invited people “of all political shades” to join the BJP protest. “We appeal to you all to please keep this peaceful. Please do not gather at the airport...Please meet us directly at the Parliament Street police station,” he said.

Ranka issued “a last appeal” to Prime Minister Narendra Modi asking him to remove Education Minister Pradhan. “Your education minister is incompetent, because of him our education system has been destroyed... We want to appeal to you directly: Modi ji, please sack Dharmendra Pradhan ji and restore our faith in democracy,” he said.

The Minister has been under fire for a series of recent controversies, including the leak of the NEET-UG question paper and the chaos and confusion over the OSM system used in CBSE’s Class 12 exam.

The Intelligence Unit of the Delhi Police expects some people from outside Delhi to participate in the protest. According to sources, police believe there could be student groups from Punjab, members of various student organisations, and leaders and workers of political parties among the protesters. “Information has been received that AAP workers are mobilising support on the ground, while student groups are encouraging participation,” a source said.

According to this source, “The expected participants in the protest could include students, competitive exam aspirants, teachers, coaching centre affiliates and issue-based groups. Labour-linked organisations could also be present.”

Meanwhile on Friday, the Delhi HC refused an urgent hearing to a petition filed by the Delhi-based trust Save India Foundation which sought restrictions on the gathering by the BJP. The petition, which was filed Thursday, drew parallels between the actions of the BJP with “civil unrest and regime changes... in Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and Nepal”.

Penguin

clashes that left over 60 dead and 40,000 displaced.

Readers in India hoping to find it at their local bookstore will be disappointed: Penguin Random House India has pulled the plug on distributing the title, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The book, published last year, was expected to hit Indian shelves by August-September. But, Gaurav Shrinagesh, CEO of Penguin Random House (PRH) India, confirmed that the title was red-flagged during a pre-check and legal scrutiny process. “We had highlighted certain things on the Joe Sacco title but they (Penguin UK) did not get back to us,” he said. “One problem was a map in the book showing inaccurate boundaries of India. Besides that, we had raised some content questions and asked for citations which never came.”

The publisher added, “We are very clear about this: if we know there is an inaccurate map and no changes are forthcoming, we will not do it. We have decided there will be no distribution of the book due to these red flags not being attended to.”

How many content queries

were raised beyond the map issue remains unclear.

The book is available in India on some online platforms which source copies from UK-based wholesalers – a parallel distribution channel that PRH India has no control over. Some South Delhi bookstores, tired of waiting, have imported copies directly from the UK.

Sacco, who dedicated the book to India’s “hardworking rural journalists” – several assisted him as translators and researchers and also feature in its pages – visited Muzaffarnagar a year after the riots. In a recent interview for Prism magazine, he reflected on what drew him to the story. “It’s a question of looking at the lies and presenting them as lies,” he said. “‘Shesaid, he said’ is not journalism. That’s just quoting people. In this case, it was possible to make an effort to find out what actually happened.”

In the book’s final chapter, “The Future Riot,” Sacco dwells on the politics behind the riots. The 2013 Muzaffarnagar riots occurred just months before the 2014 general elections. “Communal violence, planned or not, can confer some electoral advantage,” he writes, “and bloodshed, properly framed, is nothing but a political building block”.

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‘VARSITY’S INTERVENTION CONTRARY TO PRECEDENTS GOVERNING MINORITY INSTITUTIONS’

St Stephen’s asks DU to withdraw objection to principal’s appointment

Vidheesha Kuntamalla
New Delhi, June 5

ST STEPHEN’S College has formally asked the Delhi University to withdraw a communication last month in which the university had objected to the appointment of the college’s principal, Professor Susan Elias, arguing that the university’s intervention is contrary to legal precedents governing minority educational institutions, official university sources told *The Indian Express*.

It is learnt that the college communicated to DU Registrar Vikas Gupta on Tuesday, requesting that the university withdraw its communication dated May 14, stating that St

Stephens’, a constitutionally protected minority institution, is entitled to determine the procedure for selecting its principal.

The latest exchange marks an escalation in a dispute that has reopened long-standing tensions between the college and the university over the extent of autonomy enjoyed by minority institutions.

It is learnt that Elias had been selected by the college’s Supreme Council pursuant to an advertisement issued on February 25, offered the appointment on April 6 that she accepted the same day and formally took charge as the principal on June 1 after being relieved from her previous position as Pro Vice-Chancel-



Susan Elias

lor (Research) at Chandigarh University.

The college said she fulfils the eligibility requirements prescribed by both the UGC and DU for the post.

Last month, DU had asked St Stephen’s College to not proceed with Elias’s appointment

on the grounds that the selection committee that chose her was allegedly constituted in violation of UGC norms. DU officials had argued that the committee did not include the Vice-Chancellor’s nominee and the subject experts required under the UGC Regulations, 2018.

In its response, it is learnt, the college said that those regulations do not apply to minority educational institutions. Citing a series of court rulings, including judgments of the Delhi High Court and Supreme Court, the college said minority institutions have the right to choose the modality for appointing the head of the institution and that external participation in

the selection process cannot be imposed upon them. The college noted that previous principals, including Valsan Thampu and Professor John Varghese, had been appointed through the same procedure without any objection from DU. The only dispute involving Varghese was related to his continuation beyond the initial five-year term.

The college told DU that a March 2025 judgment of the Madras HC held that the UGC Regulations, 2018, governing the selection of principals are not applicable to minority educational institutions.

DU Registrar Gupta told *The Indian Express* that he was out of office and was unaware of the development.

CBSE alleges cyber attacks on post-result services portal, FIR filed

Alok Singh
New Delhi, June 5

THE CENTRAL Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) has lodged a complaint with the Delhi Police following a series of coordinated cyber attacks on its Post-Result Services Portal.

Despite the attacks, the Board emphasised that its systems and databases remained secure. “No data breach or unauthorised access has been detected,” it said, assuring students and parents that all information remains protected.

The complaint was filed with the Intelligence Fusion & Strategic Operations (IFSO), the Cyber Unit of Delhi Police; an official said a dedicated team from the IFSO has been formed to probe the matter.

“On the basis of the complaint filed by CBSE regarding a series of coordinated cyber attacks on its portal, a case under Section 66 read with Sec 43(f) of the IT Act has been registered and investigation taken up,” a Delhi Police officer said.

According to CBSE’s complaint, the portal, which was launched on June 2 to facilitate post-result services such as verification and re-evaluation of Class XII answer scripts, came under repeated cyber attacks over the past three days.

The attacks reportedly involved massive volumes of malicious internet traffic originating from multiple IP addresses both within India and abroad.

Officials said the attackers appeared to be attempting to disrupt the portal’s functioning, deny access to genuine users, and extract information without authorisation.

As the platform serves lakhs of students across the country, any disruption could have caused significant inconvenience and dissatisfaction among students and other stakeholders, the complaint read.

Taking note of the scale

and coordinated nature of the attacks, CBSE approached the Delhi Police’s specialised cyber unit seeking a detailed investigation and legal action against those responsible.

The Board credited continuous 24x7 monitoring and rapid response measures for successfully mitigating the attacks.

Cybersecurity experts from IIT Kanpur, IIT Madras, Digital India Corporation, the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), CERT-In, and other Central Government agencies assisted in safeguarding the portal.

The CBSE reiterated its commitment to ensuring uninterrupted access to post-result services and maintaining the security of its digital infrastructure.

On Friday, *The Indian Express* reported that CBSE was forced to delay opening its Post-Result Activities (PRA) portal after an IIT-led review found major cybersecurity vulnerabilities in the Board’s digital systems, senior officials associated with the exercise had told this newspaper.

The PRA portal, the CBSE’s official online platform to help students navigate post-examination procedures, was expected to go live on June 1, but it was not launched until the early hours of June 2.

The delay set off fresh questions about the CBSE’s handling of this year’s Class 12 examination, already facing flak over the On-Screen Marking (OSM) system.

The portal is now active. However, it is learned that the re-evaluation exercise – the process that is supposed to kick in after a student who suspects errors in the marking of their paper registers a challenge on the portal – is yet to begin.

Sources said the Board has decided not to use the Coempt Edu Teck platform, which powered the OSM system used during evaluation of the Class 12 papers, for the re-evaluation.

• Skywatch



Forecast: June 6, 2026

Partly cloudy sky. Light rain, thunderstorm, lightning.

MAX: 35-37
3°C below normal

MIN: 24-26
1.6°C below normal

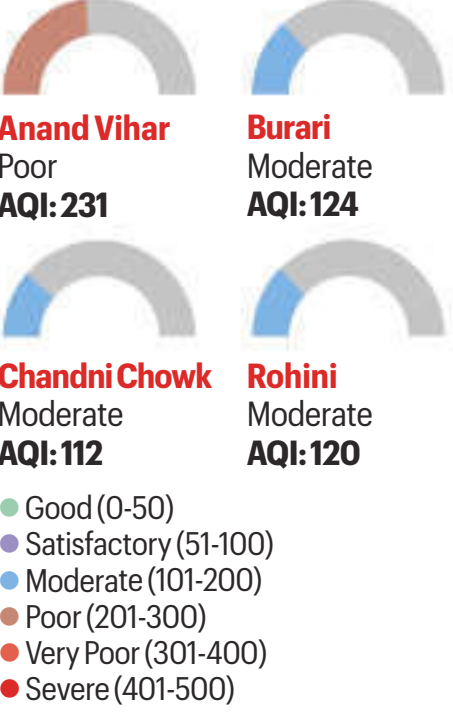
• Sunrise: 5:23 AM (June 7)

• Sunset: 7:17 PM (June 6)

• Moonrise: 11:47 PM (June 6)

• Moonset: 11:13 AM (June 7)

• AQI Tracker



Delhi Police celebrates World Environment Day

New Delhi: Delhi Police on Friday celebrated the World Environment Day by organising a mega tree plantation drive across all districts and units, highlighting its commitment to environmental sustainability and a greener future.

Police Commissioner Satish Golchha led the initiative by planting a sapling at the Delhi Police Headquarters. Senior officers, including Special Commissioners and Deputy Commissioners of Police joined the drive. Similar plantation activities were conducted across the Capital that saw enthusiastic participation of officers. The aim was to promote greenery and create awareness among people about the importance of environmental conservation and sustainable living. **ENS**

Deploy armed female cops on buses: LG to DTC

New Delhi: Delhi LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu has directed the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) to deploy armed female police personnel on its buses to ensure safety of passengers, particularly women and children, officials said Friday.

According to officials, the decision was taken during a high-level review meeting. LG Sandhu emphasised that public transport, apart from being accessible, must ensure safe travel for women, said officials.

Officials said that after reviewing the Pink Card initiative and status of CCTV camera deployment in Delhi, the LG said safety of women should not only be ensured in public transport, but also till their doorstep once they have deboarded at the stations, depots or bus stands. For this, he asked officials to also onboard operators of cabs, three-wheelers and e-rickshaws. **ENS**

2 masked suspects caught on CCTV entering DU prof’s society a day after her body found

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, June 5

TWO MASKED individuals, including a woman, were captured on CCTV cameras entering the apartment complex in East Delhi’s Vasundhara Enclave where Delhi University assistant professor Devosmita Paul was found murdered on Thursday, police sources said Friday.

According to sources, the man was seen walking ahead of the woman several times, making it difficult for investigators to ascertain if they worked together as a team.

CCTV footage obtained from cameras installed at the entrance of Satyam Apartment show the masked individuals entering the complex on Wednesday afternoon. Police said the suspects remained inside the residential complex for approximately 40-45 minutes,

after which they were spotted leaving.

The development comes a day after Devosmita, an assistant professor at Shivaji College, was found dead inside her flat. According to the police, preliminary investigations had indicated that she was attacked with a blunt object that caused fatal injuries on the head.

According to the post-mortem examination report, Devosmita was killed between 3 pm and 6 pm on Wednesday. Investigators are now attempting to reconstruct her movements and identify people who might have visited her residence during the said period.

The call detail records of the deceased, police sources said, showed that the last person she spoke to was her mother, around 12:30 pm on Wednesday. Family members told investigators that she appeared

normal during the conversation and did not express any concern.

Officers are examining footage of CCTV cameras installed on nearby roads and in adjoining residential societies to trace the movement of the masked suspects before and after they entered the deceased’s apartment complex. Technical surveillance teams have also been tasked with analysing details of mobile phones active in the vicinity during the suspected time of the murder, police said.

Devosmita lived in her flat alone. Her husband resides in Bengaluru. On Thursday afternoon, police received a PCR call from her sister, Devarati Paul, who alerted authorities after discovering the body inside the apartment.

Devarati told police that her sister’s flat was locked from the outside. Suspecting something

might be wrong, Devarati broke the lock and entered the apartment, after which she discovered her sister’s body, police said.

During the initial inspection, police did not find any sign of theft or ransacking in either of the rooms of the flat. No valuables have been reported missing so far, they said, adding that it was unlikely that robbery was the motive behind the crime.

Police have registered a case under BSN Section 103(1), which pertains to murder. Officers said they are probing the case from all angles.

Sources familiar with the probe said Devosmita was known to maintain a private lifestyle and interacted with only a limited number of people, a factor that police believe could prove significant in narrowing down potential leads.

2020 DELHI RIOTS LARGER CONSPIRACY CASE

HC allows Kalita to see papers not relied upon by cops, but not CCTV clip & WhatsApp chats

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, June 5

THE DELHI High Court on Friday vacated its stay that had restrained the trial court from passing a final order on framing of charges against the accused in the 2020 Northeast Delhi riots ‘larger’ conspiracy case. This came after the court dismissed a plea filed by activist and riots accused Devangana Kalita seeking police chat records and video footage of the violence.

While the HC allowed Kalita to inspect the malkhana (where material/evidence seized during investigation is kept/stored) for material not relied upon by the prosecution — even as the prosecution opposed the request citing the terror law, UAPA, under which the accused have been charged — it dismissed her request to be provided with CCTV footage and WhatsApp chat records from police officers’ groups.

Justice Neena Bansal



Devangana Kalita

Krishna observed that the principles of fair trial and transparent judicial proceedings “cannot be compartmentalised into terror offences and the regular criminal offences”.

“It is not the nature of trial but the rights of the accused, who is facing a trial, which is the focal point in any criminal trial. The Constitution grants equal protection to every kind of accused and such artificial distinction would not only be contrary to the criminal jurisprudence but would also shake

the foundations of right to life and liberty, which are the core values of the constitution of India. This argument, therefore, is not tenable,” the court held.

The trial court has completed hearing arguments on framing of charges, and the prosecution is expected to rebut on specific aspects of framing of charges.

On Thursday, the prosecution, referring to the stay, had requested before Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya to transfer the case away from Justice Krishna since she had not pronounced the final order in Kalita’s plea seeking video footage and police chats, despite reserving the case for orders in January.

In September 2024, while allowing the trial court dealing with the case to continue hearing the arguments on charge, Justice Krishna had, however, restrained it from passing any final order to that effect.

She reasoned on Friday that the WhatsApp chats of the po-

lice officers were not relied upon by the prosecution and an accused is entitled access only to the relied upon documents and, at best, a list of un-relied upon documents, but not copies of the un-relied upon documents.

The court recorded that Kalita had already been provided with all the material relied upon by the prosecution, and refused to interfere with the trial court’s August 2023 order.

Justice Krishna on Friday also disposed of another petition by Kalita where she was seeking inspection of documents not relied upon by the prosecution in the chargesheet but was used during the police probe.

“...in order to ensure fairness of procedure and to allay any perceived prejudice, it is well settled that the accused is not only entitled to list of un-relied documents, but also to the inspection, to be able to address arguments on Charge effectively,” she held.

Lodhi Crematorium wall collapse: As a labourer dies, a family loses its home

Mishal Mussaddique
New Delhi, June 5

HOURS AFTER a boundary wall and an adjoining storage room collapsed during rain-water drain and sewage line construction work at Lodhi Crematorium in Lodhi Colony, killing one labourer, Rahul Kharwan was seen searching through the rubble for his family’s belongings. A worker at the ritual supplies and memorial keepsakes shop at the crematorium, he lived in a one-room home – now completely damaged – inside the complex with his wife and children.

Early morning, a 55-year-old labourer was killed and two others injured after the boundary wall and the storage room collapsed at 1.08 am when excavation and pipe-laying work



At the site of the collapse in Lodhi Colony on Friday. AMIT MEHRA

was being carried out by the PWD using a JCB and a Hydra machine, DCP (Southeast) Hemant Tiwari said.

Three PWD labourers got trapped under the debris, said DCP II Jasbir Singh.

Among them, while a person identified as Devendra was declared dead at AIIMS Trauma Centre, other labourers – Rajesh (48) and Umar (20) – are under treatment, said police.

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TOLL IN SOUTH DELHI B&B FIRE NOW 22: GOVT INVOKES DISASTER MANAGEMENT ACT TO DEAL WITH NEGLIGENCE, CORRUPTION

Govt cracks the whip: Recoveries to be made from officials

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 5

TO HOLD officials accountable or responsible for allowing illegal constructions and fire safety violations, the Delhi government on Friday decided to invoke the Disaster Management Act (DMA), 2005, under which officials found guilty of negligence or corruption could face jail term up to two years and will also have to compensate the government for the loss suffered by their actions from their salary, pension and even properties.

Home Minister Ashish Sood said the decision was taken at a high-level meeting chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, two days after 22 people died in a fire at Flourish Stays B&B in South Delhi's Malviya Nagar. Officials from the government, MCD, Delhi Police, Fire department and other agencies attended the meeting.

Action will be taken against officials whose negligence or

collusion allows illegal constructions, fire safety violations, or other hazardous activities to flourish, Sood said, adding that officials have been warned that provisions of the Prevention of Corruption Act may also be invoked wherever necessary.

"The DMA Act carries a punishment of up to two years' imprisonment along with substantial fines," he said, adding that the government has also decided to recover losses from officials found guilty.

Sood said the CM has specifically said that compensation for government losses would no longer remain limited to paperwork. "There would be no scope for anyone to evade responsibility."

He added that under the Revenue Recovery Act, 1890, losses suffered by the government can be recovered from the salaries, pensions and properties of its officials. Authorities may also freeze and attach the bank accounts and assets of



Debris being cleared at the site of the gutted B&B facility in Hauz Rani, South Delhi, on Friday. AMIT MEHRA

builders, owners and colonisers found responsible for violations.

"Moreover, accountability would not be limited to subordinate staff... senior officers

would also be held responsible, if found violating rules....," Sood said.

KEY DECISIONS AFTER B&B BLAZE

- Third-party insurance mechanism to be developed for buildings, guest houses, nursing homes and other public-use premises with high daily footfall. Insurance companies would provide coverage only when structural safety is ensured.
- Digital system to be developed to track the Fire department's response time -- from receipt of a distress call to the arrival of firefighters at the site.
- GSDI, department to update records of construction activity every three months using drone surveys, satellite imagery and digital mapping.
- System will be developed to automatically alert authorities whenever new construction is detected and maintain a record of action taken.
- Online portal to be launched

- where people can report unauthorised construction and file complaints against officials responsible for oversight.
- Divisional commissioners to set up dedicated drone cells to monitor illegal construction.
- Authorities to focus on buildings taller than 17.5 m. Where permission-related violations are found, upper floors may be vacated and sealing or closure action initiated.
- Fixed-glass windows to be banned.
- No fresh water and electricity connections as well as no-objection certificates for buildings without valid completion certificates.
- Officials to submit lists of ongoing illegal constructions, along with photographs and details of the officers responsible for monitoring those areas.

The CM has said that officials will face adverse remarks

in their Annual Performance Appraisal Reports (APARs),

which could affect promotions and future postings, he added.

To improve enforcement, the government has decided to strengthen the powers of district magistrates (DMs). "DMs will soon have extensive authority to fix accountability of officials working in any department within their administrative districts, initiate disciplinary action directly, order registration of FIRs, approve or cancel leave, and take immediate action against officers who fail to perform their duties," said Sood.

He added that to address concern over frequent transfers in building departments, junior engineers, assistant engineers and other field officials will be held responsible for construction activities and permissions issued during their tenure, even after being transferred. "A transfer from one area to another will not absolve any official of responsibilities arising from past assignments," said the minister.

28 deaths in one week, illegal structures under MCD scanner

26 structures in South Zone, comprising Saidulajab and Hauz Rani, either sealed or demolished

Drishiti Jain & Pragynesh
New Delhi, June 5

AS PART of a drive against illegal and unauthorised structures across Delhi's 12 zones, which began on June 1, Friday saw at least 26 structures in South Zone being either sealed or demolished, officials said.

The action follows two major incidents in the South Zone in the past week: a building collapse at Saidulajab near Saket Metro station last Saturday that claimed six lives, and a fire at Flourish Stay B&B in Hauz Rani, Malviya Nagar, which killed 22 people.

Officials said that 82 properties have been demolished and 43 sealed as part of the citywide drive since June 1

Around 150 notices related to unauthorised constructions, sealing and demolitions have been issued to properties, they added.

These 150 include demolition action taken against 12 properties in the South Zone on



While demolition work was carried out in front of several shops and establishments in Hauz Rani on Friday, the MCD sealed a hotel in the area. AMIT MEHRA & VIVEK PRAKASH KRISHNA

Friday. Further, 14 properties in the zone were sealed.

While the 26 properties included the sealing and demolition of eight properties in Saidulajab, the MCD has also identified 32 properties in Saidulajab and 9 in Khirki Extension operating in violation of norms, officials said.

Additionally, since June 1, while demolition action has been carried out against seven properties in Civil Lines Zone, eight illegal properties have

been demolished in Narela Zone. Officials added that while in Savitri Nagar, Sainik Farm and Khanpur, action was taken against three properties, three basements were sealed for running the library in violation of law in Gautam Nagar.

The MCD had confirmed the four-storey building that had collapsed at Saidulajab was illegal while the B&B that caught fire in Malviya Nagar lacked several permissions, including NOC from the Fire de-

partment.

"The action was taken against properties in Saidulajab near the collapsed building, which were also identified during last week's survey; structures in Sultanpur opposite the Metro depot; and housing facilities in Hauz Rani. Inspections are also being carried out in Gautam Nagar, where notices and orders are being issued," an official said.

According to MCD, it has identified over 12 B&Bs and



guest houses operating in violation of building bye-laws in Hauz Rani, and has sealed five since June 1. The drive on Friday targeted underground restaurants and kitchens in the area, which were running in buildings having multiple floors.

These guest houses included two more properties owned by Luvkesh Bajaj – the owner of Flourish Stay B&B – along with Venue Inn, Sky inn, Mikasa inn and Crown Moon

Inn, among others. The two properties of Bajaj, said a police officer, had 15 to 18 rooms, violating the permitted limit of six, similar to Flourish Stay B&B that was operating 26 rooms.

"Just like in the case of Bajaj, most of these properties receive licenses on the name of managers instead of the owner, to bypass liability. This especially started to happen after the Up-haar Cinema tragedy," said a police officer involved in the drive.

Fire claimed over 500 lives in Delhi in 5 years: Govt data

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, June 5

BETWEEN 2019 and 2026, a total of 543 people have lost their lives in incidents of fire in the city — with over 65 deaths recorded over the past six months alone, according to data provided by the Delhi government.

The data shows that fire claimed a total 84 lives in FY 2025-26, 90 in 2024-25 and 77 in 2023-24. Such deaths were slightly less during the Covid-19 pandemic, though only during phase 1 and 2.

While 41 such deaths were reported in 2020-21, 2021-22 saw 55. However, the numbers rose again in 2022-23, when 95 people died in fire tragedies.

● The deaths: 65 so far this financial year

YEAR	DEATHS	INJURED	FIRE-RELATED CALLS
2019-20	100	843	17,231
2020-21	41	421	15,158
2021-22	55	392	14,268
2022-23	95	749	17,043
2023-24	77	709	15,832
2024-25	90	704	21,668
2025-26	84	585	20,379

At 100, the highest number of deaths due to fire was seen in 2019-20. The Anaj Mandi fire, one of major fire incidents Delhi saw since the 1997 Up-haar fire tragedy, happened in 2019 that claimed 44 lives.

A total of 4,403 people also

sustained injuries in such incidents between 2019 and 2025, according to the data.

The data also shows that the number of emergency calls received by the Delhi Fire Services regarding fire-related incidents has risen over the

years from 17,231 in 2019-20 to 20,379 in the last financial year. As per the data, at 20,379, the highest number of such calls were received in 2024.

Talking about the rise in the number of fire-related calls and deaths, Delhi Home Minister Ashish Sood said: "There is a change of pattern in the urban fire risk. The uptick in fire calls and deaths also highlights that one of the reasons for this is the changing lifestyle of residents in the Capital... Earlier, people had coolers or there was just one air-conditioner per house. Now, households have multiple ACs."

Sood added that even construction practices have changed, with residents going for wooden interiors, inflammable chemicals, plastic and oil

paintings, wallpapers, false ceilings and lighting, which are prone to fire.

Officials said that, "oil and solvent-based paints, including enamel, lacquer and duco, pose a higher fire risk compared to conventional water-based paints due to the presence of combustible solvents".

"New ACs have highly inflammable chemicals that are more prone to fire hazard," an official said.

Another senior official said that one of the most significant reasons behind residential and commercial fires in urban areas continues to be widespread non-compliance with building by-laws and planning norms — particularly in unauthorised colonies.

Towels, running shower & 'how to' video helped Nigerian couple escape

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, June 5

A 'HOW to survive a fire' video and quick thinking helped a Nigerian couple survive the massive fire at the bed-and-breakfast in Delhi's Hauz Rani that claimed 22 lives. The couple, a police officer said, turned on the shower in the bathroom, spread towels on the floor and lay low till help reached them.

Following the tragedy, police spoke to the survivors to record their statements. For foreign nationals, translators were roped in. A senior police officer said a couple told them that they had read about a fire drill and also watched a video

on how to survive a fire.

"They had learnt that during a fire, smoke rises and accumulates in the upper part of a room, and that one should turn on the shower or any water outlet and lie low. The couple spread towels on the bathroom floor and lay under the running shower," the officer added.

According to the officer, these steps protected the couple from the thick smoke, which appears to have caused most of the deaths in the fire.

During the initial investigation, police have found that many of the victims died not of burns but of suffocation. Officials said the building lacked adequate ventilation and ad-

equated exits for an emergency.

The families of several foreign nationals who died or were injured are in Iraq, Bangladesh and several African countries, Liberia, Nigeria and Mozambique. Police said the respective embassies have been informed, and they are coordinating with officials for further procedures.

Most of them were medical tourists who had come to India for treatment, or were accompanying patients. "We have decided to conduct a DNA examination of all the bodies," the officer said.

Preliminary findings indicate that the fire may have been caused by a short circuit, according to officers.



Md Robiul at AIIMS mortuary on Friday. AMIT MEHRA

Pragynesh
New Delhi, June 5

FORTY-FOUR-YEAR-OLD MD Nurul Amin did not need to visit India. But on June 2, the transport businessman chose to board a flight from Dhaka to Delhi to accompany his younger sister Rahana Akhtar (38) and her husband Mosharaf Hossain (44), who was in need of a kidney transplant.

Also tagging along was Hossain's sister Zohra, the donor, and her daughter.

"They landed in Delhi on June 2 evening and stayed the night at the Delhi airport. The next day, they went to a cafe," Md Robiul (33), Amin's brother-in-law, told *The Indian Express*. The cafe was located on the first floor of Flourish Stays B&B in South Delhi's Malviya Nagar, near Max Hospital Saket, where Hossain was set to undergo the transplant. As Amin and the family ate, just before they planned to visit the hospital, a fire broke out in the building.

Amin was among the 22 people who died in the fire, while Hossain, Rahana, Zohra and her daughter sustained injuries. Two days later, Robiul stood at the AIIMS mortuary, waiting for the completion of post-mortem formalities.

"He didn't have to come. He only came because he wanted

to help his sister take care of Hossain during the treatment. The last time I spoke to him was last month when he was planning to come here," Robiul.

"People from the Embassy told me that they were eating at the restaurant when the fire broke out. I think because they were on the first floor, at least the others managed to get out in time. Amin couldn't," he added.

Back in Dhaka, Amin leaves behind his wife and three children. None of them could travel to India because only Robiul had a valid visa.

"When the embassy contacted us, I was asked to come because I had travelled to India before. I came with my parents," he said.

As he waited outside the mortuary, Robiul scrolled through his phone to show the only photograph he has of Amin – fair, clean shaved and sharp cheekbones, with thick black hair swept on the side.

● UNLIKE UBER AND RAPIDO, GREEN SM OWNS THE CARS OPERATING ON ITS PLATFORM

Vietnam's EV cab service debuts in Delhi-NCR, begins with 1,000 vehicles

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, June 5

COMMUTERS IN Delhi-NCR now have another electric cab option.

Vietnam-based mobility company Green SM on Thursday launched its electric taxi service, Green SM Limo, in the region, marking its entry into India — its latest international market after Laos, Indonesia and the Philippines.

The company said it is beginning operations in key areas of the National Capital Region

and plans to expand its coverage in phases, depending on demand. It plans to deploy a fleet of around 10,000 electric vehicles (EVs) in the country, seeking to fill the premium electric mobility space left behind by Blusmart after its shutdown last year.

A fleet of 1,000 electric taxis were flagged off at the event by Delhi Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa and Transport Minister Pankaj Singh. Haryana Environment Minister Rao Narbir Singh also attended the event.

Unlike Uber and Rapido, Green SM owns the cars operating on its platform. According to the company, the service will use the VinFast Limo Green, a seven-seater electric sport utility vehicle developed for passenger transportation. "There is a premium market of around 7-10%, which we want to tap. Once we see the results, we will think about the next category of vehicles," said Manoj Ravikanti, Chief Operating Officer of Green SM India, on why the company has launched its services directly with a SUV.



Green SM plans to expand its coverage in phases. GAJENDRA YADAV

The vehicles have been equipped with cameras, emergency support buttons and an in-car monitoring system. The company said passengers will be able to book rides through its mobile application, a hotline or by hailing vehicles directly in operating areas.

On why the company chose NCR to its launch operations, Ravikanti said, "Delhi represents India with all of its diversity. We want to test our model and stabilise our operations here, after which we will look at other markets in India."

The company said its drivers have undergone training in electric vehicle operations, road safety and customer service. It added that the service would focus initially on daily commuting, airport transfers and business travel.

It further said that drivers from various other ride hailing companies are enrolling themselves as GSM drivers, as the company was offering them a minimum payout of Rs 35,000 a month for two months, following which payouts will be based on performance and incentives.

Company officials said while successors to Blusmart like Refex Mobility and Trevel have focused on employee transportation, around 80% of GSM's services will cater to the D2C (Direct-to-Consumer) segment.

"India is one of the most important mobility markets in the world. Its scale, rapid growth, and strong spirit of innovation are opening up many opportunities for the future of green transportation," GSM Global Chief Executive Officer, Nguyen Van Thanh, said at the launch.

PM: Cong spread chaos, its parasitic politics won't work

Kamal Saiyed
Surat, June 5

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi on Friday accused the Congress of “spreading chaos and uncertainty” and said that people were dissatisfied in the party-ruled states as he referred to the change of guard in Karnataka.

Modi was addressing a public meeting in Surat after inaugurating and laying the foundation of projects worth over Rs 18,000 crore in Gujarat.

“For the past 12 years, the Congress has been sowing chaos and uncertainty and looking for opportunities for itself, but the people of the country are giving it a befitting reply,” he said.

PM Modi said, “Everyone was talking about West Bengal, and the recent Assembly election results there gives enthusiasm and energy to the people. In the elections in West Bengal, Assam and Puducherry, the BJP and the NDA have got a huge mandate. Apart from this, in the local body elections such as panchayats and corporations, held across the country, the BJP is winning. The country does not like chaos, uncertainty and disappointment. In Gujarat, the people have pushed the Congress into a funny situation. Apart from this, in states where



PM Narendra Modi at L&T's Hazira plant in Surat on Friday. ANI

the Congress is in power, the people are fed up with that party. Recently, in the local body elections in Himachal Pradesh and Haryana, the Congress lost badly. The people of Punjab too have given a clear message to Congress. The message is that Congress's parasitic politics will not work. The Congress's politics of seeking opportunities in chaos will not work. There is widespread anger among the people of Karnataka against the Congress government there. This is why the Congress resorted to the process of changing the CM in Karnataka.”

Speaking in the backdrop of the West Asia conflict, which has disrupted the global supply chains, Modi noted the ongoing global crisis shows just how crucial energy self-reliance is and

highlighted India's capacity building since 2014.

“On one hand, we secured oil and gas supplies from various parts of the world and on the other, we ramped up investment in renewable energy to historic levels,” he said.

“Presently, the world is going through a period of unprecedented challenges. We have seen in the past global disasters such as the coronavirus pandemic, international wars and, presently, a huge energy crisis that has kept the whole world busy. The price of petrol is constantly fluctuating worldwide. The gas supply chain is being badly affected. With the sincere efforts of 140 crore Indians, the country is facing every crisis with strength, and we have to win this battle too.”

Reform, perform, transform will go on: PM hails 7.7% GDP growth

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, June 5

REFERRING TO India's estimated GDP growth for the 2025-26 fiscal at 7.7% as “good news”, PM Narendra Modi on Friday said the country had been able to stay ahead of others at a time of global economic crisis.

Addressing a public meeting in Daman near Gujarat, the PM said India would continue to move on the path of “reform, perform and transform” at a fast pace. Modi said, “Today, a good news has come... The figures that have come today make it clear how strong the foundation of India's economy is.”

“In the financial year 2025-26, India has achieved a growth rate of 7.7%. In the quarter that ended March 31, India's growth was 7.8%. And [India] is a big economy, which is progressing fast,” Modi said. “The world is surrounded by a crisis... With the collective efforts of 140 crore citizens, India is not only managing itself, but also succeeding in staying ahead of all.”

HC dismisses appeal against ED probe by firm linked to Pinarayi daughter

Deeptiman Tiwary & Shaju Philip
New Delhi, Thiruvananthapuram, June 5

IN A ruling that could have significant implications for money laundering investigations across the country, the Kerala HC has held that the existence of a predicate or scheduled offence is not a prerequisite for the Enforcement Directorate (ED) to initiate inquiries under the PMLA.

A Division Bench of the HC, while dismissing appeals challenging the ED's proceedings in the Cochin Minerals and Rutile Limited (CMRL)-Exalogic transactions case involving former Kerala CM Pinarayi Vijayan's daughter Veena Vijayan, drew a distinction between the agency's power to conduct inquiries and its power to prosecute for money laundering.

“The civil action of attachment may be initiated on the basis of material suggesting the

existence of proceeds of crime, even without a registered scheduled offence. The penal action of prosecution, on the other hand, requires the registration of a scheduled offence as a foundational prerequisite,” said the bench comprising Justices Raja Vijayaraghavan and K V Jayakumar.

The judgment comes amid a political and legal debate over ED's powers under the PMLA and allegations by the Opposition that the agency frequently embarks on “roving and fishing inquiries” without a clearly established criminal offence.

The challenge before the HC arose from an ECIR registered by the ED in connection with payments made by CMRL to Exalogic Solutions, a company owned by Veena Vijayan. The ED had issued summons under Section 50 of the PMLA. Last week, the ED raided Vijayan's premises as part of its probe. The raid was held a day after a

single bench of the High Court rejected CMRL's plea to quash all proceedings against it.

The petitioners argued that when the ECIR was registered and summons were issued, no FIR or complaint existed in respect of any scheduled offence. Since the PMLA is predicated on the existence of a scheduled offence, they contended that the ECIR and subsequent proceedings were without jurisdiction and liable to be quashed.

Rejecting the argument, the court held that the PMLA contemplates a distinction between inquiry, investigation and prosecution.

“It is not as if after every inquiry, prosecution is launched against all persons found to be involved in the commission of the offence of money laundering,” the court observed.

The Bench held that inquiry is the “foundational process” under the statute. When the ED receives information suggest-

ing the existence of proceeds of crime, it can begin gathering evidence, issue summons, record statements and seek documents to determine whether property qualifies as “proceeds of crime”, the court observed.

“The existence of a prior registered scheduled offence is not a jurisdictional prerequisite” for the exercise of powers under Section 50, the court said.

The ruling is significant because it effectively endorses the ED's ability to open a money laundering inquiry before a predicate offence has been formally registered by another agency. The court relied heavily on Supreme Court's judgment in Vijay Madanlal Choudhary, which upheld several provisions of the PMLA and recognised a distinction between the Act's civil and criminal components.

The Bench held that an ECIR cannot be equated with an FIR under the Code of Criminal Procedure.

US has deported more than 4,600 Indians in last 17 months: MEA

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 5

MORE THAN 4,600 Indians have been deported from the US to India in the last 17 months since the US administration led by President Donald Trump assumed office in January last year.

The figures were disclosed by the Ministry of External Affairs' official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal in response to questions. “A total of 1,076 Indian nationals have been deported from the US to India so far this year. During 2025, a total of 3,567 people were deported from the US,” he said.

The issue of immigration has been a political hot button for the Trump administration. India has made it clear it is the obligation of all countries to take back their nationals, if they are

found to be living illegally abroad. This is however subject to verification of their nationality. “This is not a policy practiced only by India; it is a generally accepted principle in international relations,” the MEA had told Parliament last year.

It had also said that the Government continues to work in close coordination with the US on deportation of individuals who were found to have illegally entered the US, or have overstayed their visas, or have been found living in the US without any documentation. The list of persons identified for deportation by the US side is closely scrutinised and verified by the Indian agencies concerned. Only those persons who have been verified to be Indian nationals are accepted to be deported to India, it had said.

‘Gilgit-Baltistan Assembly’ elections: India lodges strong protest with Pakistan

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 5

INDIA ON Friday lodged a strong protest with Pakistan regarding the latter's plans to hold “general elections” on June 7, 2026, for the “Gilgit-Baltistan Assembly”, in the Indian territories illegally and forcibly occupied by Pakistan..

The MEA said in a statement: “The Government of India reiterated its well-known position that the entire Union Territories of J&K and Ladakh, including the so-called ‘Gilgit-Baltistan’,

are integral and inalienable parts of India as a result of complete, legal and irrevocable accession of J&K to India in 1947.”

“The Government of India further emphasised that such endeavours by Pakistan cannot mask the underlying issues of grave human rights violations, political repression, economic exploitation and denial of freedom in territories illegally occupied by Pakistan,” it said. India “categorically rejects any attempts by Pakistan to bring material change to areas under Pakistan's illegal occupation”, it said.

Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board, Katra
Abridged Tender Notice

Vide No. CO/Pur/NE/661/940 dated 05.06.2026, SMVDSB has issued an e-NIT inviting offers from reputed professional Companies/Firms dealing in the bulk packing/ supply of pasteurized dry fruits for supply of specified “Pouch Prasad” to SMVDSB. The last date for bid submission (online) is 19.06.2026.

All relevant information viz. tender schedule, terms & conditions etc. are available at www.iktenders.gov.in & www.maavaishnodevi.org.
Queries, if any, may be addressed to: res_purchase@maavaishnodevi.net

Sd/-
Asstt. Chief Executive Officer (G)
Dated: 05.06.2026

No. Co/Pur/NE/661/941

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E-Tender Notice
E-tendering mode only on website - www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in
E-Tender Notice No.: 08/2026-2027/Network/IGIMS/Store

IGIMS, Patna invites bid from eligible and qualified manufactures or their authorized distribution / agents for supply, installation and commissioning of Campus Networking System for the department of IT Cell.

The last date & time for submission/ uploading of complete tender document at www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in is 06/07/2026 up to 17:00 hours. Details of specification of equipment's, terms and conditions can be seen and downloaded from Institute Website: www.igims.org & www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in. The undersigned reserves the right to accept / reject any or all tenders without assigning any reason. Prospective bidders are advised to regularly visit www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in and www.igims.org for Corrigendum / amendments etc., if any. It will be notified on these portals only and no separate advertisement will be made.

Director, I.G.I.M.S. - Patna

Ghaziabad Development Authority
VIKAS PATH, GHAZIABAD
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पत्र संख्या : 229 / प्रशा0अनु0/2026 दिनांक : 04/06/2026

REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL

Ghaziabad development authority, Ghaziabad (GDA) intends to appoint a consultancy agency/firm for providing assistance to GDA for architectural and engineering services.

Therefore, GDA Invites experienced and reputed consultancy firms to submit proposal (Technical and Financial) for the selection of expert consultants for proving assistance in architectural & engineering services.

Details of RFP can be viewed from the website through <https://gdaghaziabad.in> and can be downloaded form UP E-Tender portal form date- 08.06.2026

Proposal Submission start date - 08.06.2026
Last date for submitting response - 29.06.2026
Bid opening date - 01.07.2026
Tender fees - 13098.00
Earnest money deposit (EMD) - INR 500000/- (Through RTGS) to be paid using the link <https://gdaghz.procore247.com> Tender Pay/x-login.)

Further enquiry can be made form OSD(administration) mobile no. 8299508165 during office hours (10:00 AM To 5:00 PM).

Chief Engineer
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Future Tense

THE LATEST list of the BJP's Rajya Sabha candidates has set off whispers in the party circles that it follows a "pattern". According to BJP sources, most of the leaders among the 11 RS candidates named by the party were not sure about their candidacy till the list was released. At the same time, two Union Ministers — George Kurian and Ravneet Singh Bittu — were not informed beforehand that they would not get a renomination. Party leaders said Kurian may face a fate similar to one of his predecessors, Mukhtar Abbas Naqvi, who had to resign as MoS Minority Affairs on July 6, 2022, a day before his RS term ended, as the party did not renominate him.

Party Woes

THE GOA Congress is witnessing rumblings of discontent over the appointment of Girish Chodankar as the state unit chief. Lok Sabha member from South Goa Captain Virato Fernandes, who has been appointed the head of the manifesto committee for the state Assembly elections next year, has sought an appointment with the party high command in Delhi. He is learnt to be unhappy with his new responsibility as well as the change of guard in the Goa unit. Fernandes has also sought time to discuss issues related to restructuring in the state unit, but the Congress leadership is yet to respond to his request, said sources.

Order on Paper

AS THE NDA completes 12 years in power, it has, for the first time, decided to engage PSUs to run campaigns on the government's achievements in different sectors. Two meetings have been held so far wherein all the ministries — petroleum, steel, coal, housing, shipping, education — have been asked to rope in big PSUs for a two-week campaign this month. While most enterprises have agreed to take part in the campaign, a couple of them are said to have raised procedural issues, asking their ministries to give it in writing so that they can get clearance from their boards.

WILL SORT IT OUT...DISCIPLINE IS IMPORTANT: KARNATAKA CHIEF MINISTER

Ramalinga quits DKS Cabinet over portfolio, Muniyappa miffed too

Johnson T A
Bengaluru, June 5

THE NEWLY formed Cabinet of Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar faced discontent Friday with Ramalinga Reddy, an eight-time Congress MLA from Bengaluru, resigning as a minister after being denied the Bengaluru development portfolio, which has been given to a younger party MLA Krishna Byre Gowda.

There were speculations since Thursday — a day after the new CM and his 13-member Cabinet were sworn in — that Reddy, 72, was unhappy over his portfolio. On Friday morning, he announced that he had sent his resignation to Shivakumar after being named the Water Resources and Irrigation Minister.

"I am upset (over the portfolio). I cannot work against my conscience and have given my resignation. I will remain in the Congress and will remain an MLA," he announced.

The resignation drama has unfolded on a day when Congress president, Mallikarjun Kharge, and Leader of the Opposition (LoP) in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi are in Bengaluru for the filing of Kharge's nomination for the upcoming Rajya Sabha election.



Ramalinga Reddy (second from left) and K H Muniyappa (second from right) during the oath-taking ceremony in Bengaluru. PTI FILE

Shivakumar said he would "sort it out" and added that "discipline is important". "He (Reddy) is not from a rural area. He has been given the portfolio of irrigation. He feels he should work for the welfare of the urban sector. I will speak to him. He is a great friend and an important leader. I will sort it out. Discipline is important," the CM said.

This is the second time Reddy has been unhappy with his portfolio. He had expressed a similar desire to quit the Cabinet in 2023, soon after the Congress made to power with Siddaramaiah as the CM. Reddy was initially promised the Bengaluru city portfolio but was later given the Transport and Muzrai ministry.

At the time, then Deputy CM

and state Congress chief Shivakumar convinced Reddy that he would be given the Bengaluru portfolio when the former becomes the CM.

"In 2023, when Siddaramaiah became the CM, I did not ask to be made a minister. He called me and told me of my appointment. I was told that I would be given the Bangalore portfolio by Byrathi Suresh (an MLA and close associate of Siddaramaiah). When the portfolios were announced, I was entrusted with the transport ministry," he added.

"Inquired why this had happened. They told me it had been changed for various reasons. Later, I said that I would not like to be in the Cabinet. However, the current CM Shivakumar and

his brother D K Suresh came to my house and said that after two and a half years, when Shivakumar becomes the Chief Minister, the portfolio would be handed over to me," he said.

The Bengaluru development portfolio is considered influential and lucrative owing to the huge funds available for the capital's development. A powerful politician-contractor lobby controls the city's affairs, and several long-term Bengaluru MLAs have entrenched interests in the city's contracts, ranging from garbage disposal to the asphaltting of roads.

When Shivakumar was the minister in charge of Bengaluru development from 2023 to 2026, a Rs 40,000-crore solid waste management contract, spread over 30 years, was finalised. This drew criticism from the Opposition leaders, including the BJP's Union minister Shobha Karandlaje. The politician-contractor nexus in Bengaluru is considered a key factor in the city's poll outcomes. With the newly created Greater Bengaluru Authority set to hold polls for the city councils in the next two years, after a lapse of over five years, city satraps like Reddy are considered key to the Congress's prospects in several areas.

Another veteran Congress

leader, K H Muniyappa, who is a seven-term MP and two-time MLA, has also expressed disgruntlement about being given the Food and Civil Supplies portfolio for a second successive time. "I am not inclined to take up the Food and Civil Supplies portfolio. As a senior leader I should be given the unallocated Social Welfare or Agriculture portfolio," Muniyappa, 78, said.

He has, however, not expressed any intent to stay out of the Shivakumar Cabinet, also participating in government meetings Friday. Muniyappa was asked by the Congress leadership to also consider his daughter Roopakala Shashidhar, 46, for a Cabinet berth but he chose himself to be a part of the Shivakumar ministry.

The Congress dispensation has named Bengaluru MLA and former revenue minister Krishna Byre Gowda, 54, as the new Bengaluru development minister. As an emerging leader, he is considered a "threat" to entrenched Congress players.

"The onus of developing Bengaluru lies not only with the government but also with the people in the city," Byre Gowda said, refusing to be drawn into the controversy over Reddy's demand for the Bengaluru portfolio.

SC orders status quo on deportation of two women declared foreigners by Tribunal

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 5

THE SUPREME Court on Friday stayed the possible deportation of two women who were declared foreigners by the Foreigners Tribunal in Assam.

Issuing notice on appeals by Saleha Khatun and Sarbanu Begum, a bench of Justices Vikram Nath and V Mohana directed that "in the meantime, status quo, as it exists today, shall be maintained" and the petitioners, "if they are in detention, shall not be deported till the next date of listing i.e. 16th July, 2026".

The appellants contended that they were "impoverished, illiterate" and were working as maids. They said they have been languishing in the Goalpara Detention Camp since March 2, 2026, after they were declared foreigners by the Tribunal in Darrang, Mangal-dai.

The appellants said they belong to economically vulnerable backgrounds and have been deprived of their liberty and separated from their family "solely on the basis of

The petitioners shall not be deported till the next date of listing i.e. July 16, the top court said

findings which are ex facie perverse, extremely hypertechnical and arbitrary".

Both claimed that their father's name is reflected in pre-1971 electoral records.

The duo said they had "produced documentary as well as oral evidence to establish" their "linkage with" their projected Indian parents relatable to a period prior to 25.03.1971 and also produced before the Tribunal "documentary evidence including the NRC legacy details of" their "father, voter lists, Gaonburah, and Gaon Panchayat" as their "linkage certificates, family electoral documents and oral testimony of independent witnesses... to establish continuity of residence and lineage".

However, the Tribunal rejected their pleas on trivial grounds.

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, June 5

LEGISLATOR FATHIMA Thahiliya, who became the Indian Union Muslim League's first woman MLA in Kerala after winning the recent Assembly elections from the Perambra constituency, has faced criticism from a Muslim clerics' body for lighting a nilavilakku (traditional oil lamp) at the inauguration of a local restaurant last week.

After a meeting of its Supreme Consultative Council on Thursday, Samastha Kerala Jam'iyyathul Ulama, a clerics' body traditionally known for its pro-IUML stance, said that lighting the traditional oil lamp is a practice of non-Muslims. If a Muslim performs such an act, relying upon the beliefs held by non-Muslims that are contrary to Islamic teachings, doing so could result in that person leaving Islam, the group claimed. However, if the person does not accept or base the act on such beliefs, but performs it merely as a form of imitation of non-Muslims, then that action is considered forbidden and sinful, Samastha said.



Fathima Thahiliya had lit the lamp at the inauguration of a local restaurant last week.

Prominent Samastha leader Abdul Hameed Faizy Ambalakadavu said in a Facebook post on Friday that Islamic laws were clear, precise and explicit. "Islam has strictly prohibited the faithful from following and performing the traditions of other religions," he said.

Fathima Thahiliya has been known as a reformist voice in the IUML, and has fought for greater space for women within the party. In the recent Assembly elections, she defeated

CPI(M) Central Committee member and LDF convener T P Ramakrishnan in his Perambra seat.

Her candidature had been opposed by conservative elements, including a section of Samastha.

Thahiliya was the founding state president of Haritha — the women's wing of the Muslim Students Federation. Established in 2012, Haritha created a platform for women supporters of the IUML on college campuses. Under her leadership, Haritha played a key role in expanding the MSF's influence across campuses.

Thahiliya's political journey took another turn when Haritha leaders raised allegations of sexual harassment against senior MSF figures. When the party leadership allegedly attempted to suppress the issue, she chose to speak out, leading to her removal as MSF national vice-president and the eventual disbanding of Haritha.

As the nilavilakku controversy continued to burn, Fathima said, "I do not want to comment on that issue anymore."

Annamalai launches movement, eyes new party for 2031 polls

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, June 5

K ANNAMALAI, the former Tamil Nadu BJP president who emerged as one of the party's most visible faces in southern India over the past six years, formally announced his departure from the BJP on Friday and unveiled a new political movement that he said would eventually become a political party and contest the 2031 Tamil Nadu Assembly election.

In a lengthy online address that mixed autobiography, political explanation and a roadmap for the future, the 42-year-old former IPS officer revealed that his decision to leave the BJP had been conveyed to the party leadership months ago and described the move as the culmination of a long internal process rather than a sudden break.

"On December 4, 2024, I told the BJP," Annamalai said. "They asked me to complete the election work and then leave."

The announcement marks one of the most significant political departures in Tamil Nadu in recent years and comes amid a rapidly changing political landscape following Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay's rise to power and the weakening of several established political formations.

Annamalai said his new organisation would initially function as a movement before transforming into a political party. "Certainly, in the next Tamil Nadu Assembly election, our party will contest. There is no doubt about that," he said. The movement will function under the banner of We The Leaders, an organisation he said had originally been started in 2020, and will establish an A P J Abdul Kalam Centre for Ethics and Politics in Coimbatore to train future political entrants before they contest elections.

The former BJP leader repeatedly framed the new initiative as an attempt to build what he called "common man politics," distancing himself from personality-driven political culture. "We must come out



The former Tamil Nadu BJP president announced departure from the party on Friday

of this cult politics," he said. "We must promote common man politics."

He also proposed term limits within the future party, arguing that politics should not remain the preserve of a handful of permanent leaders. "Permanent leaders, permanent MLAs, permanent ministers, permanent MPs — we are going to put an end to that," he said.

Much of the speech was devoted to explaining why he joined the BJP in 2020 and why he eventually chose to leave. Annamalai disclosed that actor Rajinikanth had personally called him a day before he joined the BJP and invited him to join his proposed political effort.

"At that time, when the Superstar requested that I should return from Delhi and join his movement," Annamalai said, he ultimately declined because he had already given his word to BJP national general secretary (organisation) B L Santhosh. "I had given a promise. I should not break that promise," he said.

Annamalai said he continued to hold "immense respect and regard" for Rajinikanth and disclosed the episode primarily to end years of speculation about his political entry. Throughout the speech, he avoided personal attacks on BJP leaders and repeatedly praised Prime Minister Narendra Modi while explaining his disagreements with the party. "Prime Minister Modi has my respect. That honour remains," he said. At the same time, he acknowledged long-running differences with the party leadership.

'Will support him': TN BJP vice-president quits

Press Trust of India
Chennai, June 5

BJP STATE vice president Karu Nagaran on Friday said he would quit the party to support former Tamil Nadu unit chief K Annamalai, who has announced plans to launch his own political movement.

"I don't wish to fault any leader... We have decided to support Annamalai, who is an energetic and bold leader," Nagaran told reporters.

Meanwhile, following Annamalai's announcement earlier in the day, Abhilash Gopi-

nath, BJP Yuva Morcha state legal convener, resigned from the party.

"My decision is driven by my conviction to follow the path and vision of K Annamalai, whose leadership, integrity, and commitment to public life inspired me to enter politics and continue to influence my political journey," Gopinath said in his resignation letter.

Over 8.09 lakh people enrolled as volunteers on <https://wetheleader.org/>, launched by Annamalai earlier in the day, to connect with supporters for his political journey.

Why Congress bets big on Shivakumar as Siddaramaiah remains in the game



THE NEERJA CHOWDHURY COLUMN

WEEKLY INSIGHT INTO WHAT'S CHANGING IN NATIONAL POLITICS — AND WHY

WHAT WORKED for D K Shivakumar, popularly known as DKS, who took oath as the new Chief Minister of Karnataka Wednesday, seemed to be a calculation made by the Congress high command that he will pull out all stops to spearhead the party to power in 2028 again.

Having been a CM aspirant for several years — and worked relentlessly towards achieving this goal — Shivakumar, 64, is unlikely to be satisfied with being the CM for only two years, and could be expected to go into an overdrive. Before becoming the "richest CM", DKS had already shown his mettle as an organiser, fund mobiliser, trouble-shooter and a backroom strategist for the party. Now he will be called to put these skills into full use in the run-up to the 2028 Assembly elections to show that he can deliver infrastructure projects in Bengaluru, ensure ad-

equate funds for the party's promised "guarantees", and catch the imagination of Gen Z with good governance.

Shivakumar's predecessor Siddaramaiah, the 78-year-old two-time CM, had earlier maintained that he would not contest the next election. That could have been just a message to the Congress leadership to let him complete his entire tenure in his second term. Rahul Gandhi supported him essentially because as the Congress's tallest OBC leader in the state, his credentials were in sync with the politics the former has sought to pursue nationally around the themes of caste census and social justice.

For the Congress, which has virtually become a party of the South, it has become a make-or-break battle to retain Karnataka. While the party wrested Kerala from the Left Front, and retains Telangana, where CM Revanth Reddy seems to have doubled down on his outreach to the masses — in a manner compared with the late Y S Rajasekhara Reddy's efforts in united Andhra Pradesh — the real challenge for the party lies in retaining Karnataka.

Barring Karnataka, the BJP

has so far not managed to come to power in other southern states. So the BJP will also try to tap into any "anti-incumbency" in Karnataka to mount its bid to return to the helm two years down the line.

Karnataka becomes more important for the BJP in the wake of its debacle in recent Tamil Nadu elections, where the Congress has returned to government after six decades, as a junior partner of Vijay's TVK. The grand old party dumped its old ally and ex-incumbent DMK with which it had fought the elections. The new alignments in state politics that Vijay's win has triggered have yet to crystallise. While the DMK is distancing itself from the INDIA bloc — there are reports about the Dravidian party's "backchannel talks" with the BJP — Vijay has shown no hurry to join the Opposition grouping, even though the Congress is its key ally now.

When Vijay recently came to Delhi on his first official visit as the CM, he called on PM Modi besides meeting Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman. However, he wrapped up his Delhi visit and returned to Chennai without meeting Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi.



Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar with former CM Siddaramaiah earlier this week. ANI

These were seen as straws in the wind, to indicate that the political newbie, despite his stunning electoral success, may choose to tread with caution now and not upset the Centre in any way. The point remains that Vijay does not have a majority on his own in the Assembly. The Congress, which has only five MLAs, may also have to guard its flock closely — it could be early days for the party to celebrate in Tamil Nadu.

Congress play

Given the Congress's high

stakes in the South, the party high command has lately displayed more prudence in its decision making in the region. As in Kerala, where Rahul Gandhi was initially leaning towards his confidant, AICC general secretary (organisation) K C Venugopal, becoming the CM, he finally agreed on the candidature of V D Satheesan for the top job.

It was Satheesan who, as the Leader of the Opposition (LoP) in the Kerala Assembly, had been seen by people as the face of the Congress-led UDF's fight against the incumbent Left,

even though Venugopal had the support of a majority of MLAs.

In Karnataka too, as DKS became increasingly restive for the post he had been promised under a rotational chief ministership deal, months after Siddaramaiah completed his half-way mark, the Congress leadership decided to bell the cat. Rahul and Venugopal had initially been in favour of Siddaramaiah's continuance while Sonia Gandhi, Mallikarjun Kharge and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra reportedly supported the need for a change. Eventually, all came on the same page — and it was DKS.

DKS & Siddaramaiah

In Karnataka, the changing of guard was a smooth affair, unlike Rajasthan where the Congress leadership could not get its way in 2022. The then Rajasthan CM Ashok Gehlot upstaged the AICC observers who had been sent to Jaipur to name Sachin Pilot as his successor, who was also promised chief ministership in the second half of the government.

However, Siddaramaiah chose to play his cards differently from the way Gehlot had done. He saw the writing on the

wall and made way for his deputy — and that is not an easy thing to do. The senior leader embraced his junior, displaying impeccable optics, and earning public sympathy, along the way.

But this did not mean that Siddaramaiah was calling it quits. By accepting the caste census just before his exit, he has left a hot potato for his successor — to implement it and risk the unhappiness of his own Vokkaliga community, or to put it on the backburner and provoke the wrath of the backward classes.

Cast in the old school mould, Siddaramaiah chose to make his moves politically. He said he was not interested in a Rajya Sabha seat or moving onto the national stage, making it clear that he would continue as an MLA in the state. However, on the eve of the DKS's swearing in as the CM, he was appointed a member of the Congress Working Committee (CWC).

Unlike Siddaramaiah, Shivakumar is not considered a mass leader. He also does not enjoy the support of a caste alliance that Siddaramaiah has had in the form of AHINDA, comprising sections of backward classes, dalits and minorities, which has stood the Congress in good

stead.

The Vokkaliga group makes up more than 10% of the state's population and is concentrated in the old Mysore region that accounts for 61 Assembly seats. The community has so far looked up to former PM H D Deve Gowda, the JD(S) chief, and his son and Union minister HD Kumaraswamy, as their key leaders. The elevation of DKS may make the JD(S) vulnerable.

There are already reports that a worried Kumaraswamy may consider returning back to state politics to keep his flock together and consolidate the JD(S)'s vote base. The situation is in a flux, but Karnataka may be heading towards a more bipolar politics.

It is evident from the ministers inducted in his Cabinet, several of them close to Siddaramaiah, that DKS realises the importance of keeping his predecessor placated for his government's success. Power sharing may well be the name of the game. And the "doer" DKS has his task cut out.

(Neerja Chowdhury, Contributing Editor, The Indian Express, has covered the last 11 Lok Sabha elections. She is the author of 'How Prime Ministers Decide'.)

THE RISE OF WOMEN EMPOWERMENT IN UTTAR PRADESH



Under the visionary leadership of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, Uttar Pradesh is scripting a powerful narrative of women-led transformation. With a sharp focus on safety, dignity and self-reliance, the state has built a comprehensive ecosystem that ensures protection, promotes participation and powers progress. From strengthening law enforcement and expanding welfare coverage to enabling entrepreneurship and financial inclusion, Uttar Pradesh is ensuring that every woman is empowered to lead, contribute and achieve success through financial inclusion and equal opportunities.



Policies Empowering Every Daughter

- ➔ More than 27.37 lakh daughters have benefitted under Mukhyamantri Kanya Sumangala Yojana, strengthening education, healthcare and social security for the girl child.
- ➔ Under Mukhyamantri Bal Seva Yojana (COVID & General), orphaned children are being provided financial support of ₹1 lakh each, ensuring protection and continuity of education.
- ➔ Through Mission Vatsalya, over 1 lakh children have been reunited with families and connected with rehabilitation support.
- ➔ Nearly 60 lakh mothers have benefitted under Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana, reflecting the Government's commitment towards maternal health and nutrition.



Policies Driving Women's Protection and Inclusion

- ➔ More than 2.39 lakh women have received assistance through One Stop Centres, ensuring legal aid, counselling and protection support.
- ➔ Under Mukhyamantri Samuhik Vivah Yojana, over 5.50 lakh daughters have benefitted through transparent and Aadhaar-linked financial assistance.
- ➔ Women affected by crime and violence are receiving rehabilitation and financial assistance, reinforcing the Government's zero-tolerance approach towards crimes against women.
- ➔ Pension support for elderly destitute women and differently-abled women has been strengthened to ensure social dignity and economic security.
- ➔ Women's participation in night shifts with safety measures reflects a progressive policy environment focused on equal opportunity.



Creating Women Led Economic Growth

- ➔ More than 9.43 lakh Self Help Groups have been formed under the National Rural Livelihood Mission, connecting over 1.06 crore women with sustainable livelihood opportunities.
- ➔ Under Lakhpati Didi Yojana, over 35 lakh women are moving towards financial independence and entrepreneurship.
- ➔ More than 64.34 lakh families have been linked with livelihood initiatives driven by women beneficiaries.
- ➔ Women self-help groups have been allotted over 2,682 fair price shops, strengthening their participation in the public distribution system.
- ➔ More than 60,000 women-led groups are ensuring transparent ration distribution while creating local economic opportunities.



Mission Shakti

Women Security
Women Dignity
Women Empowerment



Mission Shakti: Promoting women's safety, dignity and self-reliance

Mission Shakti has emerged as a transformational campaign focused on women's safety, dignity and self-reliance.

Awareness drives and grassroots outreach are ensuring that women directly benefit from welfare schemes and government services.

More than 13.57 lakh women have been linked with banking and financial literacy initiatives, promoting economic inclusion.

Convergence of schemes related to housing, education, healthcare, pensions, agriculture and employment is creating a holistic ecosystem of empowerment for women across the state.



Strong Intent for Nutrition

- ➔ Anganwadi centres across Uttar Pradesh are being transformed into Saksham Anganwadis with upgraded infrastructure and smart monitoring systems.
- ➔ More than 2.36 lakh Anganwadi centres have been sanctioned to strengthen nutrition and child development services.
- ➔ Through Mukhyamantri Suposhan Yojana, over 2 crore 12 lakh children, pregnant women and lactating mothers have received nutritional support.
- ➔ Technology-enabled monitoring through Poshan Tracker has improved service efficiency to nearly 98%.
- ➔ Significant reductions in stunting and underweight cases among children reflect the long-term impact of nutrition-focused governance.



Empowering Women Workforce

- ➔ UP's vast Anganwadi network includes nearly 1.82 lakh workers and 1.28 lakh helpers, playing a crucial role in women and child welfare.
- ➔ Honorarium of Anganwadi workers has been increased to ₹6,000 per month along with additional incentives.
- ➔ Anganwadi helpers are receiving enhanced financial support up to ₹4,000 per month, improving livelihood security for grassroots women workers.
- ➔ Insurance and welfare schemes have benefitted over 1.89 lakh Anganwadi workers and helpers, ensuring social protection and recognition.



Dignity, Growth and Governance

- ➔ Construction of 1,100 Pink Toilets across 189 urban local bodies has enhanced convenience, dignity and safety for women in public spaces.
- ➔ Women beneficiaries are being prioritised in rural and urban infrastructure schemes, ensuring equal participation in development.
- ➔ The Government has introduced the Women Economic Empowerment Index (WEE Index) to scientifically measure women's participation in entrepreneurship, education, employment and safety.
- ➔ Women are increasingly becoming active stakeholders in governance, local economy and community development across Uttar Pradesh.



1090

Women Power Line

1076

Chief Minister Helpline

102

Ambulance Helpline for Pregnant Women & Newborn
epaper.indianexpress.com

112

Emergency Police Service

1098

Child Line

1930

Cyber Helpline

181

Women Helpline

Delhi court orders framing of charges in terror case against top PFI leaders

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, June 5

OBSERVING THAT there was a “grave suspicion” of a conspiracy to overthrow the Indian government and establish an Islamic Caliphate in the country by 2047, a Delhi court on Friday ordered framing of charges in a terror case against the top leaders of the banned Popular Front of India (PFI). “Considered as a whole, the material on record raises grave suspicion that the accused, acting through and on behalf of the Popular Front of India and its National Executive Council (NEC), agreed and acted in furtherance of a single conspiracy — to overthrow the secular democratic Government of India and to establish an Islamic Caliphate under Sharia law in India by or before the year 2047 through an armed struggle against the State,” Additional Sessions Judge Prashant Sharma said in his order. The NIA’s case, lodged in 2022, pertains to allegations that PFI “conspired to overthrow the secular democratic

Government of India” and to establish an Islamic Caliphate under Sharia law in India by or before 2047. The agency had claimed that the PFI’s objective was to be achieved “through armed struggle against the state”. “Each accused’s role, on the material at face value, fits into one or more limbs of the conspiracy,” Judge Sharma said, ordering framing of charges against PFI and 25 other accused persons. Formal framing of charges will take place on July 10 following which trial is likely to begin against all the accused persons. The NIA was represented in court by Special Public Prosecutor Rahul Tyagi, assistant public prosecutors Vikas Wallia and Jatin Khatri, along with advocates Amit Rohilla and Shubham Goyal. Over 1,300 criminal cases have been registered against PFI members across the country by law enforcement agencies. In September 2022, the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) had published a gazette notification declaring the organisation and its associates unlawful.

MANIPUR VIOLENCE

Couple among 3 dead, homes set ablaze in attack on Kuki village

Sukrita Baruah
Guwahati, June 5

THREE PERSONS, including a couple, were killed on Friday morning in an attack on a Kuki-Zo village in Manipur’s Kangpokpi district, amidst continuing tensions in the state’s hills. A senior police officer confirmed an attack by “unidentified gunmen” on Loibol Khullen village in Kangpokpi on Friday morning, and that three bodies were recovered from there. Kuki-Zo groups in the district have identified those killed as Lethkhongam Haokip (34), his wife Tinmary Haokip (30) and Jangminlan Haokip (34). They have also reported that seven houses were set ablaze. While Kuki-Zo groups have alleged that Naga armed

groups are responsible for the attack, the official said that the matter is under investigation. “Kuki Inpi Manipur unequivocally denounces this barbaric act of violence against unarmed civilians. The deliberate killing of innocent persons and the destruction of homes and livelihoods constitute a serious violation of human dignity and fundamental human rights. The deliberate targeting of civilians and the destruction of homes can never be justified under any circumstances,” the Kuki Inpi Manipur, a top body of the community, said. Calling for the assailants to be apprehended, it added that it “shall not be held responsible for any consequences arising from this heinous crime.” Haokholet Kipgen, the local MLA, an Independent, con-



“I call upon the central forces, state forces, and the government of India to take immediate action to restore security in the area... prevent further attacks”

HAOKHOLET KIPGEN,
LOCAL MLA

demned the incident and stated, “I call upon the Central Forces, State Forces, and the Government of India to take immediate and decisive action to restore security in the area, protect vulnerable villages, prevent further attacks, and ensure that those responsible are held fully accountable under the law. Immediate relief and assistance must also be extended to the affected families who have suffered immense loss and hardship.” Friday’s attack comes amidst heightened tensions between Manipur Naga and Kuki communities and a protracted hostage crisis, in which 14 Kuki villagers have been held captive by Naga groups for over three weeks, and six Naga men who had been abducted remain missing for the same duration.

Nepal’s Foreign Minister begins 3-day India visit

New Delhi: Nepal’s Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal arrived in India Friday for a three-day official visit. This is the first visit by a minister from Nepal’s new government led by Prime Minister Balendra Shah. Khanal is scheduled to hold talks with External Affairs minister S. Jaishankar Saturday and will depart Sunday. The visit comes days after Nepal’s ruling Rastriya Swatantra Party chairman Baki Ram Lamichhane visited India earlier this week. Sources said that the issues of development partnership, economic assistance and cooperation in the power sector are expected to be on top of the agenda for discussion between Khanal and Jaishankar. ENS

Himachal ex-deputy AG booked on former chief secy Gupta’s complaint

Saurabh Parashar
Shimla, June 5

POLICE IN Himachal Pradesh Friday booked former deputy advocate general Vinay Sharma for defamation and criminal intimidation, following a complaint by former chief secretary Sanjay Gupta. The FIR was registered at the Chhota Shimla police station under sections 248 (fabricated or baseless criminal charges with the explicit intent to injure or harass someone), 351 (criminal intimidation) and 356(2) (criminal defamation) — based on a complaint filed by Gupta on May 30, who accused Sharma of making false allegations of corruption, abuse of office, benami property holdings, illegal use of funds and

FIR against ex-RERA chief

Shimla: Shimla police Friday booked former HP Real Estate Regulatory Authority (RERA) chief Shrikant Baldi for criminal defamation on a complaint by former chief secretary Sanjay Gupta. The FIR was registered under BNS sections 248, 351 and 356(2). Gupta alleged Baldi had issued a press statement containing “false, malicious and defamatory allegations” to tarnish his reputation. ENS

on March 24 as malicious and intended to damage his reputation. Sharma, a 1988-batch IAS officer, superannuated as Himachal Chief Secretary on May 31 and subsequently joined as the chairperson of Punjab State Electricity Regulatory Commission (PSERC) on June 3. According to the FIR, the police headquarters examined allegations levelled by Sharma and found them to be “incorrect, legally untenable, unsupported by documentary evidence, and based on assumptions and conjectures”. Responding to the FIR, Sharma alleged that the action was politically motivated and intended to discourage him from pursuing legal action against Gupta. “I was not called even once to record my statement.”

कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबन्धक, युनिट-7
कन्स्ट्रक्शन एण्ड डिजाइन सर्विसेज
उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम (नगरीय)
(30 प्रो सरकार का उपक्रम)
का.पता:-ए-212, ब्लाक-ए, देवदयासपुरी,
मेरठ-250005
E-mail ID: cds.upsunit7@gmail.com

निविदा सूचना सं.: 2201/E-Tender/195
दिनांक: 04.06.2026

ई-निविदा सूचना
उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम, को ओर से
अयोध्याखोरी द्वारा Construction of
Integrated Tourism Development
Project in Hastinapur “Hastinapur Ki
Hastyan” (Waste-to-Wonder Theme-
Based Park) के निर्माण अनुमानित लागत
₹ 1778.32 लाख (जी.एस.टी. रहित एवं
लेबर सेस सहित) हेतु सी. एण्ड बी.एस. में
यथोचित श्रेणी में भवन कार्य हेतु पंजीकृत
टेकेदारों से दिनांक 06.07.2026 के
अपराह्न 15:00 बजे तक ई-निविदाएं
आम्मानित की जाती हैं। उक्त कार्य हेतु
ई-निविदा प्राप्त दिनांक 05.06.2026 से
दिनांक 06.07.2026 के मध्य उत्तर प्रदेश
सरकार की e-procurement वेबसाइट
<https://etender.up.nic.in> से डाउनलोड
किये जा सकते हैं तथा ई-निविदा दिनांक
23.06.2026 को अपराह्न 01:30 बजे
कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबन्धक, युनिट-09,
सी.एण्ड बी.एस., उ.प्र. जल निगम (नगरीय),
सहारनपुर में खोली जायेगी। ई-निविदा प्राप्त
का मूल्य **₹11,800.00 (₹10000.00+GST 18%)**
अतिरिक्त देय होगा। निविदा से सम्बन्धित विस्तृत विवरण
विभाग की वेबसाइट www.cdsupn.org
एवं प्रोक्वोरमेंट पोर्टल <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर उपलब्ध है। समस्त शुद्धि पत्र
(Corrigendum) <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर ही अपलोड किये जायेंगे, इनका
पुष्टक से कोई प्रकाशन नहीं किया जायेगा। निविदादाताओं को सलाह दी जाती है कि वे उक्त वेबसाइट का समय-समय पर
अवलोकन करते रहें।

Timber e-Auction
Forest Department, Gujarat State
This is to inform all the traders who are interested to participate in the e-auction of Teak/non-teak Timber and Fuel wood to be held in Dang North/South division of Valsad Circle from Date 22/06/2026 to 30/06/2026. All interested traders are requested to participate in the e-auction.
The procedure for participation in e-Auction and the details of lots of Teak/ non-teak timber and fuel wood is available on the website <http://forestauction.nprocure.com>
Sd/-
Dy. Conservator of Forests
Dang North Division,
Ahwa
INF-DANG-38-2026

DIRECTOR, STATE FORENSIC SCIENCE LABORATORY, RAJASTHAN, JAIPUR
Nehru Nagar RPA Road, Jaipur Phone No. 0141-2301584, Fax No. 0141-2301859
Email- Director.fsl@rajasthan.gov.in
File No.: N-53(sycks -tu/Manpower/2021-00255/ 6685 Date: 29/05/2026

NOTICE INVITING BID
NIB NO.: 05/2026-27
Bid for 120 Expert Manpower Services (DNA & Cyber Division) of estimated value INR 720.00 Lac is invited from interested bidders up to 11:00 AM on Date 22-06-2026 Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> or <http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in>) of the State.
UBN FSL2627A0017
DIPRC/9704/2026

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Tender Notice No. JHS-N-GSU-10-26 Dated : 30.05.2026
E-TENDERING TENDER NOTICE
Dy. Chief Signal & Telecom Engineer/GSU/Jhansi, DRM's office, Jhansi, for and on behalf of President of India invite open Tender through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following works.
E-Tender No. : JHS-N-GSU-10-26 **Approx Cost : Rs. 7820354.35**
Description of work: EI alteration and other S&T work for Construction of ROB's in lieu of level Crossing No. 33 at KM 1267/9-1268/0 and 40 at KM 1283/5-6 in between Gwalior-Bhind section of Jhansi Division.
Earnest Money : Rs. 156400.00 **Cost of Tender Form : Nil.**
Opening of tender : 23.06.2026 Time 15:00
Completion period from issue of letter of acceptance : 12 Months
• Tender on line can be submitted upto 15:00 hrs on 23.06.2026 • For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in (JHANSI DIVISION-GATI SHAKTI, NORTH CENTRAL RLY) 1267/26 (ADM)
North central railways **www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in** **@ CPRONCR**

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA TENDER NOTICE

Sr. No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP/ AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD/CORP/ AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/ CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	HVPNL	MAJOR REPAIR IN TYPE-II AND TYPE-III QTRS AT 66 KV SUBSTATION COLONY, MARUTI GURUGRAM (ONLINE TENDER ID- 2026_HBC_526588_1) - HEW TENDER REF. NO. 2026FFHBE99 6199 47DB B62F 627BA3E2603987HVP (DISTT. GURUGRAM)	03.06.2026 16.06.2026	Rs. 20,36,442/-	www.hvpn.org.in	0172-2583789 pro@hvpn.org.in
2	HVPNL	ENIT RAISING OF APPROACH ROAD, MAIN GATE, BOUNDARY WALL AND OTHER MISCELLANEOUS WORKS AT 220 KV SUB-STATION SECTOR-56 GURUGRAM	03.06.2026 12.06.2026	Rs. 24,59,627/-	www.hvpn.org.in	0172-2583789 pro@hvpn.org.in

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No- 45925/HRY

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD BRIDGE CONSTRUCTION DIVISION UJJAIN (M.P.)
Tender Notification No.-03/SAC/2026-27 Ujjain, Date: 31/05/2026

Notice Inviting Tender
Online Tender for the work mentioned below are being invited. The Tender have been uploaded on the e-Tender Portal of Public Works Department <https://mptenders.gov.in> in Tender details are as below :-

S. No.	Tender ID.	District	Nature of work	Name of work	Call No.	Cost of Project (PAC) (Rs. In Lacs)	EMD/Fee/Tender Fee All Document & Other Document Submission
1	2026 PWDDB 511842_1	Bridge/Railg	4	5	6	7	8
1	2026 PWDDB 511842_1	Railg	Work	CONSTRUCTION OF HIGH SUMERSIBLE BRIDGE ACROSS ANAR RIVER ON THE ROAD NH-52 (OLD AB ROAD NH-3) AHINSA GATE APPROACH ROAD VIA BIAORA CIVIL HOSPITAL IN RAIGARI DISTRICT M.P.	Fourth	381.51	Online Only

The document can only be purchased online from the above website after making online payment. The last date & time for purchase of document online is Dated 22.06.2026 up to 17:30 PM. Detail NIT and other details can be viewed on the above mentioned portal. Amendments to NIT, if any, will be published on website only, and put in newspaper.

Sd/-
Executive Engineer
PWD Setu Nirman Division Ujjain
G-13964/26

M.P. POWER GENERATING COMPANY LIMITED
Office of the Addl. C.E. (P&W), Shree Singaji Thermal Power Project, Dongalia, Distt. Khandwa (M.P.)
E-mail ID : sepnw.sstpp1@gmail.com

No. 515-1700/SSTPP/MPPGCL/P&W/1828 Date 05.06.2026

Tender Particulars/Tender Number	Estimated Cost (Rs.) (including GST)	Tender Cost & EMD in Rs.	Last Date and Time for Closing of Online Submission
Work contract for external surface painting of Air Receiver Tanks and associated lines (installed near Air Compressor House and FOPH area) and Ash Slurry Pipe Rack up to PH-II chimney at 2x600 MW, SSTPP, MPPGCL, Dongalia. (T-2026_MPPGCL_478921_1)	Rs. 50,86,500/- (including G.S.T.)	2000/- & 1,01,800/-	29.06.2026 Up to 15:30 hrs
Upgradation of performance Analysis Diagnostics and Optimization (PADO) system at 2X600 MW and 2X660 MW Units at SSTPP, Khandwa. (T-2026_MPPGCL_507395_1)	Rs. 7,78,80,000/- (inclusive of G.S.T.)	5000/- & 7,78,800/-	25.06.2026 Up to 15:30 hrs

For extension & other details, the bidders are requested to please visit e-portal of GoMP at www.mptenders.gov.in

M.P. Madhyam/126222/2026 **SAVE ELECTRICITY** **SE (P&W)**

OFFICE OF THE RESIDENT COMMISSIONER
GOVT. OF MADHYA PRADESH, MADHYA PRADESH BHAWAN 29-C & D, JESUS AND MARY MARG CHANAKYAPURI, NEW DELHI-110021
Phone No. 011-26772001, 2002
NIT No. 01/MARCH/TONER REFILLING/MPB/2026 Dated: 01/06/2026

TENDER NOTICE (3rd Call)
Online tenders for Annual work of Recycle/ Refilling of Printer Toner (High Quality) at Madhya Pradesh Bhawan, Plot No. 29 CD, Jesus & Mary Marg, Chanakypuri, New Delhi and Madhyanchal, 12 IHC Pocket, Institutional Area, Vasant Kunj, New Delhi are invited with two bid system (Technical bid & Financial bid) under e-tendering website www.mptenders.gov.in or www.mpbhawan.gov.in in the prescribed proforma from interested parties/Registered Firms/ Registered Companies/ Reputed Organizations/ Agencies.

S. No	Description of Items	Remarks
1	NIT No. & Date	NIT No. 01/MARCH/TONER REFILLING/MPB/2026 Dated: 01/06/2026
2	Issuance of tender	M.P. Bhawan, New Delhi website (www.mpbhawan.gov.in) (www.mptenders.gov.in)
3	Date of Submission of tender	Submission on or before 22/06/2026 up to 03:00 PM.
4	A pre-bid conference	15/06/2026 at 03:00 PM
5	Date of Opening of technical bid	23/06/2026 on 03:00 PM
6	Date of opening of financial bid	30/06/2026 on 03:00 PM
7	Annual Probable Amount of Contract	₹ 35,000/-
8	Cost of Tender cost	₹ 200/- (to be paid online)
9	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)	₹ 1,050/- (to be paid online)

G-13953/26 Addl. Resident Commissioner
M.P. Bhawan, New Delhi

NORTHERN RAILWAY Tender Notice
Invitation of tender through E-Tendering (E-Procurement Systems)

N.I.T. No. 04(A,B,C,D,E,F,G)/26-27WE

Name of work with its location	(A)
(B)	Repair to road surface, beams, Plinth protection, gulley chambers and drainage system at PK road railway colony in the section of SSE/W/PG under ADEN/E/D/LI.
(C)	Provision of Sauna Bath, Steam Bath and Chiller Bath at PK Road colony and Balance work for Repairs to Engineering workshop, garages, out houses, road berms, manhole covers and drainage system at PK Road colony in the section of SSE/W/PG under ADEN/E-I.
(D)	Development & establishment of a new nursery at Chankyapuri Railway Station in the S/o SSE/Hort./SPM under ADEN/Hort./NDLS.
(E)	Annual Supply of Horticulture Material in the S/o SSE/Hort./NDLS & SSE/Hort./DKZ under ADEN/Hort./NDLS.
(F)	Upgradation of kitchen wood work, repair of damaged doors & windows of staff quarters and officers flats, Doctor Lane etc. colony in the section of SSE/W/PG under ADEN/E-I.
(G)	Renovation of new allotments in type-IV, type-IV spl and type-V flats with improvement to kitchen, toilet, balconies flooring etc. at P.K. Road Railway colony in the section of SSE/W/PG under ADEN/E-I.

Approx. cost of work (A) 9999986.68 **(B)** 7154408.18 **(C)** 6499272.76 **(D)** 9144393.21 **(E)** 11998959.54 **(F)** 19999922.25
EMD amount (A) 200000.00 **(B)** 143100.00 **(C)** 129994.45 **(D)** 182900.00 **(E)** 240000.00 **(F)** 400000.00
Completion period of work (A) 08 Months **(B)** 06 Months **(C)** 18 Months **(D)** 12 Months **(E)** 08 Months **(F)** 08 Months

Date and Time for submission of tender and opening of tender : Closing date of tender on 30.06.2026 at 15:00 hrs.
Website particular notice board location complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc. :
No: 128-W/269/O.E.T/NIT No. 04 (A,B,C,D,E,F,G)/26-27/WE Dated :- 05.06.2026 1945/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

Murder attempt case against Khan Sir for ‘asking guards to shoot’

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, June 5



BIHAR EDUCATOR and You-Tuber Faizal Khan has been booked for attempted murder and under the Arms Act days after his two security guards allegedly told police that he ordered them to open fire during violence outside his coaching institute in Patna on June 2. The case came days after Khan claimed that “8-10 rounds of gunfire” were fired outside his coaching institute, Khan Global Studies (KGS), during violence outside the centre in Patna’s Musallahpur. Registered Thursday, the latest FIR invokes BNS Section 109 (attempt to murder) and relevant provisions of the Arms Act against two guards, Khan Sir alias Faizal Khan, and other unidentified associates for allegedly firing and creating fear and panic among the public.

Police allegedly contacted Khan, who confirmed that the two men were his private security guards, and said the rifles used were licenced weapons procured through a Noida-based APS security agency. The guards were eventually arrested and allegedly told investigators that on the night of June 2, a group had gathered outside the coaching institute, assaulted guard Chun Chun, tore banners at the gate, raised slogans and created a disturbance. “Seeing the crowd, Khan Sir and his unidentified aides told both of us security personnel — ‘what are you looking at, shoot at the crowd immediately, I’ll handle whatever happens,’” the complaint records the guards as purportedly telling investigators, adding they fired “two rounds each”.

The latest FIR came a day after police had publicly stated that CCTV footage and local inquiries had yielded no evidence of firing during the June 2 attack. An FIR based on Khan’s complaint led to the arrest of three persons linked to the rival Gyan Bindu Coaching Institute, including its director Raushan Anand. On Friday, Khan was unavailable for a comment.

witnesses claimed the duo was seen firing “two rounds each” from rifles. Police allegedly contacted Khan, who confirmed that the two men were his private security guards, and said the rifles used were licenced weapons procured through a Noida-based APS security agency. The guards were eventually arrested and allegedly told investigators that on the night of June 2, a group had gathered outside the coaching institute, assaulted guard Chun Chun, tore banners at the gate, raised slogans and created a disturbance. “Seeing the crowd, Khan Sir and his unidentified aides told both of us security personnel — ‘what are you looking at, shoot at the crowd immediately, I’ll handle whatever happens,’” the complaint records the guards as purportedly telling investigators, adding they fired “two rounds each”.

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No: 128-W/280/Tender Notice/26-27/W-(NIT-10 & 11) Dated: 04.06.2026

Name of work with location, cost of work and Earnest money	1. Provision for protection Arrangement of Track Embankment by MS sheet piling & Nailing for construction of Under-passes/LHS/RUB by Box pushing method on DUK section under ADEN/PNP.
2. Construction of Zero track along with augmentation of track machine siding at KKDE under ADEN/KUN.	

Approx. Cost: 1. Rs. 4,21,79,953.33/- 2. Rs. 2,33,89,165.65/-

Earnest Money	1. Rs. 843600/-	2. Rs. 467800/-
Completion Period	1. 12 Months	2. 12 Months
Date and time of submission of tender and opening of tender.	Upto 15.00 hrs on 30.06.2026, opening of e-tender after 15.00 hrs on 30.06.2026.	
Website particulars, published-tender, notice location etc complete details of tender can be seen and web site where the tender form can be downloaded	Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in	
Similar nature of work	1. Any Bridge work. 2. Any Civil work other than track work.	

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1. The Director, Directorate of Sports & Youth Welfare, M.P. Bhopal invites bids from reputed Firm/Organizations with relevant background and experience for Supply & Installation of Cardiovascular & Training Apparatus for Sports Academies Training Centres.
2. The bids will be received through electronic tendering mode only. The details regarding participation in the e-tendering process can be obtained on www.mptenders.gov.in. If there any queries regarding participation through e-tender process, interested bidder may contact on toll free No. 18002588684.
3. The corrigendum and addendum issued (if any) related to this bid will be published on e-tendering portal only.
M.P. Madhyam/126215/2026 **DIRECTOR**

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 84 BNSS
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Sujeet S/o Late Chhote Lal R/o W-182, Chandra Shekhar Gali No. 5, Babarpur, Welcome, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 511/2020 U/S 33 D Ex. Act, PS Welcome, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Sujeet** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Sujeet** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sujeet of FIR No. 511/2020 U/S 33 D Ex. Act, PS Welcome, Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the date of **01.08.2026**
By Order,
Ms. Deepakshi Rana
Judicial Magistrate First Class- 03
Room No. 19, First Floor, Shahdara District
DP/7292/NE/2026(Court Matter) Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

TMC strongman among six held for attack on Abhishek

Ravik Bhattacharya & Atri Mitra
Sonarpur, June 5

THE STARKEST expression of the anger directed at the Trinamool Congress since its defeat in the West Bengal Assembly elections was witnessed on May 30, when its virtual No. 2 and once all-powerful Abhishek Banerjee was physically assaulted during a visit to Rajpur-Sonarpur Municipality in South 24 Parganas district.

The TMC called the attack “planned and BJP-sponsored”, and shared videos to “prove” this. However, of the six people arrested over the incident so far, including one who surrendered, the biggest name is that of a local TMC strongman. The five others are identified as “BJP supporters”.

Police have said they are looking for more people based on videos of the incident. All the six arrested are out on bail. It was just 50 metres from the house of the arrested TMC leader, Nirmalya Sengupta, in Kamrabad in Rajpur-Sonarpur Municipality, that Abhishek was heckled while on his way to the



The MP was heckled just 50 metres from the house of the leader in Sonarpur

house of a deceased party worker and attacked with eggs, shoes and stones. A banner on the two-storey building where Sengupta lives identifies it as the main office of the TMC's 'Jai Hind Bahini'. Locals said it has been locked since the day of the assault, on May 30. A member of a club in the area says: “Sengupta is one of the prominent TMC leaders of Ward No. 9. He was removed as president of the club after the BJP came to power in Bengal. We saw him that day in the crowd...After that, we have not seen him. His home is locked too.” A police officer of South 24 Parganas said, “We arrested six people based on footage of the incident.”

Nilgiri Tahr population rises to 1,364 in TN, 4.68% rise over ’25

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, June 5

TAMIL NADU'S Nilgiri Tahr population has recorded a steady rise with the third synchronised population estimation conducted in April 2026, putting the count at an estimated 1,364 individuals, showing a 4.68 per cent increase over last year. The ungulates, or hoofed animals are an endangered species found exclusively in the Southern Western Ghats. The Nilgiri Tahr inhabits the verdant sub-alpine grasslands of the Western Ghats in Tamil Nadu and Kerala, and it plays a vital role in nutrient cycling in the high-altitude mountain ecosystem. It has been accorded the highest protection status under the Wildlife Protection Act. In the last two estimation exercises, the state had recorded 1,303 and 1,031 individuals, in 2025 and 2024, respectively, thus signalling a positive recovery

The animal plays a vital role in nutrient cycling in the high-altitude mountain ecosystem

trend. The results carry a 95% confidence interval of 869 to 2,465 individuals. Among all the divisions that were covered, Pollachi Forest Division recorded the highest estimated population with 438 individuals, contributing a major share of the total population. Udhagai Division of the Mudumalai Tiger Reserve recorded the second highest estimate with 313 individuals, while Tiruppur division supported a significant population with 148 individuals. “The Anamalai Hills holds 44.87 per cent of the total population of Nilgiri Tahr in Tamil Nadu, whereas the Nilgiris landscape holds 29.25 per cent of the

TMC overhaul: Old-timers in, Abhishek loyalists dropped

Ravik Bhattacharya & Atri Mitra
Kolkata, June 5

BESIEGED BY rebellions — first by the newly elected MLAs and followed by growing murmurs of an imminent split among her MPs — Trinamool Congress (TMC) chief Mamata Banerjee, in a desperate bid to keep her flock together, on Friday announced a major organisational reshuffle in the party, packing it with loyalists and old-timers. While Mamata has retained nephew Abhishek Banerjee as the party's national general secretary despite widespread criticism, she has appointed two joint national secretaries — Rajya Sabha MPs Derek O'Brien and Dola Sen — to assist him, signalling to the rebels that the decision will be taken jointly and not unilaterally by Abhishek. The announcement was made after the national working committee meeting of the party, which, according to sources, was attended by a handful of leaders at the TMC chief's Kalighat residence in Kolkata. The reshuffle comes two days after 60 of the newly elected 80 TMC MLAs defied Mamata



The TMC chief is set to visit Delhi on June 8 for INDIA bloc meeting

Banerjee and party number two Abhishek Banerjee to choose expelled MLA Ritabrata Banerjee as the Leader of Opposition in the Assembly. Within minutes of it, TMC leadership dissolved all the party committees and frontal organisations and, in a statement, said it would carry out a “comprehensive exercise of introspection, performance review and organisational assessment at every level”. The party has also reconstituted its West Bengal unit by replacing incumbent state chief Subrata Bakshi with former minister and Mamata loyalist

E. EXPLAINED

Exclusion that stands out

THE NAME of Firhad Hakim, one of the TMC's most recognisable minority faces and among party chief Mamata Banerjee's longest-serving lieutenants, is missing from the list. Hakim's omission came hours after he stepped down as Kolkata Mayor, saying he “cannot continue occupying the chair and disrespect its dignity”. The development is likely to trigger fresh speculation about his equation with the leadership at a time when the party is navigating its most turbulent phase.

Chandrima Bhattacharya. Bakshi, on the other hand, has been appointed vice-president in the party's National Working Committee. Also, Sajda Ahmed, Mamata Thakur, Nayana Bandyopadhyay, and Swati Khandekar have been appointed state vice presidents, while Aroop Biswas,

DATA REVEALS A PERSISTENT GENDER DIVIDE

India's ‘partner-less’ population shrinks but TN, Kerala buck national trend

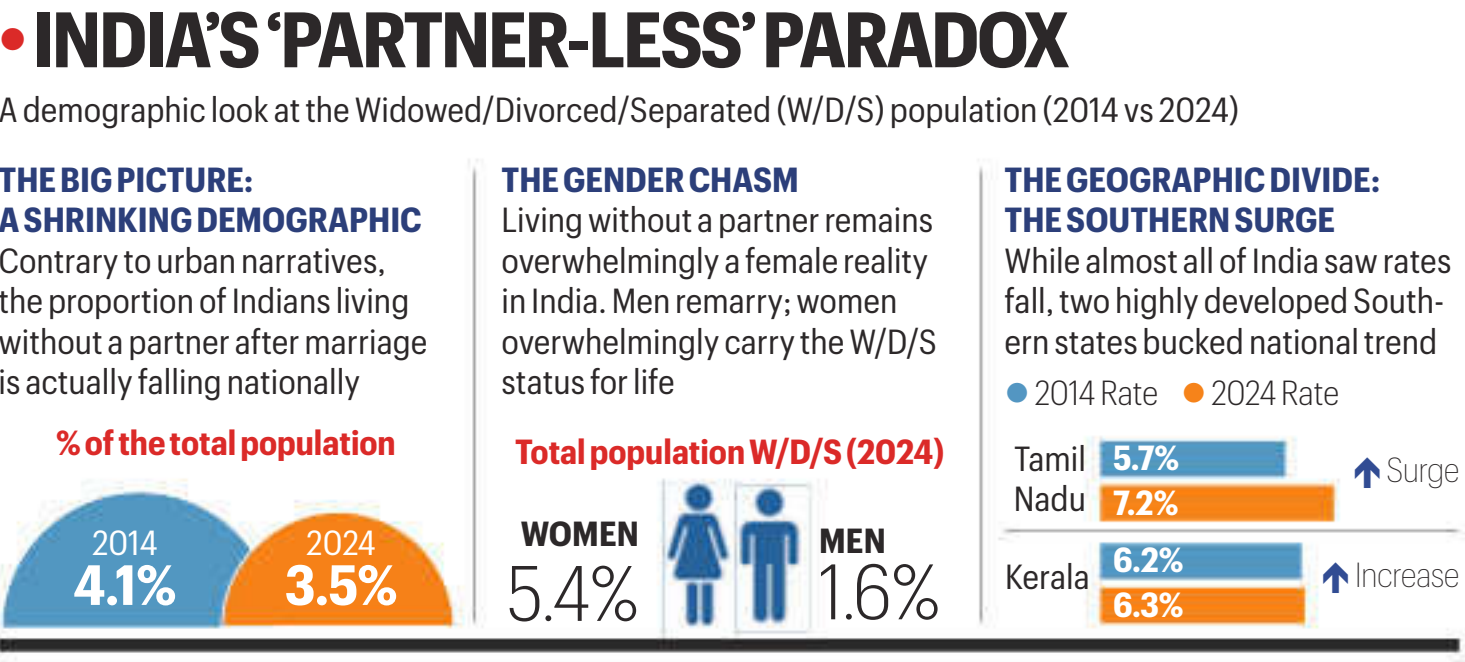
Zeeshan Shaikh
Mumbai, June 5

AT A time when there is a conversation about rising divorce rates and changing family structures, fresh demographic data suggests a different reality. The proportion of Indians who are widowed, divorced or separated has declined over the past decade, even as a handful of southern states have moved in the opposite direction. According to the Sample Registration System Statistical Report 2024, 3.5 per cent of India's population is currently classified as widowed, divorced or separated (W/D/S), down from 4.1 per cent in 2014. The sharpest reductions were recorded in Uttarakhand, where the W/D/S population fell from 6.2 per cent to 3.5 per cent over the decade, and Chhattisgarh, where it dropped from 5.2 per cent to 3.6 per cent. Delhi saw its figure decline from 3.6 per cent to 2 per cent, while Gujarat fell from 4.8 per cent to 3.1 per cent. Bihar, which already had one of the country's lowest proportions, saw it decline further from 2.3 per cent to just 1.5 per

cent. This national trend also masks a striking regional divergence. Tamil Nadu recorded the highest W/D/S rate in the country in 2024 at 7.2 per cent, up sharply from 5.7 per cent a decade ago. Kerala was the only other major state to record an increase, rising from 6.2 per cent to 6.3 per cent. Telangana remained unchanged at 4.6 per cent. The contrast with northern states is stark. Uttar Pradesh reported a W/D/S population of 2.2 per cent, Haryana 1.9 per cent, Jammu and Kashmir 1.7 per cent and Bihar 1.5 per cent. The critical takeaway from the 2024 data is that living without a partner in India remains overwhelmingly a female reality. The figures lay bare a severe structural disparity: men who divorce or lose a spouse are highly likely to remarry, while women overwhelmingly bear the social and economic burden of living out their lives with the W/D/S status. A decade ago, a massive 6.5 per cent of the total female population was classified as W/D/S,

compared to a mere 1.9 per cent of males. While the overall numbers have improved, the gender chasm remains firmly intact. Today, 5.4 per cent of all Indian females carry this status, compared to just 1.6 per cent of males. While almost every state in northern, eastern, and western India mirrored the national trend of a declining W/D/S population, the data expose a massive geographic shift in the South. Two of India's most highly developed states completely bucked the national trend, registering notable increases in marital dissolution and partner loss. Tamil Nadu witnessed a drastic surge, jumping from a W/D/S rate of 5.7 per cent in 2014 to a country-leading 7.2 per cent in 2024. Kerala also experienced an increase, rising from 6.2 per cent to 6.3 per cent. Higher female literacy, greater financial independence, and better social safety nets may be leading to a higher social acceptance of divorce and separation.

FULL REPORT ON
[WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM](#)



Goa: After viral ‘littering’ video and police notice, student dies by suicide

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Panaji, June 5

GOA CM Pramod Sawant on Friday ordered an inquiry into the death of a 22-year-old undergraduate student, who died of suspected suicide after he was booked for an offence of littering on the roadside. On Thursday, a video was shared on social media, purportedly showing a local person confronting the student for allegedly dumping garbage on the side of the road in the Mapusa area. After police received a complaint, an offence was registered under the Goa Non-Biodegradable Garbage (Control) [Amendment] Act. Police said the student was summoned to the police station as per protocol and issued a no-

tice, after which he was allowed to leave. Mapusa Sub-Divisional Police Officer (SDPO) Salim Shaikh said, “...We examined the incident and registered an offence... Under this Act, the punishment most commonly meted out is a fine, though imprisonment is also one of the options, depending on the discretion of the court... We called him, interviewed him, issued a notice to him, and sent him home.” Police said between 1.30 am and 2 am on Friday, they received a call about the death of the man from a gunshot wound. Police said he shot himself with a gun, adding that an investigation is being conducted to ascertain the circumstances of his death and from where he got access to the weapon.

Man killed in Kuwait drone strike was hours away from flying back home

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, June 5

FOR NEARLY three decades, Manzoor Ahmed worked as a tailor in Kuwait, sending money home to support his family in Madhya Pradesh. On Wednesday, just hours before he was due to board a flight home for his nephew's wedding, the 55-year-old was killed when an Iranian drone strike hit Kuwait International Airport. Ahmed, who was a resident of Raj Royal Colony in Ujjain district, was scheduled to fly from Kuwait to Mumbai on Wednesday evening before travelling onward by train. His family had been preparing to welcome him home after months apart. “He called me on Tuesday evening and said he would be reaching home soon. He asked me to come to Nagda railway station to receive him,” his son, Mo-

• BRIEFLY



CJI Surya Kant during the International Conference on Arbitrating Indo-UK Commercial Disputes, in London on Friday. PTI

UNITED KINGDOM

India-UK FTA offers commercial impetus for co-creation: CJI

THE INDIA-UK Free Trade Agreement (FTA) is a “historic moment” for both nations that provides the commercial impetus for co-creation in the arena of mediation and arbitration, Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said in London on Friday. Delivering the inaugural address at the Indian Council of Arbitration's (ICA) international conference on ‘Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR) as a Catalyst for Strengthening India-UK Economic Partnership’, CJI Kant called for ensuring a level playing field and procedures proportionate to the value and urgency of disputes. PTI

8 women held with heroin in Mizoram

Eight women have been arrested with 352 gm of heroin during separate operations in Mizoram's Champhai district, police said on Friday. Most of the seizures were made during routine vehicle inspections at the Khankawn check gate on the outskirts of Champhai on Wednesday, a key transit point towards Aizawl, they said. The largest seizure was reported from Aizawl's Bethlehem Vengchhak, where a 19-year-old woman was arrested with 180 gm heroin, police said in a statement, adding the value of the total heroin seized is around Rs 70 lakh. PTI

12-year-old dies after crocodile attack in UP

A 12-YEAR-OLD boy died after being attacked by a crocodile while taking a bath in a river in Sonbhadra district of UP, police said on Friday. Station House Officer of Ghorawal Police Station, Brijesh Singh, said that Adarsh had gone to bathe in the Belan river when a crocodile attacked him. Upon receiving information about the incident, locals rushed to the spot and pulled the child out of the water. He was later taken to the Community Health Centre (CHC) in Ghorawal, where doctors declared him dead, the officer said. PTI

Bihar ICU fire: ‘Absent’ on-duty doctor among 3 hospital staff arrested

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, June 5

AMID MOUNTING allegations of negligence, mismanagement and fire-safety lapses by patients' families following the blaze that killed six people at a private hospital in Muzaffarpur, police on Friday arrested three members of the hospital's management and medical staff. They have allegedly been found responsible for immediate lapses in patient care and emergency response in the facility's ICU.

The arrests come amid an ongoing probe into the fire at Prasad Hospital in the Brahmapura police station area, which broke out in the early hours of Thursday morning and triggered a large-scale evacuation of critically ill patients. Muzaffarpur City SP Mohammad Mohibullah Ansari said on Friday that an FIR was registered on the basis of a complaint filed by the Sub-Divisional Fire Officer of Muzaffarpur, Ram Niwas Pandey. Those arrested include the hospital's maintenance head Ajit Kumar, administrative head Ram Kumar, and Dr Pankaj Kumar the doctor who was supposed to be on duty in the ICU at



Six people were killed in the fire in Muzaffarpur on Thursday

the time of the incident but was allegedly absent. “Due to their immediate negligence, some people lost their lives,” Ansari said, adding that Sections 106(1), 125(a) and (b), 287, and 324(4) and (5) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 (BNS) have been invoked in the FIR. These provisions pertain to causing death by negligence, acts endangering the life or personal safety of others, negligent conduct with respect to fire or combustible matter, and mischief. He said the investigation was examining the roles of the hospital's owner and director. “We are conducting a fire safety audit... If negligence is found in these aspects, the hospital owner will also be arrested and sent to judicial custody,” he said.

Rahul launches petition against GNI project, seeks youth support

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 5

ALLEGING THAT the Modi government is trying to benefit “one businessman”, Lok Sabha Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi Friday launched an online petition opposing the Great Nicobar Island (GNI) project. On the occasion of World Environment Day, Gandhi said in a post: “I want to ask every young Indian one question: What kind of India do you want to inherit? One where rainforests have been bulldozed for casinos, coral reefs erased from maps, tribal communities pushed off their land, and the air we breathe turned into poison? Or one where India's natural heritage is pro-



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi during a visit to the Andaman and Nicobar Islands. X/@INCINDIA

tected, our tribal communities are safe, and progress works with nature – not against it.” “This is your inheritance they are bulldozing. And only you can stop them,” said Gandhi,

while asking the young people to sign his petition against the mega infrastructure project. Gandhi had visited the island in May and had alleged that the Rs 81,000-crore project is “one of the biggest scams” and “gravest crime” against India's natural and tribal heritage. In a separate post, Gandhi said: “I visited the southernmost tip of India... I walked under trees that have stood for centuries. I dove into coral reefs... And I sat with the people who live there. Tribal communities, whose land is being taken away by violating the Forest Rights Act. Settlers, many of them former soldiers, placed on these islands by the Indian government, who aren't getting fair compensation.”

FIVE BOOKED IN HARYANA'S HISAR

Dalit man hung upside down in well over theft suspicion

Sukhbir Siwach
Chandigarh, June 5

A 32-YEAR-OLD Dalit man was allegedly hung upside down inside a well and beaten by villagers on suspicion of stealing a water-pump motor in Haryana's Hisar district, prompting police to register an FIR against five named persons and several unidentified individuals. The incident took place on June 1 in Sorkhi village near Hansi, but came to light after a purported video of the incident, showing the man tied with ropes and suspended upside down inside a well, was shared on social media. Acting on the complaint of the victim, identified as Baru, police registered an FIR on Thursday. In the video, villagers can al-

legedly be seen questioning the man while he appears to be crying out in distress. Sub-Inspector Praveen Kumar, in-charge of the Sorkhi police post, said Baru was admitted to the Hansi Government Hospital on June 4. The FIR has been registered under Sections 109(1) (attempt to murder), 126(2) (wrongful restraint), 3(5) (common intention) and 351(3) (criminal intimidation) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, and relevant provisions of the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989. In the video, the victim is initially seen hanging upside down inside the well, while later scenes show him being pulled out and assaulted. Villagers claimed multiple water-pump

motors had been stolen from agricultural fields in the area within a week, and they were keeping a vigil to catch the thief. They alleged that on June 1, some villagers spotted Baru on the field and caught him over suspicion of theft. Subsequently, they began questioning the man and later hung him upside down. It was during this time that the purported video was recorded. In his complaint, Baru alleged that he had gone out to relieve himself when a villager raised an alarm, accusing him of being a thief. “I stopped and told there was no need to catch me as I was not going to run away. But more villagers gathered and began beating me, accusing me of stealing a water motor,” he alleged.



Reading Supreme Court on SIR: Now rulers are free to elect their people



DESHKAAL

BY YOGENDRA YADAV

THE SUPREME Court judgment in the ADR case is to our times what the ADM Jabalpur case was to the Emergency. To this day we do not know why some of the best legal minds of that time signed on an order that extinguished the citizen's right to life. What mattered was not the intention behind the judgment, but the signal that everyone read in it: The doors of the Supreme Court were shut for the rest of the Emergency.

That's the true significance of the Supreme Court's order on the SIR. It's not just that the Court has signed on the largest ever disenfranchisement in an electoral democracy. Not just that the order has "declined to name those bearing its costs, declined to reckon with who was excluded and what that exclusion meant", something Rudraksh Lakra's insightful legal scrutiny calls "thesin at the heart of this judgment". Above all, the ADR judgment will be remembered as the moment when the doors to the guardian of the Constitution were perceived to have closed for any attempt to seek lawful remedies in a "politically sensitive" matter.

While hearing the arguments in this case, Justice Joymala Bagchi observed that the "Court does not operate in a vacuum". He was referring to what the Court perceived as the absence of popular protest against the SIR exclusions during the Bihar election. That momentary acknowledgment of the larger truth outside the courtroom that frames judicial proceedings helps us understand what else the Court could have noticed. It could have noticed a strange rush to carry out the SIR just before the elections the ruling party was desperate to win. It could have remembered its own remarks on how the government had dodged the Supreme Court to make appointments to the Election Commission. It could have noted the brazenly partisan conduct of the Chief Elec-



ILLUSTRATION: C.R SASIKUMAR

tion Commissioner and the *jugalbandi* between the BJP and the ECI. It did not. On the contrary, the Court extended credulity, indeed deference, to this institution precisely when the ECI's credibility is at its lowest.

Indeed, the Court did not operate in a vacuum. Therefore, you could be forgiven for reading a chilling signal into this order: Once the regime puts its foot down on any matter, shutters are down for constitutional remedies in the courts. You still have to approach the courts for emergency relief like bail. And hope you are lucky with the bench. You can still look for an occasional stirring judgment on matters of low salience to the present dispensation. But you would be naive to expect judicial checks on democratic dismantling. As during the Emergency, the apex judiciary has abdicated its constitutional responsibility at a moment when the republic needed it most.

The real signal was not just in the Court's validation of the SIR exercise. As many commentators have pointed out, that was *a fait accompli*. The case was effectively decided when the Court allowed the ECI to rush through the Bihar elections and then proceed with the second and then the third phase of the SIR. Any remaining doubt disappeared when CJI Surya Kant warned everyone against obstructing the SIR and finally when Justice Bagchi asked the 27 lakh voters excluded in West Bengal to

The real signal was in the Court's willingness to suspend disbelief. The SIR faced a fatal legal flaw, as it did not follow any of the established procedures laid down by the law, the rules and the ECI's own Manual on Electoral Rolls

wait for the next election. So, no one expected the court to nullify the SIR. Yet the order was crucial to see if there were any ifs and buts, any safeguards, any mandatory SOPs, any concessions to the crores of persons excluded from the voters' list. Eventually, there were none. This silence rings loud in the present judgment.

The real signal was in the Court's willingness to suspend disbelief. The SIR faced a fatal legal flaw, as it did not follow any of the established procedures laid down by the law, the rules and the ECI's own Manual on Electoral Rolls. Faced with this challenge, the ECI used a disingenuous, hyper-technical argument that it could invoke an exceptional clause that allowed it to deviate from standard procedures to address an extraordinary situation in a constituency or part of one. In a staggering display of credulity, the Court allowed this exceptional measure to be generalised, a provision meant for a constituency to be applied to the entire country, and for routine factors like migration and urbanisation to pass off as good reasons for an extraordinary remedy. The Court's order outdid the ECI's own pleading in taking an elephant through the needle's eye.

The real signal was in what Vasudev Devadasan calls the Court's "post-hoc rationalisation" in an order that "rests on misstated doctrine, avoidance of binding preced-

ents, and outright denial of logic and facts". Some of these facts were pretty stark. That the SIR would eventually delete about 10 crore persons from the existing voters' list. That this massive pruning did not fit with the official data on the adult population. That the SIR brought down almost everywhere the already poor gender ratio in the voters' list. That the post-SIR voters' list in Bihar contained as many, if not more, inaccuracies, gibberish names and duplication as the list it sought to revise. Not a word about these inconvenient facts in the judgment.

The real signal was in the Court's refusal to constrain the ECI from curating the voters' list any which way. While upholding the SIR, the least the Court could have done was to make some procedures, from within the ECI's existing Manual on Electoral Rolls, mandatory. It could have stipulated a time-window when the SIR could not be carried out. It could have laid down a protocol for verification of documents. It could have provided a path for rectification of errors where existing voters were wrongfully excluded from the draft electoral rolls. It could have insisted on transparency, on public hearing, on publication of machine-readable lists at every stage of the SIR. It could have asked for the number of deletions of "illegal foreigners". All of this was in line with the norms the ECI had evolved over the last 75 years, which the SIR bypassed. Instead, the Court offered a blank, undated cheque to the ECI. The two orders touted as relief — access to courts for those wrongfully deleted and reference to competent authorities for those deleted on suspicion of being foreign nationals — are either harmless reiteration of existing law or a dangerous descent into a witch hunt.

This order has laid the ground not just for the eventual deletion of nearly 10 crore voters across the country without any amendment to the Constitution, law or even rules. It provides the toolkit needed to overturn the foundational principle of representative democracy. The ECI, and now by implication the BJP, is free to exclude anyone or any section of people from the voters' list. Bertolt Brecht had foreseen it — instead of the people electing their rulers, now the rulers are free to elect their people.

The writer is member, Swaraj India, and national convenor, Bharat Jodo Abhiyaan. Views are personal

Absence of conviviality & a disease called capitalitis



GAUTAM I MENON

IN A talk at CMC Vellore some years ago, the veteran public health expert John Oommen referred to what he called "capitalitis". Among its symptoms was the tendency, most prominently of those based in Delhi, to believe that policies devised in the national capital could be transplanted without change to the rest of the country.

Capitalitis is a disease with diffuse symptoms. It shows itself, for example, in how input is taken to inform decisions at a national level. An instructive example is that of the On-Screen Marking system, or OSM, instituted this year by the CBSE in its Class XII examinations. The CBSE did not hold pilot projects across its 22 regional centres, even though this was reportedly suggested by its advisory committee in the previous year. Only about 100 teachers, all from Delhi-based schools, participated in the exercise. It is understood that even those teachers advised the CBSE not to go ahead with the OSM rollout, citing the need for better features, training and more time to adapt. The total number of city schools that participated was just five, a tiny, non-representative fraction of the approximately 33,000 CBSE schools across the country.

A broader pilot project might have led to a better understanding of the problems faced by teachers in areas far from the capital. These are problems of erratic power supplies, intermittent internet availability, quality of scans, a lack of appropriate devices, and the availability of time, given the many other civic duties often assigned to schoolteachers. The idea that the national capital, with its relatively stable power supply, 5G internet, and relatively better-off schools might serve as a template for the rest of the country is a clear example of capitalitis.

More than a decade ago, I served on a committee tasked with devising a national-level graduate examination. For the two days that it took to complete the paper, we were effectively secluded. Cell phones were not allowed and no papers could be taken out of the room in which we worked.

The committee was composed of academics from all over India. All of them were committed to creating an examination that would help identify those who would benefit most from advanced training. The questions had to be appropriate to the level at which students were trained, across India. But they also needed to be able to identify an additional layer of creativity and out-of-the-box thinking.

What strikes me now, looking back, is the collegiality, sociability and joyfulness with which we worked together to this end. We were, in a single word, convivial.

Many things have changed since then. One major change is that the National Testing Agency has taken over administering the same examination, in addition to others. While there were no serious complaints about the older system, the same cannot be said of the NTA more recently. Several academics of repute have simply not agreed to work with the NTA in forthcoming rounds of exam setting.

There are many reasons for this, but chief among them seems to be the structure of the NTA itself. It is largely staffed by contractual employees. They are overworked and susceptible to multiple pressures, including deadlines imposed on them at short notice. Administrative requirements and the call of efficiency have taken centre stage, replacing the passionate involvement of convivial individuals. The idea of "one agency to rule them all", located in the capital city, manned by staff with no intrinsic attachment to a larger purpose, subverts the true strength of our federal system. The architecture of the past was diffuse, flexible, consensus-based, and diverse.

The combination of capitalitis and AI is worse than these on their own. Any reasonable AI model can now generate questions at an appropriate level, with suggested answers and partial scores. One could go further and have all evaluations done by machine. A further advantage would be to have multiple versions of the papers, again an easy task for any AI. Such a model would be an efficient one and could be administered completely in the national capital. But would it be a convivial one?

A convivial society is one where no centre holds absolutely, where diversity is accommodated, and where industrial-level efficiency is not the chief metric that measures performance. The project of building a social nation requires, at a deep level, conviviality. A Viksit Bharat should also be a convivial Bharat.

To achieve conviviality, even with AI to help, we should first cure ourselves of capitalitis. One step towards that is to see it for what it is.



The writer is a professor at Ashoka University. Views expressed here are his own and do not represent those of his institution

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Tariff pressure

INDIA'S RESPONSE to American trade pressure has so far been largely reactive — matching concessions without extracting proportionate commitments ("Trump tariff saga goes on, India must find way", *IE*, June 5). This asymmetry needs correction. New Delhi should use the ongoing USTR hearings as leverage to secure enforceable market access guarantees in pharmaceuticals, textiles, and IT services, rather than offering tariff reductions and hoping that goodwill will follow.

S.M. Jeeva, Chennai

Name and fame

THE EDITORIAL takes us back to the distinctive memory lane of Indian cricket, vividly marked by some sudden "exits" of the key players in the recent past ("Suryakumar & Sooryavanshi", *IE*, June 5). But notwithstanding the impending fate of former captain Suryakumar Yadav, owing to him having fallen out of favour with both the chief selector and Team India coach Gautam Gambhir, it also goes without saying that 15-year old Vaibhav Sooryavanshi appears to be largely aiming at winning the 100-metre race and creating a new world record. However, his career may be cut short if he does not quickly make amends and stop recklessly playing flashy strokes to earn his "name and fame" in the cricketing world.

S.K. Gupta, via email

Exam security

EXAMINATIONS ARE not merely selection mechanisms; they are instruments of social mobility and merit recognition ("Dear students struggling with exam chaos and scams", *IE*, June 5). Repeated disruptions weaken public trust in institutions and adversely affect the aspirations of millions of young people. The problem is further aggravated by intense competition, limited opportunities, and increasing dependence on costly coaching systems. There is thus an urgent need to strengthen examination security.

Arshnoor, Mohali



RAM RAJYA

BY RAM MADHAV

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi will soon cross another milestone by becoming the longest continuously serving elected PM. On June 10, he will complete 4,399 consecutive days in office, overtaking Jawaharlal Nehru's record of 4,398 days after the first general election. He will also have crossed 9,000 days in office as an elected head of government by then, including his 13-year stint as Gujarat CM — overtaking CMs like Pawan Chamling (Sikkim) and Naveen Patnaik (Odisha). Come October, Modi will complete 25 years in public office. He is also the longest-serving non-Congress PM, and the first non-Congress PM to lead majority governments twice. In total, Modi has led the BJP to victory in six consecutive elections — three to the state assembly and three to Parliament. He is also Gujarat's longest-serving CM.

These data points, however, are only one side of the story. Quite a few substantive issues distinguish Modi's rise from that of his predecessors. A comparison with Nehru is inevitable because Nehru was the only other dominant leader in post-Independence India. His rise in politics was primarily due to his involvement in the freedom movement and support from M.K. Gandhi. The controversy over his selection as Congress president and PM of the interim government in

On June 10, Modi will complete 4,399 days in office, overtaking Jawaharlal Nehru's record of 4,398 days after the first general election

1946 is well known. Twelve of 15 provincial Congress committees recommended Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel. None proposed Nehru. Yet Gandhi preferred "glamorous Nehru", in Rajendra Prasad's words.

The Congress party of the Independence movement was a platform for nationalists to come together to secure freedom. That's why, in his "Last Will and Testament", published in *Harijan*, Gandhi said Congress as a "parliamentary machine" had "outlived its use", and recommended disbanding "the existing Congress organisation". Instead, Congress under Nehru went to the people during the first general election as the "party of freedom" and reaped a rich harvest. That tag led to an uneven competition providing undue electoral advantage to Congress in the years right after Independence.

Like every PM, Nehru has achievements to his credit. Admirers credit him with India's initial years of industrialisation, infrastructure development and institution-building. But critics argue his obsession with the "socialist pattern of society" did more harm than good. Between 1955 and 1965, India's poverty rate grew from 52.66 per cent to 58.60 per cent. The number of poor people grew from 198.7 million in 1951-55 to 301.7 million in 1966-70. Nehru's tenure saw scams like the jeep scandal (1948), the Mundhra scandal (1957-58), and the Dharma Teja shipping loan scam

(1960). He was seen as an expert on foreign policy, yet his tenure saw non-alignment fail, and a humiliating defeat at China's hands.

Modi's rise is the antithesis of Nehru's, with no godfather like Gandhi. He came from very humble beginnings and rose through the committed ideological ranks of the Hindu cultural-nationalist movement. During his 25 years in public office, Modi has offered clean governance, and through a singular focus on development, earned the title of *vikas purush*. GDP doubled over the past decade, absolute poverty was virtually eradicated, and almost 25 crore people were lifted out of multidimensional poverty. In foreign policy, through the effective implementation of strategic autonomy and multi-alignment, India has emerged as an important pole in the multipolar order.

Modi will undoubtedly be remembered as India's most effective and successful PM. He is midway through his third term, yet his dominance over the political landscape remains towering and unchallenged. He is certain to break more records as he continues to lead India for many more years to come. But it is not just the numbers that distinguish him. It is the quality of governance, the ideological vision and effective development agenda that he brings to the table that make him the shining star of Indian politics.

The writer, president, India Foundation, is with the BJP

Modi's road is distinct as he passes Nehru milestone



ALAKA SAHANI

AFTER WORLD No 1 Aryna Sabalenka beat Naomi Osaka and advanced to the women's singles quarter-finals of the 2026 French Open in Paris, the Belarusian tennis player thrilled spectators by doing Michael Jackson's signature moonwalk. This playful moment was an extension of an earlier dance-off between Sabalenka and Novak Djokovic: The latter had done a moonwalk on the court's steps as a challenge to Sabalenka, who responded with the zombie dance from Jackson's "Thriller" video.

After being relegated to near irrelevance following allegations of child abuse and his death in suspicious circumstances in 2009,

Jackson — or MJ — is back at the centre of pop-culture conversations. This resurgence of interest can be credited to the Antoine Fuqua-directed *Michael*, a biographical drama about the musician's life and artistic brilliance. Over a month after its release, the film has earned over \$850 million worldwide, becoming one of the highest-grossing biographical films of all time after *Oppenheimer* (\$975 million) and *Bohemian Rhapsody* (\$911 million). With its upcoming Japan release, *Michael* is expected to touch the \$1-billion mark at the box office. Not surprisingly, the film, as well as its immense success, have triggered polarised reactions.

While *Michael* has been praised for its sensitive performances, it has also drawn criticism for the sanitised gaze it turns on its controversial subject, leaning heavily into nostalgia and spectacle, and skirting around

the contradictions that defined Jackson's life. The pop star's life was as messy as it was magical. He experienced phenomenal success as a global star as well as the unimaginable lows of scandals and legal troubles. His dramatic life story and incredible musical legacy, layered with many contradictions, insecurities, health complications and tragedies, are not easy to capture in a single narrative for the big screen. So, when *Michael*

While 'Michael' has been praised for its sensitive performances, it has also drawn criticism for skirting around the contradictions that defined Jackson's life

keeps the lens firmly trained on the child prodigy who grows into a performer of near-supernatural talent, it is a deliberate artistic choice to ensure that what is captured is the enigma and magnetism of the global star before his life is mired in controversy.

Not that the makers always intended to sidestep the thornier issues. The dramatisation of a 1993 child sexual abuse lawsuit against Jackson was reportedly removed after the makers discovered a clause in the settlement with the young accuser that barred him from being depicted or mentioned in film or television. The film, made with the help of the Michael Jackson estate, then focussed on his musical genius and his successful break from his tyrannical father to launch his solo career.

Though Jackson stayed away from the media for a significant part of his life, he was

aware of the chatter about his personal life. In his 1993 Grammy Legend Award speech, he sounded both triumphant and wounded. "I wasn't aware that the world thought I was so weird and bizarre. But when you grow up as I did, in front of 100 million people from the age of 5, you're automatically different."

Jackson did not have an easy life. The version that *Michael* chooses to show is largely celebratory, leaving viewers with the image of an artist, whose brilliance co-existed with his personal struggles. It will be interesting to watch how *Michael 2* — likely to focus on the next phase of his career, which witnessed tremendous global success of *Dangerous* and *HISTory: Past, Present and Future, Book I* — will unfold.

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

• CLIMATE

Can scheme to replace NCR’s old trucks and buses curb pollution?

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, June 5

THE UNION Cabinet Wednesday approved a two-year clean mobility scheme to reduce air pollution in the Delhi-National Capital Region (NCR). The scheme will incentivise the replacement of older trucks and buses with vehicles that are compliant with BS-VI or higher norms. BS refers to Bharat Stage, a set of emission standards to regulate and reduce vehicular air pollution. While BS-IV regulated tailpipe pollutants such as nitrogen oxides (NOx), carbon monoxide (CO) and particulate matter (PM), BS-VI introduced stricter limits on such emissions besides pushing cleaner fuels and advanced onboard diagnostics. Government vehicles are excluded from the new scheme.

Clean mobility

Delhi-NCR suffers from extreme air pollution. Its predominant sources are the transport sector, dust, industrial pollution and biomass burning. These sources are both local as well as regional. Their share, though, varies depending on the season, as meteorological factors play a crucial role in saturation or dispersal of pollutants. Vehicular emissions remain a key concern. Delhi-NCR has a large vehicle fleet (2.98 crore) which is growing at 7% per annum, according to government data. This year, a meta-analysis of multiple emission source apportionment studies from 2015 and 2010 by a panel of air quality experts attributed 23% of winter PM2.5 pollution and 19% of summer PM2.5 emissions to the transport sector. This expert panel was tasked by the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) in Delhi-NCR to assess reasons behind the worsening of air quality in the region. One of the most important studies on source apportionment has been the August 2018 study by The Energy and Resources Institute and The Automotive Research Association of India, which found that the transport sector accounted for 40% of CO and 63% of NOx emissions in Delhi-NCR. Moreover, within the transport sector, trucks and buses account for 36% of PM2.5 emissions — fine particles that enter the lungs and the bloodstream, causing respiratory and cardiovascular ailments. Even as the share of trucks and buses compliant with older emission norms is only 3% of the total fleet, their emission load is disproportionate to their stock. It is estimated that one pre-BS norms heavy-duty vehicle pollutes as much as 14 times of the modern, BS-VI compliant vehicles. The government note on the Cabinet decision stated that even a BS-IV vehicle emits 2.7 times more than its BS-VI counterpart, making the transition to cleaner technology an important step to reduce air pollution.

Emission potential and vehicle stock

According to CAQM data from December 2025, goods vehicles accounted for 4.1% (11.80 lakh) of the region’s 2.88-crore fleet as on August 31, 2025. Buses account for only 0.6% of the 2.88 crore fleet in the region. Of these 1.61 lakh buses, only 34,449 are compliant with BS-VI norms while 1,26,549 fall in the pre-BS to BS-IV-compliant category. Last year, CAQM submitted to the Supreme Court that even though a vehicle might be fit otherwise, it would still be emitting pollutants as per its BS standard, which are outdated. The CAQM-constituted panel of air quality experts had noted in their report that older vehicles, particularly those operating beyond their regulatory life, exhibit higher emission intensity due to engine deterioration and compromised emission control performance.



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• HISTORY

Maulana Barkatullah: ‘First PM of India’ whose name varsity wants to drop

Yashee
New Delhi, May 5

THE EXECUTIVE council of Bhopal’s Barkatullah University has passed a proposal to change its name to Vagdevi Bhojpal University. The university got its current name in 1988, before which it was called Bhopal University. Maulana Barkatullah Bhopali was a freedom fighter and the ‘first prime minister of independent India’, as he along with some associates, most notably Raja Mahendra Pratap, set up India’s first ‘government in exile’ in Kabul in 1915. “Maulana Barkatullah devoted his life to working for India’s freedom abroad. From Japan to England to US to Germany to Russia to Afghanistan, he travelled to several countries, creating awareness for and building alliances to usher in India’s independence. He died in 1927 in the US, which is probably why his activities weren’t widely known back home. The recognition given to him in 1988, by naming a university after him in his hometown, had been a long-due

honour,” said Chaman Lal, Honorary Advisor, Bhagat Singh Archives and Resource Centre, New Delhi. Lal, a retired JNU professor, said that instead of changing the university’s name, more should be done to popularise the legacy of Barkatullah. **His beliefs, ideals** Maulana Barkatullah is believed to have been born on July 7, 1854, in Bhopal. A meritorious student, he went to Bombay and then London for studies. He started teaching in Liverpool, where he came into contact with Indian revolutionaries. His articles and speeches attracted negative attention from the government, after which he left for the US in 1899. Here, he corresponded with the freedom fighter Maulana Hasrat Mohani (who coined the slogan Inquilab Zindabad). The letters give a clear idea of his views. An article by Iqbal Husain that appeared in the *Proceedings of the Indian History Congress*, Vol. 66 (2005-2006), quotes from one of the letters. “Nearly 20 million people have perished due to starvation and hunger.



X/@ASADQWASI

These poverty-stricken people were both Hindus and Muslims... an entire country has perished due to hunger,” Barkatullah wrote. Barkatullah firmly believed that the British could be driven out of India only if Hindus and Muslims fought shoulder to shoulder and resisted the divide-and-rule ploy. “What makes Barkatullah special is his strong belief that India could only be free if



PHOTO COURTESY: CHAMAN LAL

Maulana Barkatullah (left); his gravestone at a cemetery in Sacramento, US.

all its communities stood together. He worked closely with Hindus, Muslims, Sikhs, and people from every region,” said Ali Na-deem Rezavi, Secretary, Indian History Congress, and Professor of History at Aligarh Muslim University (AMU). “The best example of this is the Provisional Government of India set up in Kabul in 1915. He, along with Raja Mahendra Pratap, a Hindu

prince, and Maulana Ubaidullah Sindhi, a great Islamic thinker, formed a government in exile. Raja Mahendra Pratap became president, and Barkatullah became prime minister. This was one of the first times Indians had set up their own independent political body outside British control. This story is important not just because it challenged the British, but because it showed a vision of India where people of different faiths fought for a common goal,” Rezavi said. **Govt in Kabul, meeting Lenin** During World War I, Barkatullah and his associates travelled to Germany and tried to convince captured Indian soldiers to form an army against the British. He also worked prominently for the Ghadar Party, founded by Lala Har Dayal in 1913, which aimed to win independence through armed struggle. Then on December 1, 1915, the ‘Provisional Government of India’ was formed in Kabul. Four years later, the leaders of this ‘government’ travelled to Moscow to meet Vladimir Lenin, the leader of Soviet Russia.

After the British victory in World War I, the Indian revolutionaries’ plans suffered major reverses. However, Barkatullah kept travelling — to Belgium, Switzerland, France — working for his cause. “Unlike many freedom fighters who worked from inside the country, Barkatullah spent most of his life in exile. He connected with anti-colonial movements around the world and became one of the most well-known Indian revolutionaries of his time. Inspired by resistance efforts in the Muslim world, he believed that justice was a global cause and that India’s freedom was part of that larger fight,” Rezavi said. In 1927, despite failing health, he travelled to California for a Ghadar Party event. This is where, in September 1927, he breathed his last. He was laid to rest in Sacramento, with Raja Mahendra Pratap by his side till the end. Both Rezavi and Chaman Lal pointed out that the Union government is working to popularise Raja Mahendra Pratap, and Barkatullah, as his close associate, should get the same treatment.

• FIFA WORLD CUP 2026

AI-enabled ball for better decisions, fewer surprises



SHASHANK NAIR

EVERY FOUR years when the FIFA World Cup comes around, official sponsor Adidas creates a new iteration of the ball that will be used. This time, as the world further integrates artificial intelligence (AI) models into everyday use-case scenarios, the humble football now finds itself an AI-enabled entity, loaded with a sensor specifically built to track its movements. But the Trionda, this edition’s ball, is notable for more than its modern sensor. It has the lowest number of panels ever used to make a football. And, unlike the mercurial Jabulani ball used during the 2010 World Cup, it promises far fewer surprises than what many players had to contend with in South Africa.

The early World Cup football

The Telstar ball was created for the 1970 FIFA World Cup. Made of 32 panels, it was coloured black and white so that it would be more clearly visible to television audiences in a pre-colour TV era. Its iconic design is what immediately comes to mind when you think of a football. It is from this foundation that the modern football has evolved.

How different is the Trionda from the Telstar?

A lot. For starters, this ball is like an electronic appliance — it needs to be charged for 90 minutes for six hours of play. This is because it contains a sensor inside — something Adidas first adopted with the Al Rihla ball used at the 2022 World Cup in Qatar. This is how this ‘connected ball technology’ works. The Trionda has a 500hz ‘inertial measurement unit’ motion sensor inside one of its four panels, with counter-balances placed on all other panels as well to ensure that its flight remains true. An inertial measurement unit measures and reports an object’s specific force, orientation, and how fast it rotates or revolves around an axis.

1970: TELSTAR



The classic, with 32 black-and-white panels that would boost TV visibility. The iconic Telstar, named after a satellite, and its upgraded versions, were the Cup standard until 2002.

1978: TANGO



Essentially an upgraded version of the Telstar. It was famous for its white base surrounded by thick black triangular graphics. It featured in France’s 3-0 victory over Brazil in the 1998 final.

2006: TEAMGEIST



The Teamgeist was the first football to ditch the standard 32 panels and used 14 instead. Its unpredictable movement — especially with long-range shots — caused controversy.

2010: JABULANI



Jabulani means ‘to rejoice’. But goalkeepers found little reason to. Adidas’ smooth-surfaced ball had a life of its own, twisting and dipping at will. But this did lead to spectacular long-range goals.

THE TRIONDA: TEXTURE, TECHNIQUE, TRAJECTORY

This is a tetrahedron: four triangles, three of which meet at every point. The panels are curved but have three points, like a typical triangle.

The ball has a rough surface with a host of microtextures. The physics is similar to golf balls that have dimples.

This ensures evenly distributed drag, which helps the ball go faster but doesn’t necessarily compromise its path in the air.

What is the purpose of the chip?

Football authorities are attempting to cut down the often prolonged decision-making time that has followed the introduction of the virtual assistant referee (VAR) system. The sensor chip inside the Trionda sends razor-sharp ball-movement data to officials and hastens the process of making offside decisions. “We can track every event, every interaction the player has with the ball. Every location at any given moment is being tracked by a local positioning system,” said Hannes Schaeffe, Football Innovation Lead for Adidas. “So this sensor essentially sends a signal 500 times per second, to anchor points around the stadium.”

How will AI help in making quicker VAR calls?

The sensor will be complemented by pitchside sensors, which track player

Sensor check

The virtual assistant referee system has been criticised for slowing down decisions.

• The Trionda’s sensor will send data to officials and hasten the process of making offside decisions.

movements. FIFA has also chosen to scan each footballer at the tournament, and VAR will also use a 3D digital avatar of the player. Combine all this information gathered — add AI to the mix — and FIFA and Adidas believe there lies a path to issuing lightning-fast offside calls and other VAR checks like accidental handballs and accurate player tracking. Many countries have found themselves on the losing end of a match based on a decision that went against them. World Cups have famously amplified those calls — be it Diego Maradona’s handball against England in 1986 or Frank Lampard’s ghost goal against Germany in 2010. FIFA is hoping to minimise such incidents.

How will the Trionda perform?

The make-up of the Trionda is unlike any other football. While technology plays a big part, it is also a football that — just like

the Jabulani, or the Al-Rihla used in Qatar — has its own characteristics. Chief among those are the Trionda’s similarities to the Jabulani. Both balls are tetrahedrons: four triangles, three of which meet at every point. For the Trionda, the panels are curved but have three points, like a typical triangle. The Jabulani, used in 2010, was notorious for its wild trajectories. Made of eight thermally bonded panels, the ball was the smoothest ever created by Adidas. The drag from that smoothness was what led to its unpredictability and unpopularity among footballers. But the Trionda is different and has a failsafe in place. Adidas has deliberately made the Trionda’s surface rough. It has added three deep grooves in each panel and a host of microtextures (microscopic, raised patterns engineered onto the upper surface). The physics is similar to golf balls that have dimples. The result should be evenly distributed drag that helps the ball go faster but doesn’t necessarily compromise its trajectory through the air.

Does it come with complications?

A team of scientists led by Professor John Eric Goff used a wind tunnel and five World Cup balls: Jabulani (2010), Brazuca (2014), Telstar 18 (2018), Al Rihla (2022), and Trionda (2026). Their experiments showed that the Trionda “exhibited the smallest measured critical speed among the five balls in both tested orientations”. The researchers noted: “A long ball struck with great force may land several meters shorter than expected... Our experiment analyzed a no-spin state, so further research is needed that takes into account external variables in real matches such as spin, humidity and temperature.” The results were published in the journal *Applied Sciences*.

What does its design denote?

The 2026 FIFA World Cup will be the first time three countries will host the tournament. Keeping that in mind, the Trionda is made on a white base, with red, blue, and green-coloured graphics across the four panels of the ball. There is also the graphic of a maple leaf, an eagle and a star to denote the three hosts: Canada, Mexico, and the US.

• ECONOMY

Behind Kerala’s poor finances: High borrowings, low capital spend



GRAPHS, DATA, PERSPECTIVES

BY UDIT MISRA

WEEKLY ECONOMIC AND POLICY INSIGHTS USING DATA

A REPORT recently unveiled by new Kerala Chief Minister VDSatheesan presents a grim picture of the state’s financial health, showing that it trails the national average across most crucial parameters. This is a state that once boasted the most sought-after growth model in India. The decline, however, did not happen overnight. Satheesan, a Congress leader who is also the state’s Finance Minister, wrote in the report’s preface: “The purpose of this report is not to revisit the past in a spirit of criticism, but to understand the challenges before us with clarity and objectivity.” **The Kerala model** Long before Arvind Kejriwal’s “Delhi model”, Nitish Kumar’s “sushashan” (good governance) in Bihar and Narendra Modi’s “Gujarat model”, there was the Kerala model of economic development. In the 1950s, it had the country’s highest population growth rate. By the 1970s, it be-

• Kerala’s fiscal health vs national average

Key metrics	Kerala	National average
Outstanding liabilities as a % of GSDP (2025-26)	35.50%	29.2%*
Interest payment as a % of Revenue Receipts (2025-26*)	20.90%	12.2%*
Committed expenditure as a % of Revenue Receipts (2024-25)	77.60%	46.1%*
Development expenditure as a % of Aggregate Disbursement (2024-25*)	39.90%	63.5%*
Capital expenditure as a % of GSDP (2025-26, BE)	1.34%	3.2%*

*BUDGET ESTIMATE, *REVISED ESTIMATE

came one with the lowest.

This was not all. Over the next two decades, Kerala achieved levels of social and economic development — better health, education and quality of life — that not only surpassed other states but rivalled influential countries. What’s more, Kerala achieved all this with much lower levels of income. In 1996, its per capita income was one-hundredth of the US’s. Despite this, it had a Human Development Index score of 0.775, close to the US’s 0.925 and well above India’s 0.45 — and

Debt burden

• Government debt is not a bad thing, as long as it supports development and can be repaid. • But most of Kerala’s borrowings go towards paying salaries and pensions.

without the kind of coercion that countries such as China employed.

Kerala’s worsening finances

However, over the past several years, Kerala’s model has lost its sheen. The tell-tale sign has been the worsening state of the state government’s finances. Simply put, with each passing year, the state has had to borrow more just to meet the gap between its expenses and its revenues. What’s worse is that the bulk of this money goes towards paying salaries and pensions. This means very little is left to spend on developmental areas (such as health and education) or building the state’s productive capacity (also called capital expenditure). As a result, despite having one of the most educated populations, Kerala has some of the highest levels of unemployment, especially for women. The table shows how far Kerala’s fiscal position has slid relative to the national average on some of the most important metrics. Outstanding liabilities refers to all the debt that the state government has to pay back. Kerala’s outstanding liabilities as a percentage of its total economic output (gross state domestic product, or GSDP) is at 35%. The national average is around 29%. Not surprisingly, Kerala also has a very high interest burden thanks to its past loans.

The next three metrics show that despite having high levels of borrowings, the state is stuck in a cycle of using the bulk of its money just to pay salaries and pensions, etc. This is what is called committed expenditure. This leaves it with little money to spend on development. Finally, the state is also unable to spend enough on creating new productive assets. Capital expenditure lags far behind the national average. The state government’s report sums all this up. “Kerala has been violating the basic tenet of ‘borrow to invest, growth will repay’ in a big way, weakening the growth generating capacity.”

The new govt’s proposals

Part of the solution is to address the wastage in expenditure and to make the administration more efficient. Some of the solutions discussed in the report include raising the retirement age to the same level as the Union government. This move is expected to cut down on the pension bill. Similarly, it is proposed to have pay commissions only once in 10 years, just like the Union government. The report also finds that Kerala has the largest number of public sector enterprises among Indian states and “the majority of them are making losses”. This is draining state finances that could otherwise be put to more productive use.

THE CENTRAL BANK ALSO RAISED INFLATION PROJECTION FOR FY27 TO 5.1%, FROM 4.6% EARLIER

RBI trims FY27 growth forecast to 6.6%

‘Average crude oil prices in F27 may be substantially higher than the \$85/barrel the RBI had assumed’

George Mathew, Akash Mandal & Siddharth Upasani
Mumbai/New Delhi, June 5

THE RESERVE Bank of India (RBI) on Friday cut its GDP (gross domestic product) growth forecast for the current financial year to 6.6% from 6.9%, and raised the inflation projection to 5.1% from 4.6%, cautioning that elevated energy prices and global supply constraints were having “adverse spillovers” on economic activity.

And while domestic demand remains resilient, “there are energy incipient signs of moderation in some sectors”, Governor Sanjay Malhotra said.

He added that there are indications that average crude oil prices in 2026-27 would be “substantially higher” than the \$85 per barrel the central bank had assumed in its forecasts in April.

As per the new forecast, growth is seen at 6.6% in April-June 2026, 6.3% in July-September 2026, 6.5% in October-December 2026, and 6.8% in January-March 2027.

Back in April, the central bank expected the country’s GDP to increase by 6.8%, 6.7%, 7%, and 7.2% in the four quarters of 2026-27.

Meanwhile, the quarterly average inflation forecasts, as measured by the Consumer Price Index (CPI), have been revised from 4%, 4.4%, 5.2%, and 4.7% to 4.2% in April-June 2026, 5.1% in July-September 2026, 5.9% in October-December 2026, and 5.4% in January-March 2027. The RBI is mandated to target a CPI inflation of

4% in the medium-term in a range of 2-6%. The new forecasts show inflation reaching the upper bound of the RBI’s target range towards the end of 2026, with Malhotra saying the impact of the energy price shock is seen waning thereafter.

The core inflation forecast for the current year has also been increased to 4.7% from 4.4%. Core inflation is a measure of inflation that does not include food and fuel items, whose prices can be volatile. As such, it is seen as an indicator of underlying demand in the economy.

The revised macroeconomic forecasts of the RBI were announced by Malhotra while detailing the Monetary Policy Committee’s (MPC) interest rate decision. The governor said that the global environment has deteriorated since the last policy meeting with the conflict lingering amidst a fragile truce.

“The adverse implications of the extended disruption in supply chains and elevated energy prices are reflected in the moderation of growth and increase in inflation projections from the April policy,” he said.

Prices of several inputs such as commercial LPG, industrial raw materials, chemicals, base metals, rubber, and plastic products, among others, have increased. “These could exert upward pressure on CPI inflation in the coming months as firms pass on higher input costs,” he said. Generalisation of inflation through second-round effects on expectations and wages is a



The RBI is mandated to target a CPI inflation of 4% in the medium-term in a range of 2-6%. REUTERS

distinct possibility, warranting a close vigil. “The outlook also remains clouded due to the sub-normal south-west monsoon forecast and El Niño risks. Elevated energy prices coupled with global supply constraints are having adverse spillovers on economic activity,” he said.

Global economic outlook remains clouded by the continuing geopolitical impasse in West Asia, as sharply escalating energy prices and global supply chain disruptions continue to hinder economic activity.

Faced with difficult trade-offs, monetary policy has turned more cautious, he said.

The rupee, which has fallen over 5% since March 2026 when the West Asia conflict started, gained 85 paise at 94.94 against the dollar on Friday following the latest RBI steps to boost in-

flows and the government move to cut capital gains tax and withholding tax. Malhotra said the RBI will continue to curb excessive volatility and prevent disorderly movements in the foreign exchange market, while emphasising that its objective is not to resist market-driven adjustments.

The Governor’s statement comes after the rupee nearly touched the 97 mark last month, while the central bank’s foreign exchange reserves declined by nearly \$46 billion as it intervened in the currency market to stabilise the rupee.

Reiterating that the RBI’s exchange rate policy remains unchanged, Malhotra said the central bank does not target any specific level or band for the rupee and allows the currency’s value to be determined by mar-

• PRICE PRESSURES

THE CORE inflation forecast for the current year has been increased to 4.7% from 4.4%. Core inflation is a measure of inflation that does not include food and fuel items, whose prices can be volatile. It is seen as an indicator of underlying demand in the economy

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GENERALISATION OF inflation through second-round effects on expectations and wages is a distinct possibility, warranting a close vigil

India can return to 7% growth path in FY28, says CEA

New Delhi: Macro stability and supply measures can bring back India on a 7% growth trajectory in FY28, Chief Economic Adviser (CEA) V Anantha Nageswaran said on Friday, asserting that the growth is contingent on improvement in external conditions.

“We have no reason to second-guess them (RBI forecast) at this point, because there are both possibilities on the upside and on the downside with respect to the numbers that they have presented,” he said here.

“So, even if the growth were to slip below 7% as the RBI forecast suggests...macro stability measures and supply assurances will bring us back to a 7% plus growth track in FY28 or as soon as external conditions improve,” he added.

He further said it is a hope based on the assumption that the pre-February 28 condition is restored before FY28.

“Now, if these conditions continue, then we will revisit the estimate for the next financial year,” he added. Talking about nominal GDP, he said, it is a fair estimate that it will overshoot the 10.1% estimated in the Budget 2027, given the rising inflation. “The good news is that the nominal GDP growth will be much higher than the number which the budget estimates used, which is 10.1% for the current financial year,” he said. On the overall trade deficit, he said it widened in FY26, and a similar trend with potentially wider deficits is possible in FY27. PTI



• PLASTIC CURRENCY NOTES ON ANVIL

From rupee to deposits: What RBI Governor said on key issues

RBI measures on inflows We are not targeting any particular amount, but we do expect healthy flows of ECB (external commercial borrowing) and the other measures announced today... expect a much better balance of payments this year compared to what it would have otherwise been.

Hedging costs Yes, I do expect them (banks) to pass on some of the benefits of hedging (PSU ECBs and FNCR deposits), and that will result in good flows.

On FCNR sops We expect the measures announced today to allow banks to offer higher interest rates for NRI and OCI depositors.

Forex benefits to PSUs Concessional facility for forex (ECB borrowing) is restricted to PSUs since benefits to these companies are passed on to a much larger section of the society, unlike the case with private sector.

On the 4% inflation target It’s a target which is sacrosanct for us, which was given by the government. But keep in mind that this target is to be met over a period. It’s a medium-term kind of a target. It is not advisable to take action for each and every small deviation from the target because that can have consequences.

Rupee valuation I have never said the rupee is not undervalued. By some accounts it is undervalued, especially if people compare it to the REER.

On competition for deposits There is competition. Competition is healthy. As long as it is transparent and fair, competition is good. And that should continue.

Economy Economic condition remains robust in the wake of the West Asian war. And the global shock currently seen applies to other countries too. India is in a much better state compared to some of the other economies, as well as compared to similar shocks in the past. Forex reserves are adequate, corporate balance sheets remain healthy, banks are in a good position, so our economy is in a good place.

On private capex Private capital formation numbers have actually been very healthy. Investment to GDP ratio has been turning upwards. So those numbers remain healthy, but more can certainly happen.

Plastic currency notes The proposal is under consideration. We are examining the pros and cons of it, and whether it will be worthwhile to do it. It is still at a preliminary stage. **AKASH MANDAL**

Working to close ‘open ends’, 1st tranche of India-US trade deal by mid-July: Goyal

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, June 5

A DAY after India and US trade officials concluded negotiations, Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal on Friday said that India and the US will sign the “first tranche” of the bilateral trade deal by mid-July.

The US has already proposed new Section 301 tariffs on 60 countries, which are expected to come into effect after July 7. Washington has set 12.5% tariffs on 54 countries, including India, China and 10 on 6 countries, such as Pakistan and the European Union.

“We had excellent discussions from June 2-4 this month. We had a full team of officials from different divisions of trade from the US in New Delhi. I also met them yesterday. We are fast-moving towards closing all the open ends. Sometime by the middle of next month or so, we should be in a position to execute a very vibrant first tranche of the bilateral trade agreement. It will give preferential access to India over our competitors. I expect a higher level delegation by the end of this month,” Goyal said at a press conference in Andhra Pradesh. US President Donald Trump on Thursday also said that India and the US would fi-



The US has proposed new Section 301 tariffs on 60 countries, which are expected to come into effect after July 7. REUTERS

nalise a trade agreement.

Speaking to reporters at the White House, Trump said, “For years, India took advantage of the United States. They charged us tremendous tariffs and paid nothing. Now it is the exact reverse, and we are making a lot of money with India. But we will get to a deal...I like your Prime Minister a lot. He is a good friend of mine, and we get along well. We have a good relationship,” Trump said.

The Commerce and Industry Ministry on Thursday had said that a delegation from the Office of the United States Trade Representative (USTR), led by the Chief Negotiator, visited India from 1-4 June

2026 to advance discussions on the trade agreement.

“During the visit, the teams held constructive and positive discussions across a wide range of issues covering Trade in Goods, Non-Tariff Measures, Customs and Trade Facilitation, Economic Security Alignment and other areas of mutual interest,” the ministry said.

Experts have said that Section 301 is a far more potent tool than the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) tariffs, which were used to impose reciprocal tariffs but did not pass muster in the US Supreme Court. This legal tool was mostly used by the US against countries such

as Europe & Japan, dominant export powers then, before the WTO came into existence in 1995. The Trump administration has resurrected Section 301 again amid a weakening WTO.

Singapore-based Henrich Foundation explained that under Section 301, USTR gets sweeping powers not only to impose duties but also other kinds of restrictions.

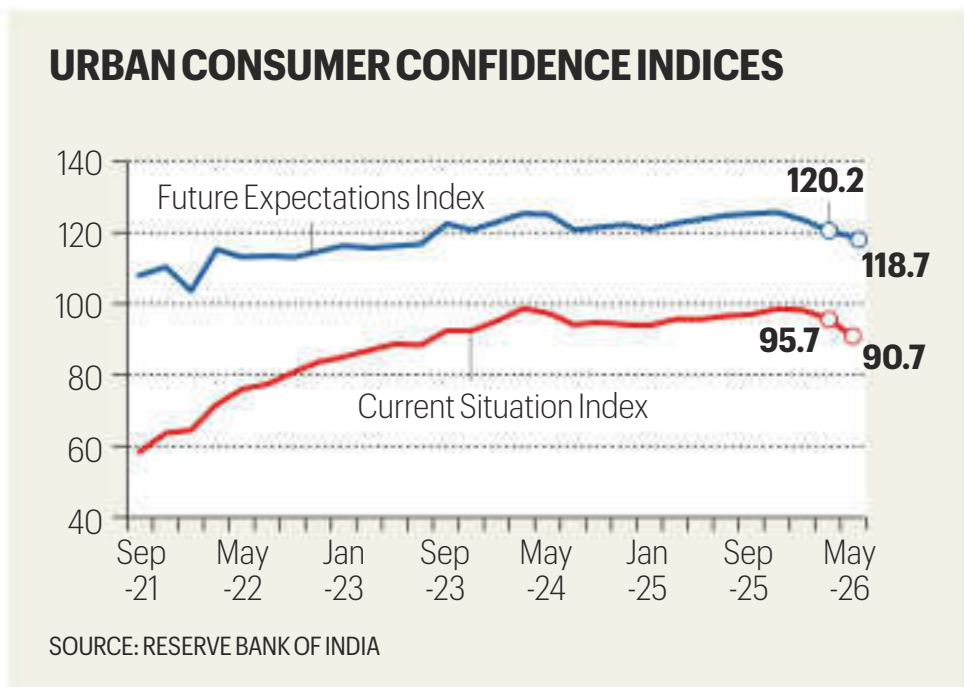
USTR can “withdraw or suspend trade agreement concessions”, enter into binding agreements with the foreign government to eliminate the conduct or unburden US commerce, or compensate the US with satisfactory trade benefits. “After consultations, USTR is meant to investigate to determine whether the action is unfair and harms US trade. This investigation can result in a determination of either mandatory or discretionary actions. The former includes trade agreement violations, unjustifiable or burdensome, or restrictive behaviour. Because Section 301 need not apply only to goods, other retaliatory actions are allowed, such as restricting the terms or conditions or denying the issuance of any ‘service sector access authorisation’,” the Henrich Foundation report said. **FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM**

• Urban, rural consumer confidence falls: RBI survey

Consumer confidence in urban India declined last month, according to the Reserve Bank of India’s latest survey, published on Friday. Based on perceptions of households on the general economic situation, employment, prices, income, and spending and conducted from May 2-11 with responses from 6,086 people across 19 major cities, the survey showed that confidence for the current period declined for the third successive survey round, with the Current Situation Index falling to 90.7 from 95.7.

Meanwhile, the Future Expectations Index — which considers the one-year-ahead period — declined to 118.7, the lowest since September 2023. An index of more than 100 is indicative of optimism, while a sub-100 figure suggests pessimism.

“Households’ sentiment significantly weakened on spending for both the time horizon. The waning is primarily driven by ebbed sentiment on discretionary expenditure,” the RBI noted.



● The story is not too different in rural India, with the central bank’s Rural Consumer Confidence Survey showing that the Current Situation Index fell for the fourth survey in a row to 95.2. The Future Expectations Index, while in the optimistic zone of over 100, declined to 119.3 as all parameters, except prices, deteriorated.



• MARKETS

Sensex 74,243.34	NIFTY 23,366.70	Gold ▼ ₹1,54,238	US Dollar ▼ ₹94.94
-116.67	-49.85	Silver ▼ ₹2,56,908	Oil ▼ \$97.84
-0.16%	-0.21%		

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF JUNE 4, 2026

Govt committed to further drive ‘Reform Express’: FM

New Delhi: Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Friday said the government is committed to further drive the ‘Reform Express’ with decisive policy measures to ensure positive economic momentum amid global challenges.

Earlier in the day, the Reserve Bank lowered its GDP forecast for FY27 to 6.6% from the 6.9% estimated in April, citing elevated energy and other commodity prices, as well as continued supply disruptions arising from the West Asia conflict, which are likely to weigh on economic activity.

However, real GDP is estimated to rise by 7.7% in FY26 (Provisional Estimates), and real GVA has grown by 7.9% in

FY26. Real GDP and Real GVA have been estimated to grow by 7.8% and 7.9%, respectively, in Q4 of FY26.

Notably, manufacturing, trade, repair, hotels, transport, communication & services related to broadcasting, storage and financial, real estate & professional services sectors have attained double-digit growth at both constant and current prices in FY26.

“Our government, led by Hon’ble PM Shri @narendramodi is committed to further drive the ‘Reform Express’ with decisive policy measures to ensure positive economic momentum amidst the global challenges,” Sitharaman said in a post on X. PTI

AirTrunk plans \$30-bn investment in India

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, June 5

New Delhi: Blackstone-backed hyperscale data centre operator AirTrunk plans to invest about Rs 3 lakh crore (\$30 billion) in India by 2030 as it scales up its capacity in the country to 5 GW, a move Prime Minister Narendra Modi described as among the largest proposed investments in India’s digital infrastructure ecosystem.

“India’s digital infrastructure journey is gathering remarkable momentum. AirTrunk has announced plans to invest around Rs 3 lakh crore (\$30 billion) in India and develop 5 GW of data centre ca-

capacity. This is among the largest proposed investments in the country’s digital infrastructure ecosystem,” PM Modi said in a post on X.

Modi said such investments would strengthen India’s position as a global hub for cloud computing and artificial intelligence (AI), while generating employment opportunities, supporting local supply chains and accelerating innovation-led growth.

“It is clear that the future of the world’s digital economy is increasingly being shaped in India,” he added. AirTrunk said the proposed investment programme positions India as a cornerstone of its global growth strategy. FE

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Email ID : sampatnig@ajvsnl.com, Website : <http://energy.rajasthan.gov.in/avnvl>

No. : AVVN/SE(M&P)/E&S/F/D - 1049 Dated : 03/06/2026

Tender Notice TN- 42

Bids are invited from eligible bidders for the work of TN-42 “Pre-AMC Survey & repairing / replacement of all defective parts & further execution of AMC for 03 years of all 06 nos. Semi-Automatic Meter Test benches (20 point position) installed under Ajmer Discom” under TN-42. All the details regarding tenders are available at our website <http://energy.rajasthan.gov.in/avnvl> <https://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in> and <https://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>.

NIB Code : AVV2627A0022, UBN Code : AVV2627SL0800037
Raj.Samwad/C/26/4252 Superintending Engineer (M & P)

The Brihanmumbai Electric Supply & Transport Undertaking
(OF THE BRIHANMUMBAI MAHANAGARPALIKA)

TENDER NOTICE

E-tenders are invited for the supply of following items.

(1) 81803 - 1.1KV, Aluminium Conductor XLPE Cables of various sizes,

Re – invited e-tenders

(2) 81418.

Note: For more details, log on to website <https://mahatenders.gov.in>

PRO/AAM(M)/30/2026 GENERAL MANAGER

DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE
Commissionerate of Agriculture,
Sheshadri Road, Bengaluru – 560001
No.: DDA(F&M)/MNR/INM/Re/e-RfP/2026-27 Date: 06.06.2026

e-REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL (RfP) NOTIFICATION

The Technical and Financial Proposals are invited through GoK e-procurement portal from the registered Manufacturers/ Authorized distributors for Green Manure seed Pillepesaru (Phaseolus trilobus), Dolomite and Potash Derived from Rhodophytes required for various Departmental programmes for the year 2026-27. These Agricultural inputs are required for supply to farmers under different schemes of the Department.

Short Term Re-REQUEST for PROPOSAL (RfP) document is available in the e-Procurement website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>. Suppliers must be accompanied by a Common Earnest Money Deposit (CEMD) for an amount of Rs.50,000/- which should be paid online through e-Procurement portal using any of the following payment modes : Credit Card-Visa or Master card, Debit card-Visa or Master card, Internet banking and offline payments through Remittance at the Bank counter using challan, National Electronic Fund Transfer (NEFT/RTGS). The Applicant has to further submit a Performance Bank Guarantee as per the Technical Proposals submitted along with the Copy of the documents uploaded, one day before or on the day of opening of technical proposal to “Deputy Director of Agriculture (Fertilizer and Manure), Commissionerate of Agriculture, Sheshadri Road, Bangalore”.

Suppliers should upload the documents through e-Procurement website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> on or before **22.06.2026** within **05:00 P.M.** The hard copies of the documents which are not uploaded online through e-procurement portal will not be accepted. The Proposal Scrutinizing Committee will open the Technical Proposal on **24.06.2026 at 11:00 AM** at Samruddhi Conference Hall, Department of Agriculture, Sheshadri Road, Bangalore – 560 001. The date of Financial Proposal opening will be communicated later. Estimated value of the RfP is approximately Rs.2.50 Crore.

DIPR/CP/ILC/998/2026-27 **Sd/-, Director of Agriculture**

US Senate OKs \$70-bn ICE fund; no ban on payout for Trump allies

Some Senate Republicans seek amendments to end funding

Nolan D McCaskill, Richard Cowan & David Morgan
Washington, June 5

THE US Senate handed President Donald Trump a victory early Friday morning, passing a bill that would provide the Department of Homeland Security an additional \$70 billion for immigration enforcement and sending it to the House of Representatives for final consideration. The Senate voted 52-47 to approve the legislation, with no support from Democrats and no provision to ban a \$1.8 billion “anti-weaponization” fund that could compensate Trump’s political allies for allegations that the government mistreated them.

One Republican, Senator Lisa Murkowski, voted against the bill. Senate Republican Leader John Thune said the fund was a “settled issue,” citing acting Attorney General Todd Blanche’s congressional testimony this week that the Depart-



Renovation work underway at the Lincoln Memorial Reflecting Pool in Washington, Friday. AP

ment of Justice would not move forward with it, though Democrats have said his word was insufficient. Trump subsequently said he intended to nominate Blanche to lead the Justice De-

E. EXPLAINED

Action, reaction

A number of recent actions by Trump have prompted open criticism from some Republicans, from seeking \$1 billion in taxpayer funding for a White House ballroom and security upgrades to his decision to nominate Todd Blanche as attorney general and name political ally Bill Pulte as US intelligence chief.

partment. It would need Senate confirmation.

Trump himself Wednesday said the establishment of the fund was important. Republicans have accused Democrats of “defunding” ICE and Border Patrol, despite the agencies having a combined \$100 billion in unspent funds part of a larger DHS spending package enacted last year by Republicans, who control Congress.

The House is not expected to take up the measure before next week. During the long debate Thursday, Senators also argued on provisions making it illegal for federal dollars to be used for

the “anti-weaponization” fund. None of those amendments were approved. The funding provided by the bill would help pay for Trump’s controversial migrant deportation crackdown over the next three years.

An initial move by Senate Democratic Leader Chuck Schumer to kill the “anti-weaponization” fund, which Democrats call a “slush fund” for Trump’s allies, brought the session to a largely procedural halt for hours after Republican Senator Susan Collins voted for the motion. She was later joined by fellow Republicans Jon Husted and Dan Sullivan.

Schumer’s measure failed in a 50-49 vote but exposed the political turmoil among rank-and-file Senate Republicans. Some of them sought their own amendments to eliminate the fund permanently, five months before the November midterm.

“Republicans refused to permanently outlaw Trump’s \$2 billion slush fund, leaving taxpayers to rely on nothing more than a promise from Donald Trump’s personal fixer,” Schumer said in a statement after the final vote, referring to Blanche. The fund has already been put on hold by the White House and Justice Department. **REUTERS**

U.S. FORCES BOARD TANKER, IRAN FIRES WARNING SHOTS

Wider peace deal in doubt: Iran supports Hezbollah as Israel keeps up its strikes

Ahmed Elimam & Jana Choukair
Dubai, June 5

IRAN HAS reaffirmed support for its Lebanese ally Hezbollah and demanded that Israel withdraw from southern Lebanon, underscoring complications facing an interim deal to end the broader conflict between the US and Iran. Tehran has made a ceasefire between Israel and Hezbollah a condition for any peace deal with Washington to resolve the regional war, and restart shipping through the Strait of Hormuz.

“This war will end only when it ends in Lebanon as well,” Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi told Lebanese TV station Al Mayadeen late Thursday.

“The end of the war on Lebanon must be accompanied by the withdrawal of Israeli forces from the territories they have occupied,” he said. The comments came after Hezbollah leader Naim Qassem rejected a US-brokered pact between Israel and the Lebanese government to halt the fighting in Lebanon. The deal did not provide for an Israeli withdrawal and Hezbollah had not been party to the negotiations. Israel has kept up strikes in southern Lebanon, and has said its forces would not withdraw or halt operations in the country amid increasing friction with the U.S.

Hezbollah said Friday it had carried out two attacks on Israeli troops in south Lebanon, including near the recently captured Beaufort Castle.

Mohsen Rezaei, an adviser to Iran’s supreme leader, said Hezbollah had “made great sacrifices in the recent war and it is our ally. Therefore, we support Hezbollah and remain firmly



Spanish UN peacekeepers in Dibbine village, southeast Lebanon. AP

IRAN USING LEBANON AS BARGAINING CHIP IN U.S. NEGOTIATIONS: PRESIDENT AOUN

LEBANESE PRESIDENT Joseph Aoun accused Iran of using Lebanon as a bargaining chip in its negotiations with the US Friday, in some of his toughest criticism yet of Tehran and its Lebanese ally Hezbollah as it wages war with Israel. In a *CNN* interview, Aoun said, “the people of Lebanon are paying the price... for the sake” of Iran’s interests, and were “fed up” with war between Israel and Hezbollah — comments reflecting deep divisions along Lebanon’s

confessional and political fault-lines. “They are using Lebanon as a bargaining chip in their negotiation with the US,” Aoun said of Iran, according to excerpts of the interview published on the *CNN* website. “It’s unacceptable.” Iran has made a Lebanon ceasefire a condition for any peace deal with Washington in the wider regional conflict that began with the US-Israeli attack on Tehran on February 28. On Thursday, Hezbollah rejected a ceasefire plan. **REUTERS**

Macron, Merz and Starmer to meet Zelenskyy in London tomorrow

Reuters
Paris, June 5

FRENCH PRESIDENT Emmanuel Macron, British Prime Minister Keir Starmer and German Chancellor Friedrich Merz will hold talks with Ukraine’s President Volodymyr Zelenskyy Sunday, the Elysee said in a statement.

“This meeting will allow them to continue their close coordination on our shared agenda of continuing support for Ukraine and increasing pressure on Russia’s war effort,” the statement said. “Russia is facing military, economic, and strategic failure — and persists, unsuccessfully, on the front lines in a deadly war.”

Meeting is due to take place in London.

Zelenskyy wants European leaders to step up efforts to help bring an end to the Ukraine war. Macron said Friday: “We have always advocated for direct negotiations between Ukraine and the Kremlin... I think it is Ukraine and Russia who can build both a ceasefire and a peace plan. It is the Europeans who can help with this.”

In Montenegro, Merz said “we are open to dialogue, what is missing is Putin’s willingness.”

US House backs Russia sanctions, Ukraine aid

Washington: The US House of Representatives passed legislation Thursday to provide aid to Ukraine and impose new sanctions on Russia, the latest sign some Republicans are willing to defy party leaders and push back on President Trump. The House voted 226 to 195 for Ukraine Support Act. **REUTERS**

‘Age starting to take its toll’: Zelenskyy mixes taunts and peace talks offer in letter to Putin

The New York Times
Kyiv, June 5

ON THE heels of a flurry of Ukrainian drone strikes deep in Russia and recent shifts in Ukraine’s favour on the battlefield, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy published Thursday an open letter to President Vladimir Putin.

The letter, posted on the Ukrainian president’s website, offered to resume peace talks — but taunted the Russian leader over wartime setbacks, inflation and Russia’s dependence on China. It also made note of Putin’s advancing age.

Though addressed to Putin, the open letter seemed intended as well for Trump’s attention.

Zelenskyy has at various points in the war recorded video statements addressing Putin or the Russian people, including on the first day of Moscow’s invasion in 2022. This letter was among the most scathing direct addresses to Putin so far.

Zelenskyy noted that Putin



Zelenskyy suggested including European nations and holding a leaders’ meeting in Switzerland, Turkey or an Arab nation.

has by now spent about half of his 26 years in power as Russia’s paramount leader fighting Ukraine. The timeline counts the Russian military intervention in eastern Ukraine that began in 2014 and the full-scale invasion launched in 2022.

He offered a ceasefire if Putin wanted one. Zelenskyy said he would meet for direct talks outside the Trump administration’s

NO REASON TO MEET ZELENSKYY: PUTIN

RUSSIAN PRESIDENT Vladimir Putin said Friday he currently saw no reason to meet Volodymyr Zelenskyy after the Ukrainian president published an open letter proposing they hold face-to-face talks to agree an end to the war. The Kremlin chief said Zelenskyy’s letter was rude in parts and did not come across as a sincere offer to hold talks. “This letter contains some rather rude remarks. Was it a way to create the conditions for a face-to-face meet or a way not to set up a face-to-face meeting? I



Russian President Vladimir Putin

think it was the second,” said Putin. Asked whether he would meet the Ukrainian leader, Putin said: “I don’t see any point for now.” **REUTERS**

After leak aboard ISS sealed, NASA reverses evacuation alert

Washington: A worsening air leak aboard the ISS prompted five astronauts to take shelter and prepare for evacuation for roughly two hours Friday as Russia attempted to fix a crack on its portion of the orbital laboratory, NASA said.

The four astronauts of NASA’s Crew-12 mission aboard the station — two Americans, a French astronaut and a Russian cosmonaut — along with another US astronaut were ordered by NASA mission control Friday to enter their SpaceX-built Crew Dragon spacecraft docked to the station, NASA spokesperson Bethany Stevens said.

NASA reversed that order roughly two hours later and told the astronauts they could return to the station as the agency and its Russian counterparts examined the rate of leaking air.

Roscosmos said Friday its experts had detected two leaks aboard the ISS but there was no immediate threat to the crew. The first leak was quickly sealed, and preparations were underway to seal the second one, Roscosmos said, adding there was no threat to the spacecraft’s systems. **REUTERS**

Former Prince Andrew sublet cottages on his rent-free estate: Report

Associated Press
London, June 5

THE FORMER Prince Andrew made money by subletting three cottages on the estate where he lived rent-free for two decades, according to a report on the royal family’s properties released Friday by the UK public spending watchdog.

The National Audit Office report said Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor received income from renting out the cot-

tages on the Royal Lodge estate, his home near Windsor Castle for more than 20 years.

A lease for Royal Lodge signed in 2003 shows he paid only a nominal fee, known as a “peppercorn rent”, for the property, which included a 30-room mansion and 8 cottages, three of which he was allowed to sublet. The income was not included in the report, an omission that Margaret Hodge, a Labour member of the House of Lords, said was concerning.

In bid to counter Russia influence, Xi to visit N Korea to deepen ties

Reuters
Beijing, Seoul, June 5

CHINA SAID Friday President Xi Jinping would visit North Korea on a two-day trip from June 8, his first in nearly seven years as Beijing looks to reassert ties with Pyongyang, its only formal treaty ally. Xi will meet North Korean leader Kim Jong Un, China’s foreign ministry said.

Beijing has worked to draw Pyongyang back into its fold after the pandemic froze ex-

changes and Kim deepened ties with Moscow by sending troops and weapons to support Russia’s invasion of Ukraine.

“The message implicit from the Chinese side is... we are still the principal actor when it comes to North Korea,” said John Delury, a senior fellow of the Asia Society. “One of the audiences is Russia.” Last month, Xi held talks with US President Donald Trump and Russian President Vladimir Putin in Beijing.

• MANY OF THESE WORKERS HAVE LIVED THROUGH PERIODS OF INSTABILITY BEFORE — DEBT, UNEMPLOYMENT, POLITICAL UNREST AND CLIMATE DISASTERS

‘At home, who’ll pay as much?’ In Dubai migrants’ stressed lives, war one more worry

The New York Times
Dubai

ON A recent Sunday morning, Laxmi Parekh stood under a low ceiling of flickering tube lights in the cafeteria of a housing compound in Dubai and faced an audience of painters, carpenters and electricians, tasked with teaching stress management.

“Who knows what’s been going on here for the past 43 days?” Parekh, 59, who volunteers with a nonprofit organization called SmartLife, asked the group of men.

“War situation,” someone in the front shouted.

Since the US-Israeli war with Iran began on February 28, Iran

has fired more missiles and drones toward the UAE than any other country, resulting in the deaths of at least 10 civilians, according to UAE defense ministry. Most of those affected were migrant workers, like those gathered in the spartan cafeteria, where steel plates and spoons clanked as Parekh spoke.

Parekh has been running these weekly mental health workshops across Dubai’s migrant-worker dormitories for the past two years. Outside her day job as an information technology professional, Parekh gives her time to SmartLife, which organizes free English-speaking lessons, mentorship programmes and game nights in city’s



Laxmi Parekh has been running mental health workshops for Dubai’s migrant workers for the past two years. NYT

blue-collar migrant communities. It gets much of its financial support from the companies that employ the workers and the

money transfer firms that help remit their income home.

In March, as the regional conflict intensified, Parekh

began adjusting her sessions to include discussion of it. “How many of you are scared?” she asked the gathered 40 or so men, many from India, Pakistan and Nepal. The room burst into protest — a boisterous chorus of denial, awkward laughter and overlapping voices. “Not for a minute,” one man said. “You cannot let fear control you,” another said. “Scared of what?”

Many of these workers have lived through instability before — debt, unemployment, political unrest and climate disasters. The fallout from the war was just one more stressor in lives already filled with them.

In her sessions, Parekh tries to offer tips for coping: steady

breathing during air raid sirens, maintaining daily routines and speaking calmly to anxious families back home. “Yes, we will hear sounds, shrapnel will fall somewhere, you may see smoke,” Parekh said. “But think of it like a Hindi film — a bad guy’s bullet is stopped by a good guy’s bullet. The same thing is happening in our skies.”

Since the first day of the conflict, when he had seen a fireball bloom in the sky after a missile was intercepted above him on his weekly grocery run, Ramapathi Sharma, 48, a carpenter from Uttar Pradesh’s Gorakhpur, said he had struggled to sleep.

He would lie awake with thoughts of his three children,

his youngest son in ninth grade, and the promise he had made to his dying brother to look after his family, too. Now and then, the low rumble of fighter jets circling overhead would press down in waves. The booms would rattle the room’s windows, followed by the frantic screeching of birds.

“Of course I am scared,” Sharma said. But his fear was less about what could happen to him and more about what could happen to those who depend on him. He turned to his friend of two decades, Gopal Sharma, 47, from Siwan, a foreman in the same company. “If something happens to us here,” he asked, “how will our families survive?”

“The real question, brother,”

Gopal Sharma, who is not related to Ramapathi Sharma, replied. “Is that even if we go home, who will give us work that pays as much as we get here?”

Untold numbers of migrant workers across the UAE were making similar calculations: No matter how bad the fighting might get, could they afford to leave?

Around 2.2 million blue-collar workers, largely from South Asia and Africa, account for the majority of expatriates, who in turn, form over 80% of the population. And however hard the work, or long the hours — or number of missiles that fall — workers can make far more here than at home.

The Big Picture

SATURDAY, JUNE 6, 2026

15



A neighbourhood called HAUZ RANI

THERE IS something about the way Mohammad observes the action unfolding beyond the police tape that reminds you of *Peepli Live*, the 2010 satire on the media circus that typically follows big news events. In front of charred buildings are multiple TV reporters talking into cameras, with OB vans just out of sight. They are shrill in their demands for accountability, for the arrest and prosecution of Lavkesh Bajaj, the proprietor of Flourish, the bread and breakfast facility in Delhi's Hauz Rani neighbourhood where at least 21 people died on June 3 in one of the worst fire incidents in the national Capital.

"*Dekhbe dada* (Brother, you will see), in a day or two, things will go back to normal... the government will make a noise for a bit, but there are just too many people who need a place to stay. Where will they all go?" says Mohammad, who doesn't want his full name revealed.

In his mid-30s, he is both a local and an outsider to Hauz Rani. From West Bengal, he has lived and worked in the neighbourhood as an odd-job man for over two decades. As he takes a deep sip of his *chai*, you can sense an almost sardonic sense of resignation in him. He speaks of both the fire and the fact that he has had to change homes multiple times because of rising rents and the political conversations around Bengali Muslims with the same detachment, even humour.

The tragedy is on everyone's lips in the few square kilometres where the layers of Delhi — in all their beauty, complexity and sadness — sit together.

Hauz Rani is one of Delhi's several urban villages, '*Lal Dora*' colonies that sit uncomfortably between the realities of a burgeoning demand for land and space, and municipal laws and rules.

In the days after the yellow tape at the end of the lane is removed, the neighbourhood, with all its fault lines and sharp edges, will be back. The broken sewage lines, the buildings that jostle for space, the tangled electricity wires that pretend to be the sky — all of which come up when the city, or a part of it, grows and no one has time to plan for it. Hauz Rani could be any urban neighbourhood in India: in the headlines for the fire, and then forgotten as residents return to living with the conditions that made it possible.

'They all need a place to stay'

Hauz Rani's origins are almost mythical: About 800 years ago, it was a *haуз* or bath house for a queen forgotten to history, and a village emerged around it. Over years, post-Independence, the agricultural land was acquired by the government, while the residential areas were not.

A DDA sports complex is a street away, and upper-middle-class colonies such as Press Enclave, Ekta Apartments and Golf View Apartments are across the road, in Saket. In recent years, the massive Saket malls and the Max Super Speciality Hospital have made the difference between the two sides of the street all the more stark. The hotel that burnt down was once a Khadi Bhandar, where people bought clothes and other trinkets. The basement, where the fire broke out, was a photocopy

Days after one of the deadliest fires in Delhi left 21 dead, AAKASH JOSHI visits Hauz Rani, the neighbourhood whose eateries, guest houses and small hotels served the needs of a growing city, yet lay largely forgotten. The tragedy may have brought the focus back, but not for too long



(Top) Outside Flourish B&B, a day after the fire; Hauz Rani is across the street from the more affluent Saket. ABHINAV SAHA

shop that serviced the neighbourhood.

"It's with the expansion of Max Hospital that construction exploded in Hauz Rani," says Rinku Awasthi, owner of Rinku Beauty Parlour, about 30 metres from the site of the fire. For much of the three decades that she has run her establishment, "there was a connection between the Saket colonies and our lane. Many of my clients came from there".

But as Hauz Rani became more diverse, it also became more closed off. "As more and more Nigerians, Somalians and people from Central Asia came to get treatment at Max, people here began opening guest houses and building extra floors. But then, it got crowded and my older clients from Saket don't come any more. There were more barricades, less municipal attention as well. Buildings grew, but sewer lines didn't. The point is, the hospital expanded, but no one planned for the extra people that would bring... they all need a place to stay, don't they?" says Awasthi.

The demands for accountability, for heads to roll, are well taken by those in Hauz Rani, who are shaken by the fire and the deaths many of them witnessed first-hand. But there is also an undercurrent of fear.

Sharib, a carpenter's apprentice, puts it bluntly: "Delhi's home minister has said shut all hotels that don't have permission... Next, they will come after us, some of us more than others. Who are the people who work here, or even the people who died? Workers, people who have come from far away for medical treatment and can't afford fancy hotels? If there hadn't been the

fire, no one would care about these hotels... Do you think the government didn't know about this before?"

Sharib's questions do not have easy answers. After those responsible for this fire are held accountable, what will it take to ensure that the underlying problems are fixed?

The neighbourhood, its twin

"There is a symbiotic relationship between the planned and unplanned in our cities," says Amita Baviskar, Professor of Environmental Studies and Sociology & Anthropology at Ashoka University. "For every Saket, there is a Hauz Rani; for Delhi University, there's Mukherjee Nagar; for JNU and the middle-class colonies around it, Katwaria Sarai, etc... The 'legal' part of the city has an 'illegal' evil twin where the service class stays. Often, the older areas of Delhi, the villages, are repurposed to meet this need."

Onyinye, 23, is reluctant at first to talk about the conditions in Hauz Rani and neighbouring Khirki village, as are many of his compatriots from Nigeria who are sitting at a tea shop opposite Max Hospital's East Wing. He opens up, finally, when the phrase "medical tourist" comes up. He de- tests it. "I am not a tourist, nor an immigrant. We are here because my mother's disease could not be treated back home, and we cannot afford to go to the West." He has been staying in a hotel much like the one that went up in flames because "that's where our agent suggested". He shudders

visibly at the thought that he could just as easily have been a guest at Flourish B&B, that he likely passed some of the dead in the hospital corridors or sat next to them at a restaurant. "We are paying for medical treatment and need to be close to the hospital. What choice do we have? It's not like they are giving us rooms for free."

Hotels are not the only cogs in this new economy. The only shop open in the otherwise shuttered lane where Flourish B&B stood is Priya Chemist. M Shoken, a customer, recalls how he was woken up by his son and had rushed out as the fire began to roar. He was staying at Lemon Green Hotel next door. In town from Dhaka to get treatment for a heart ailment at Max, he is stocking up on the medicines.

His face wrinkles as he swipes his card for Rs 43,302. "It's still cheaper than going outside South Asia," he remarks. The hotel he stayed at was "decent enough" for Rs 3,500 a night, and only slightly above budget, and there were other Bangladeshis in the area for treatment.

At 64, Shailendra Tilak has seen many customers pause at their medical bills in his 47 years behind the counter. He assures him of the quality of the medicines. "There's a lot that has changed over the last few years," Tilak says. "My old customers from Saket still come here, and I deliver medicines home for many of them. More and more, though, people are ordering regular medicines online, searching for the cheapest deal from apps. The overflow from Max has

helped make up the shortfall."

The severed relationship with "across the road" is a refrain heard often from shopkeepers and workers across Hauz Rani. "There was a time when so much of our lives were there, in Hauz Rani," recalls Nikhil Deshpande, a 46-year-old filmmaker who grew up in Press Enclave and moved back just before the pandemic. "The small gate was open, and before getting on the school bus, we would grab a chocolate from the local store. Now, Press Enclave has only one gate that opens onto the main road; the rest were gradually closed."

Menaka Neotia, Nikhil's wife, who works in conflict management, remembers the difference between when the couple lived in Hauz Rani for four years up to 2018, and now. "The hotel that caught fire is at the same distance from here as our old front door. But if I were there, I know I would have rushed down to see what happened, to check in with Mahadev and his son Rahul, whom I chatted with every day as I bought vegetables. Here in Saket, my privilege means I can be in a bubble."

That bubble, though, may well be an illusion.

"The existence of places like Hauz Rani, or Saidulajab abutting Saket, where six people were killed in a building collapse on May 30, is a structural necessity in a city like Delhi," says Ekta Chauhan, Assistant Professor, Jindal School of Art and Architecture and author of *Sheher Mein Gaon*.

"What we need, however, is a larger conversation about how these spaces are so essential to the city... The expanded homes, small eateries and hotels serve a growing working and service class population that makes the malls, hospitals and posh homes run." On the other hand, she says, "if we just continue construction as is happening right now, then you're putting safety at risk... that's the dilemma."

The solution, if there can be one, must be radical, according to architect and urban planner Ashok Lall. "The imagination of Delhi, in Masterplan after Masterplan, has been of a middle-class city, with no thought to a growing population that does not belong to this section."

"What has made matters worse in the last few years is a government and planning mindset that sees land as an asset through which the city can enrich itself. The value of the land is determined by how much you can build on it, and the taxes on the increased value make the city's income go up. But this has left half the population behind." What's needed, according to Lall, is to view land as a lever for development. "Developmental planning, like in Singapore or Amsterdam," could be the answer, "where the state plays a greater role in determining value and allocating space for affordable housing in a manner that people don't have to choose between location and safety and environment."

Mohammad, though, will be cynical about any such radical change in governance. As he gives directions to Flourish Inn & Guest House, another hotel reportedly owned by Bajaj, he is sure it will be empty today, and perhaps filled with guests next week. "Even if they demolish it, there will be 10 more close by. People need what they need, and governments just need votes."

कार्यपालक अभियन्ता का कार्यालय
(नगर विकास प्रमंडल, जलापूर्ति)
पटना नगर निगम क्षेत्र, पटना

फ्लैट नं०-K-2, नियर पुनाईचक पार्क, न्यू पुनाईचक पटना-800023।
मो:- **9973964055 / 8527230960**, मेल:- **watersupplysectionpmc@gmail.com**
निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या- **14/E/WSO/PMC/2026**
(ई-टेंडरिंग द्वारा www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)

- विज्ञापनदाता का पदनाम एवं पता : कार्यपालक अभियन्ता, नगर विकास प्रमंडल, जलापूर्ति पटना नगर निगम क्षेत्र, पटना फ्लैट नं०-K-2, नियर पुनाईचक पार्क, न्यू पुनाईचक पटना-800023
- निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना निर्गत की तिथि : दिनांक-03.06.2026
- परिमाण विषय प्राप्त करने की तिथि एवं समय : दिनांक-20.06.2026 समय 12:00 बजे अपराह्न तक। (www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
- ग्री-बीड मीटिंग की तिथि, समय एवं स्थान : दिनांक-22.06.2026 समय 12:00 बजे अपराह्न तक। (www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
- संवेदक द्वारा निविदा अपलोड करने की अंतिम तिथि/समय : दिनांक-27.06.2026 को समय 03:00 बजे अपराह्न। (www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
- तकनीकी बीड खोलने की तिथि : दिनांक-27.06.2026 को समय 03:30 बजे अपराह्न। (www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
- वित्तीय बीड खोलने की तिथि : तकनीकी बीड में सफल होने के उपरान्त निर्देशानुसार
- कार्य की विवरणी :-

क्र/पृष्ठ सं.	कार्य का नाम	प्राक्कलित राशि (रु. में)	अग्रपत्र (Online के माध्यम से) Website:- www.Eproc2.bihar.gov.in	परिमाण विवरण का मूल्य (Online के माध्यम से) Website:- www.Eproc2.bihar.gov.in	Bid Processing Fee (Through Online Payment हेतु प्रोसेसिंग शुल्क)	कार्य समाप्ति की अवधि
1	Construction of High Yield Tube Well at Kila Road in Revenue Clerk office Campus in Ward No. 67	1,35,74,000.00	2,71,500.00	10,000.00	3,540.00	6 Months
2	Construction of High Yield Tube Well at West of Badi Bagicha Railway line Bhaiani Tola in Ward No. 69	1,35,74,000.00	2,71,500.00	10,000.00	3,540.00	6 Months
3	Construction of High Yield Tube Well at Patel Nagar in Urja Park in Ward No. 07	1,35,74,000.00	2,71,500.00	10,000.00	3,540.00	6 Months
4	Construction of High Yield Tube Well at Choumin Factory, Tilak Nagar More Ruknपुरा in Ward No. 02	1,35,74,000.00	2,71,500.00	10,000.00	3,540.00	6 Months
5	Construction of High Yield Tube Well at East Gate of Azimabad Office in Ward No. 57	1,35,74,000.00	2,71,500.00	10,000.00	3,540.00	6 Months
6	Construction of High Yield Tube Well at Vidyapati Marg, Kath Pul Mandir Road beside of Wall of Art Collage in Ward No. 27	1,35,74,000.00	2,71,500.00	10,000.00	3,540.00	6 Months
7	Construction of High Yield Tube Well at Sri Krishna Nagar Behind of SBI in Ward No. 25	1,35,73,400.00	2,71,500.00	10,000.00	3,540.00	6 Months
8	Construction of High Yield Tube Well at Telegraph Colony near Flipkart office in Ward No. 26	1,35,73,400.00	2,71,500.00	10,000.00	3,540.00	6 Months

नोट :- Bidders Should submit Bid Processing free through Online Payment as per Amount generated on website www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in

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कार्यपालक अभियन्ता
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पटना नगर निगम क्षेत्र, पटना
PR- 005055 (B & C) 2026-27
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नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार

OFFICE OF THE ENGINEER IN CHIEF PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT NAVA RAIPUR, ATAL NAGAR (CENTRAL TENDER CELL) E-Procurement Tender Notice Main Portal: <https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in>

Tenders are invited for the Following works:-

S. NO.	System Tender No./ Date	Name of Work	PAC Amount (Rupees in lacs)
1	191740 Second Call 27.05.2026	Construction of Sodhe to Gattapara Road Length 2.10 km. i/c Culverts and Bridge.	244.94
2	191741 Second Call 27.05.2026	Construction of Aamkot to Dutapipali Road Length 2.65 km. i/c Culverts and Bridge.	291.38
3	191684 First Call 29.05.2026	CONSTRUCTION OF HIGH-LEVEL BRIDGE I/C APPROACH ROAD ACROSS KOKIYA NALLA ON KUMHARBAHAR TO KONPARA ROAD.	296.04
4	191807 First Call 29.05.2026	CONSTRUCTION OF H.L BRIDGE I/C APPROACH ROAD ACROSS IBB RIVER ON THETHETANGAR TO CHONGRIBAHAR ROAD.	1104.12
5	191679 First Call 29.05.2026	Construction of Lecture Hall & Examination Hall (G + 3) at Medical College & Hospital Dimrapal Jagdalpur Ditt. Bastar (Work Code 1907920120250095) (Deposit work-without escalation and bonus).	626.37
6	191854 First Call 29.05.2026	Construction of Jevankanda to Kailash Nagar Road Length 3.40 K.M. including Bridges & Culverts at Block Kawardha (Working Length 2.60 K.M.) Distt.- Kawardha (C.G.).	532.07
7	191858 First Call 29.05.2026	CONSTRUCTION OF NARI BYPASS ROAD, LENGTH = 2.15 KM(2 LANE) I/C. CULVERTS AT UNDER SUB DIVISION KURUD AT DIST. DHAMTARI (DHAMTARI DN.).	701.13
8	191838 First Call 29.05.2026	Construction of Vicharpur to Dhooghathi Approach Road Length 2.00 Km. & D-I Nahar to Dhooghathi Via Lalpurkara Road Length 3.30 Km. Total Length 5.30 Km.	713.08
9	191903 First Call 29.05.2026	Construction of Bhedni Singhori Saldha Road Length 6.920 KM including Bridges & culverts at Distt.- Bemetara (C.G.).	824.54
10	191841 First Call 29.05.2026	Widening & Upgradation Work of Chandulal Chandrakar Govt. Medical College Building to Junwani Kohka- Kurud Main Road Length 2.50 KM i/c Bridges & Culverts at Durg Distt-Durg (C.G.).	630.92
11	191857 Second Call 29.05.2026	Construction of Kotankhod to Niche Kamta Road Length 1.80 km. i/c Culverts and Bridge.	201.71
12	191859 (3rd Call) 29.05.2026	CONSTRUCTION OF HIGH LEVEL BRIDGE I/C APPROACHES ACROSS BHAWARDING RIVER IN KM. 1/3 ON CHANDELA-DHARMABEDA TO AMLIDHAR ROAD.	1274.95
13	191860 Second Call 29.05.2026	Strengthening work of Bhlai Tarra Road (MDR) Length 15.00 K.M including Bridges & culverts Distt. Durg (C.G.).	777.20
14	191861 Second Call 29.05.2026	B.T. RENEWAL WORK OF EXPRESS WAY FROM RAILWAY STATION TO SHADANI DARBAR, RAIPUR LENGTH 12.20 KM(DISTT. RAIPUR).	1442.75
15	191986 First Call 29.05.2026	Construction of Multipurpose Sport Stadium at Mahapali. i/c W.S.S.F. Electrification & Approach Road Works.	459.39
16	191990 First Call 29.05.2026	Upgradation of Charkhapara Saskoba Bandhanpur Road Length 28.80 Km.	3362.68
17	191987 First Call 29.05.2026	Construction of Multipurpose Sport Stadium at Pussoure. i/c W.S.S.F. Electrification & Approach Road Works.	459.39
18	191988 First Call 29.05.2026	Construction of Additional Room at Govt. College Pussoure. i/c W.S.S.F. Electrification Work.	283.50

Last Date of Tender Downloading S.No. 01 To S.No. 02 date 15.06.2026, S.No. 12 date 12.06.2026, S.No. 11, S.No. 13, S.No. 14 date 17.06.2026, S.No. 04 date 24.06.2026. Other Tenders Date are Schedule as date 22.06.2026. For more details on the tender and bidding process please visit the above mentioned portal.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer
(Central Tender Cell)
Office Of Engineer In Chief
NO 262701191/13
P.W.D. Nava Raipur Atal Nagar

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER
RURAL WORKS CIRCLE, ANGUL
25001/319/2627 E-Mail - sencrwangul@yahoo.co.in ☎ 06764-236404

NOTICE INVITING TENDER FOR ROAD WORKS IN ODISHA
Bid Identification No. Road Online AGL- 0812025-26

- Name of the work : Road works
- Total No. of work : 34 Nos.
- Estimated cost : Rs.129.76 to Rs.373.38 Lakhs (Approx.)
- Class of Contractor : As per annexure.
- Period of completion : As per annexure.
- Other details. :

Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No.	Availability of Tender on-line for bidding		Last Date & Time of seeking tender clarification	Date & Time of opening of tender	
		From	To		Technical Bid	Financial Bid
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Chief Construction Engineer, Rural Works Circle,Ansul	Road Online- AGL- 08 /2026-27	10.06.26 at 10.00 A.M	30.06.26 up to 5.00 P.M	29.06.26 upto 1.00 P.M	01.07.26 at 10.00 A.M	Will be intimated separately

For detailed Notice inviting Tenders, Please visit to the website www.tendersorissa.gov.in
OIPR-25001/251801/126-27/0007 Sd/- Chief Construction Engineer, Rural Works Circle, Angul.

बिहार सरकार
नगर निगम, गयाजी
ई-निविदा आमंत्रण की सूचना (ई-टेंडरिंग द्वारा www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
संख्या- NIT No.- 13/2026-27

- विज्ञापनदाता का पदनाम एवं पता : नगर आयुक्त, नगर निगम, गयाजी।
- निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना निर्गत की तिथि - दिनांक- 03.06.2026
- ग्री बीड मीटिंग की तिथि एवं समय एवं स्थान : दिनांक- 19.06.26को समय 11:00 बजे पूर्वाह्न से 05:00 बजे अपराह्न तक।
- परिमाण विषय प्राप्त करने की तिथि एवं समय : दिनांक- 18.06.2026 के 10:00 पूर्वाह्न से (www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
- संवेदक द्वारा निविदा अपलोड करने की अंतिम तिथि : दिनांक-27.06.2026 समय 03:00 बजे अपराह्न तक (www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
- तकनीकी बीड खोलने की तिथि : दिनांक-27.06.2026 समय 03:30 बजे अपराह्न तक
- वित्तीय बीड खोलने की तिथि : तकनीकी बीड में सफल होने के उपरान्त निर्देशानुसार
- कार्य की विवरणी-

क्र०	कार्य का नाम	प्राक्कलित राशि (रु. में)	अग्रपत्र की राशि (online के माध्यम से) Website:- www.Eproc2.bihar.gov.in	परिमाण विवरण का मूल्य (अग्रपत्र के माध्यम से) Website:- www.Eproc2.bihar.gov.in	Bid Processing fee (Through Online Payment हेतु प्रोसेसिंग शुल्क)	कार्य समाप्ति की अवधि
1	नगर निगम गयाजी अन्तर्गत वार्ड संख्या 1 से 11 तक 24 हाई मास्ट लाइटों की आपूर्ति, स्थापना, परीक्षण एवं संचालन का कार्य।	16129000	322580	10000	As per eproc 2.0	3 महीना
2	नगर निगम गयाजी अन्तर्गत वार्ड संख्या 12 से 27 तक 24 हाई मास्ट लाइटों की आपूर्ति, स्थापना, परीक्षण एवं संचालन का कार्य।	16129000	322580	10000	As per eproc 2.0	3 महीना
3	नगर निगम गयाजी अन्तर्गत वार्ड संख्या 28 से 35 तक 26 हाई मास्ट लाइटों की आपूर्ति, स्थापना, परीक्षण एवं संचालन का कार्य।	16801000	336020	10000	As per eproc 2.0	3 महीना
4	नगर निगम गयाजी अन्तर्गत वार्ड संख्या 36 से 46 तक 21 हाई मास्ट लाइटों की आपूर्ति, स्थापना, परीक्षण एवं संचालन का कार्य।	14113000	282260	10000	As per eproc 2.0	3 महीना
5	नगर निगम गयाजी अन्तर्गत वार्ड संख्या 47 से 53 एवं अन्य स्थान तक 26 हाई मास्ट लाइटों की आपूर्ति, स्थापना, परीक्षण एवं संचालन का कार्य।	17473000	349460	10000	As per eproc 2.0	3 महीना

9. नोट:- Bidders Should submit Bid Processing fee through Online Payment as per Amount generated on Website www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in

12. विरल निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना विभागीय वेबसाइट www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in अथवा state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar में देखा जा सकता है।

PR- 005028 (B & C) 2026-27
नगरी की मार, बर्बाद करे सुखी परिवार।
नगर आयुक्त,
नगर निगम, गयाजी।

बिहार शहरी आधारभूत संरचना विकास निगम लि, पटना
(बिहार सरकार का एक उपक्रम)
परिचमी बोरिंग कैनाल रोड, नजदीक राजापुर पुल, पटना-800001
फोन नं.-0612-2558412 वेबसाइट- <http://buidco.in>

नियोजन हेतु विज्ञापन
No. BUIDCO/गलन-82 / 2025 -41

बिहार शहरी आधारभूत संरचना विकास निगम लि, बिहार (जो पूर्णतः बिहार सरकार का एक उपक्रम है) निम्नांकित पदों के लिए प्रतिनियुक्ति, सविदा/अनुबंध पर नियोजन हेतु आवेदन आमंत्रित करता है-

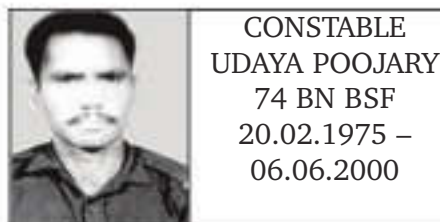
क्र.	पद का नाम	अर्हता	कुल पद	आव्रण कोट	आव्रणित उम्र सीमा (18- 01.01.2026 को)	देख/विल पाठित/कित प्रति सह
1.	प्रबंधक (फिन) (Finance)	CA/CWA with minimum 03 years of relevant experience.	02 (दो)	अन्योन्य-01 अनुभूति वित्त - 01	बिहार सरकार द्वारा निर्धारित उम्र-सीमा के अनुसार - 37 वर्ष अनवरति (महिला) - 40 वर्ष शिक्षा बत.अवधि शिक्षा बत. (एडु.मो)- 40 वर्ष अनुभूति वित्त [10.00]- 42 वर्ष	सेक्टर/अनुभव पर प्रतिक्रिया देना

सामान्य निर्देश :-

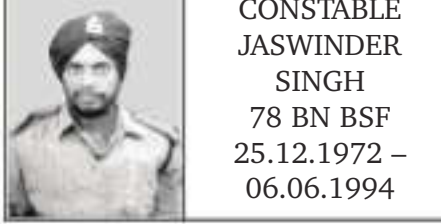
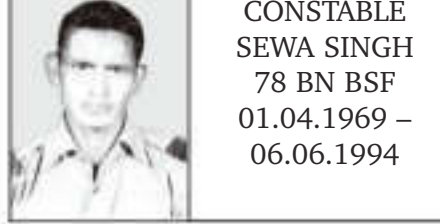
- आवेदित पद का नाम लिफाफे के ऊपरी हिस्से पर स्पष्ट और लिखा होना चाहिए।
- उक्त सभी पद व्यवसाय निबंध (नन प्रेजेंटिंग) है।
- राज्य और केन्द्र सरकार द्वारा प्रायोजित बाह्य परियोजनाओं पर कार्य किए हुए व्यक्तियों को प्राथमिकता दी जाएगी।
- बिहार शहरी आधारभूत संरचना विकास निगम लि में उक्त पदों पर सविदा/अनुबंध पर नियोजित होने के बाद किसी अन्य संस्था/कार्यालय/स्थान पर अपनी सेवा देना वर्जित होगा।
- अनुबंध की अवधि एक वर्ष की होगी जो बाद में कार्य मूल्यांकन के आधार पर बढ़ाई जा सकती है।
- विरल जानकारी एवं आवेदन पत्र का प्रारूप बुझको के [website](http://buidco.in) : <http://buidco.in> dss Career Option से प्राप्त किया जा सकता है।
- आवेदन पत्र के साथ दो फोटोग्राफ, स्वअभिप्रेक्षापत्र शैक्षणिक योग्यता का प्रमाण-पत्र, अनुभव प्रमाण-पत्र, उम्र प्रमाण पत्र, दो स्वपता लिखा (25 X 10 सेमी/गो) लिफाफा, जिस पर 41-41 रु० का डाक टिकट खराद हो, संलग्न कर भेजना होगा। पूर्ण रूप से भरा हुआ आवेदन पत्र सिर्फ निर्धारित विहित प्रपत्र में **Bihar Urban Infrastructure Development Corporation Ltd (BUIDCO), # West Boring Canal Road, Near Rajapur Pul, Patna- 800001** के पते पर दिनांक- 30.06.2026 को 05.00 बजे अपराह्न तक अवश्य प्राप्त हो जाना चाहिए।
- पूर्ण रूप से भरा हुआ आवेदन सिर्फ रजिस्टर्ड डाक/स्पीड-पोस्ट द्वारा ही स्वीकार किया जायेगा।
- आवेदन शुल्क- गैर आरक्षित, अयोग्य, पिछड़ा वर्ग के उम्मीदवार हेतु रुपये 500/- एवं अनुसूचित जाति, अनुसूचित जनजाति के उम्मीदवार हेतु रुपये 250/- का राष्ट्रीय बैंक का बैंक ड्राफ्ट, जो प्रबंध निदेशक, बुझको के नाम मुद्रित होना आवेदन के साथ मूलरूप में संलग्न करना अनिवार्य होगा। यह **Non Refundable** होगा।
- अपूर्ण आवेदन पत्र अथवा वैसा आवेदन जिनमें ऑफिस पूर्ण रूप से भरे नहीं गये हों अथवा योग्यता/अनुभव प्रमाण पत्र संलग्न या स्वअभिप्रेक्षापत्र नहीं हो वेसे आवेदनों पर विचार नहीं किया जायेगा।
- प्रबंध निदेशक, BUIDCO के पास यह अधिकार सुरक्षित होगा कि उपरोक्त पद के लिए दिये गए आवेदन को वे बिना कारण बताए निरस्त कर सकते हैं एवं परिस्थिति विशेष में नियोजन की प्रक्रिया स्थगित अथवा रद्द कर सकते हैं।
- निर्धारित शैक्षणिक योग्यता न्यूनतम है एवं इसका यह मतलब नहीं होगा कि निर्धारित न्यूनतम योग्यताधारी सभी आवेदकों को बुलाया पत्र (Call Letter) भेजा जायेगा। BUIDCO के पास निर्धारित मानदण्डों के आधार पर आवेदन पत्रों की संवीक्षा का अधिकार सुरक्षित रहेगा।
- उत्थार शैक्षणिक योग्यता एवं संबंधित कार्यक्षेत्र के अनुभव प्राप्त आवेदकों को प्राथमिकता दी जाएगी।
- यदि शैक्षणिक योग्यता एवं अनुभव संबंधी प्रमाण पत्र गलत, अथवा अथवा फर्जी पाया जाता है तो न केवल नियोजन उपरांत उनका अनुबंध रद्द किया जायेगा अपितु उनके विरुद्ध आपराधिक मामला भी दर्ज किया जायेगा तथा मानदण्ड सहित सभी प्रकार का भ्रष्टान, जो बुझको द्वारा किया गया है, उसकी वसुली भी की जायेगी।
- इस आशय का शपथ पत्र आवेदन के साथ मूल रूप में संलग्न करना अनिवार्य होगा कि संबंधित को किसी तरह का भ्रष्टाचार/भ्रष्टाचार के किसी अपराध में विधि न्यायालय द्वारा दोषी नहीं ठहराया गया है एवं उनके विरुद्ध विधि न्यायालय में वर्तमान में कोई आपराधिक कार्यवाही/मामला नहीं चल रहा है। साथ ही इस आशय का भी शपथ-पत्र आवेदन के साथ मूल रूप में संलग्न करना अनिवार्य होगा कि संबंधित के विरुद्ध कोई निगरानी का मामला/विभागीय कार्यवाही/गम्भीर आरोप विचारालय/दण्ड अतिरिचित नहीं है।
- प्रबंधक (वित्त) के पद पर आवेदन के साथ अनुभव प्रमाण-पत्र के साथ के रूप में वर्णित पूर्ण अवधि का संबंधित संस्था/कम्पनी से प्राप्त किये गये यतन का **Bank Statement/TDS Certificate/Form-16** में से कोई एक अभिलेख संलग्न करना अनिवार्य होगा।
- BUIDCO reserves the right to shortlist candidates for written test/ interview.
- किसी प्रकार के विवाद की स्थिति में न्यायालय क्षेत्र पटना होगा।

रु०/-
प्रबंध निदेशक
बिहार शहरी आधारभूत संरचना विकास निगम लि
विरल सूचना www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar पर भी देखी जा सकती है।
नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार

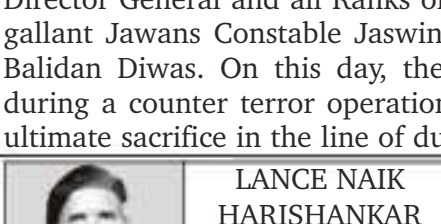
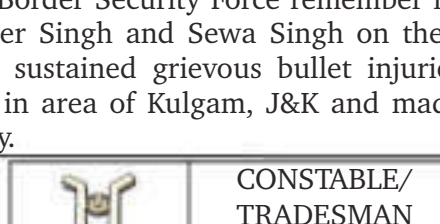
SALUTE THE SOLDIER

BORDER SECURITY FORCE	
 HEAD CONSTABLE DUMAHU RABHA 74 BN BSF 12.06.1964 – 06.06.2000	 CONSTABLE UDAYA POOJARY 74 BN BSF 20.02.1975 – 06.06.2000

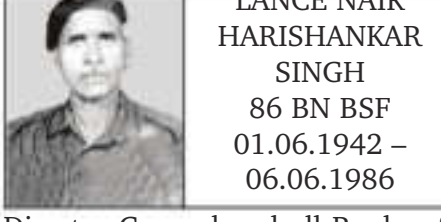
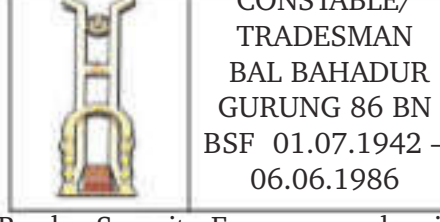
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans Head Constable Dumahu Rabha and Constable Udaya Poojary on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained grievous injuries in cross border firing in area of Manjakot, Jammu and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

 CONSTABLE JASWINDER SINGH 78 BN BSF 25.12.1972 – 06.06.1994	 CONSTABLE SEWA SINGH 78 BN BSF 01.04.1969 – 06.06.1994
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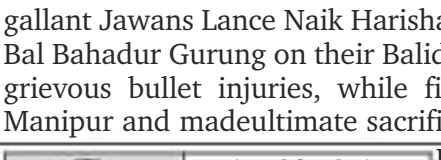
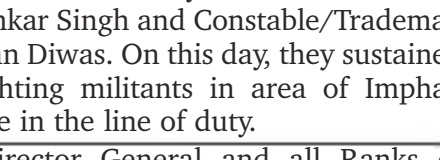
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans Constable Jaswinder Singh and Sewa Singh on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained grievous bullet injuries during a counter terror operation in area of Kulgam, J&K and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

 LANCE NAIK HARISHANKAR SINGH 86 BN BSF 01.06.1942 – 06.06.1986	 CONSTABLE/TRADESMAN BAL BAHADUR GURUNG 86 BN BSF 01.07.1942 – 06.06.1986
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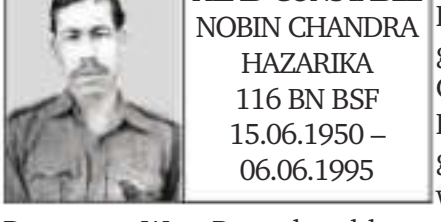
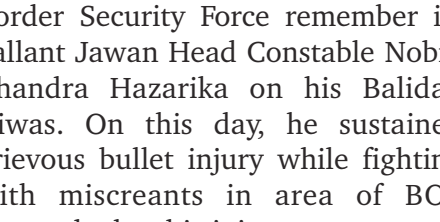
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans Constable Harishankar Singh and Constable/Bal Bahadur Gurung on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained grievous bullet injuries, while fighting militants in area of Imphal, Manipur and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

 HEAD CONSTABLE NOBIN CHANDRA HAZARIKA 116 BN BSF 15.06.1950 – 06.06.1995	 CONSTABLE/TRADESMAN BAL BAHADUR GURUNG 86 BN BSF 01.07.1942 – 06.06.1986
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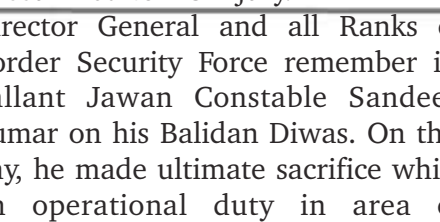
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Head Constable Nobin Chandra Hazarika on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained grievous bullet injury while fighting with miscreants in area of BOP Pannapur, West Bengal and later succumbed to his injury.

 CONSTABLE SANDEEP KUMAR 195 BN BSF 28.12.1983 – 06.06.2014	 CONSTABLE DEEN BANDHU PAL , PPMG 194 BN BSF 11.12.1973 – 06.06.2007
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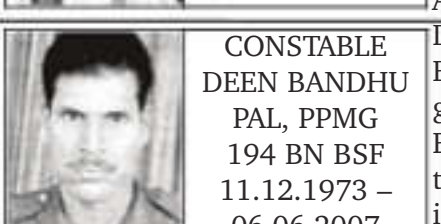
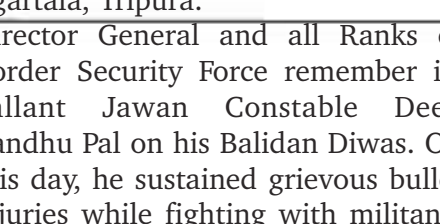
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Sandeep Kumar on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he made ultimate sacrifice while on operational duty in area of Agartala, Tripura.

 CONSTABLE RANJEET YADAV, GM 163 BN BSF 20.05.1987 – 06.06.2023	 CONSTABLE BALBIR SINGH 33 BN 08-08-1942 To 06-06-1990
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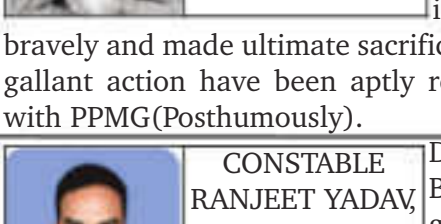
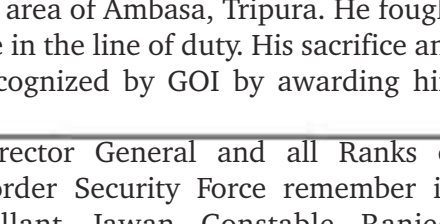
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Ranjeet Yadav on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injury, while fighting militants in area of Sugnu, Manipur. He fought bravely and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty. His sacrifice and gallant action have been aptly recognized by GOI by awarding him with PPMG(Posthumously).

 CONSTABLE VEER BALIDANI Head Constable Balbir Singh 33 BN 08-08-1942 To 06-06-1990	 CONSTABLE BALBIR SINGH 33 BN 08-08-1942 To 06-06-1990
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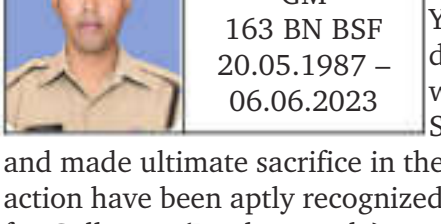
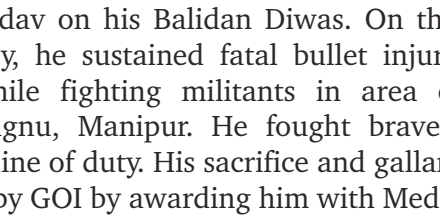
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Veer Balidani on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injury, while fighting militants in area of Sugnu, Manipur. He fought bravely and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty. His sacrifice and gallant action have been aptly recognized by GOI by awarding him with Medal for Gallantry (Posthumously).

 CONSTABLE VEER BALIDANI Head Constable Balbir Singh 33 BN 08-08-1942 To 06-06-1990	 CONSTABLE BALBIR SINGH 33 BN 08-08-1942 To 06-06-1990
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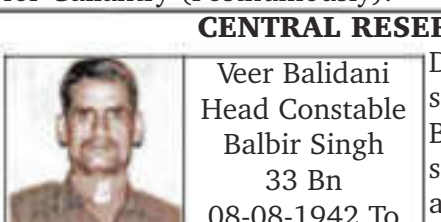
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Veer Balidani on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injury, while fighting militants in area of Sugnu, Manipur. He fought bravely and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty. His sacrifice and gallant action have been aptly recognized by GOI by awarding him with Medal for Gallantry (Posthumously).

 CONSTABLE VEER BALIDANI Head Constable Balbir Singh 33 BN 08-08-1942 To 06-06-1990	 CONSTABLE BALBIR SINGH 33 BN 08-08-1942 To 06-06-1990
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Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Veer Balidani on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injury, while fighting militants in area of Sugnu, Manipur. He fought bravely and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty. His sacrifice and gallant action have been aptly recognized by GOI by awarding him with Medal for Gallantry (Posthumously).

 CONSTABLE VEER BALIDANI Head Constable Balbir Singh 33 BN 08-08-1942 To 06-06-1990	 CONSTABLE BALBIR SINGH 33 BN 08-08-1942 To 06-06-1990
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Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Veer Balidani on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injury, while fighting militants in area of Sugnu, Manipur. He fought bravely and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty. His sacrifice and gallant action have been aptly recognized by GOI by awarding him with Medal for Gallantry (Posthumously).

 CONSTABLE VEER BALIDANI Head Constable

Shubhra Gupta

NOT ALL men. Or all men. Anurag Kashyap's *Bandar* places the viewer in a quandary: whom do you believe — a washed-out entertainer, refusing to understand the depth of his male privilege, claiming he's innocent, or the woman who claims that she is the victim of rape?

This is a difficult theme to sit with. Given that the real-life figures of Me Too accused in the Indian film industry, called out when the movement was at its peak in 2018, are now almost all rehabilitated, and that the women who do find the courage to come forward, find themselves ostracised and out of work, the central focus of *Bandar* forces viewers into examining their moral and ethical boundaries. As I'm sure it's meant to do.

I found myself conflicted through much of the film, swinging between feelings of

This is a difficult theme to sit with... This is also Kashyap's strongest film in a while; its spare, scrappy style working in tandem with the story

empathy and rage. On the one hand is the male protagonist who is flung into the slammer, there to be systematically debased by the horrors of prison: inhumanly overcrowded cells, filthy latrines, menacing inmates, threats of physical violation, and constant use of gutter language. On the other is the needy, fragile woman, desperately seeking connection, cast aside by the selfsame man after a casual, if consensual, one-night stand, which he callously claims was 'abortive' because she doesn't play into one of his fantasies.

Bobby Deol, in a career-defining performance, plays Samar Malhotra, not so much as an entitled jerk who once was a big noise in the entertainment industry — he doesn't want to do TV, which he finds limiting, only movies — but as a man who can swipe right and then be careless of the consequences of that action.

The rest of the cast does exactly what



The Anatomy of Doubt

the film needs: Sapna Pabbi as the woman who puts Samar in the dock, Sanya Malhotra as Samar's initially supportive but increasingly frustrated sister, Riddhi Sen as the hard-working lawyer, and Saba Azad as Samar's love interest, are all good.

I wished that the film worked through more of the discomfort it conjures up while challenging ingrained gender-dynamics. When it sticks to that lane, it is at its best: a female cop cringing at a condom in Samar's wallet, and the hard-core stuff he watches on his cell-phone — 'doms and young girls'; a girlfriend writing a letter as a confession to

BANDAR

★★★★

DIRECTOR: Anurag Kashyap

CAST: Bobby Deol, Sanya Malhotra, Saba Azad, Sapna Pabbi, Jitendra Joshi, Riddhi Sen, Indrajith Sukumaran, Raj B Shetty, Natesh Hegde, Sukant Goel

her own discomfort at his situation; and Samar himself not being a paragon of virtue.

And then *Bandar* turns into a dark prison drama (with impactful acts from Indrajith Sukumaran, Sukant Goel, Raj B Shetty, Natesh Hegde) and while it is successful at showing the degradation of Samar, it also clearly elicits sympathy for the man going through an ordeal he never signed up for. This is where the film shows where its own sympathies lie, for all its wanting to rock the boat. Did Samar, that monkey in a cage, really need that out, which can well be read as a cop-out?

Having said that, and while I continue to be conflicted, this is also Kashyap's strongest film in a while; its spare, scrappy style working in tandem with the story (based apparently on a real-life case), which chooses to show us a man who may not be as black as he's painted out to be, but is not all white either. And while it does come off as a gimmick, perhaps the climactic act of the flawed 'hero' breaking the third wall could refresh the much-needed conversation around Me Too, which has been tamped down by powerful men and powerless women.



He's the Man

Shalini Langer

IT DOESN'T do to go around dressed in a loincloth, wielding a shiny sword and declaring oneself "He-Man" these days — at least not in a big-bucks Hollywood film that is hoping not to cause any affront, to he, she, they, them, or it.

So how do you tap into a character that was born as a Mattel toy and largely remembered only by an audience who first encountered him as an animated TV series in the 1980s and is now into their middle age? Director Travis Knight and screenwriters Chris Butler and Adam and Aaron Nee (who have several award nominations between them) settle on a tone that is constantly mocking the whole concept while trying to kick off a successful franchise with it.

It is surprising how well they are able to do this when they do it well. It is as surprising how the film still manages to feel and look like a frenetic video game being played by a bunch of compulsive teenagers.

As He-Man aka Prince Adam of Eternia, Nicholas Galitzine must literally do the heavy lifting. The English actor is a good choice for, more than muscle, he wields his megawattage smile and blond, wholesome good looks, to give a He-Man with a difference, which is what this film is going for. As his arch enemy, Jared Leto is excellent as the faceless Skeletor, given the juiciest lines which he delivers with a flourish that puts him in the category of villains who almost walk away with the film. From "pitiful petulant pissant (and several more 'p's)" to "muscle-bound milquetoast", to "weak little palace boys", Skeletor lays out his contempt for Adam thick.

Camila Mendes and Idris Elba are the daughter-father pair of Teela and Duncan, Adam's loyal companions when he decides to take on Skeletor. The dark lord has for company Evil-Lyn (Alison Brie, living it up), his witch-at-hand who is just about

surviving with the few tricks she knows.

When Adam is just 10, Skeletor attacks Eternia and holds Adam's parents — the King and Queen — hostage. Adam escapes to Earth with the help of the Sorceress (Morena Baccarin). Fifteen years later, he is still dreaming of Eternia and to find the Sword of Power that will take him back there. When he does, with the help of Mendes's Teela, the film kicks off.

It feels compelled after that to keep kicking as much as possible, with Adam, Teela and the lot vs Skeletor's army of deplorables fighting in the sky, in flying objects one more inventive than the next, or on the ground, against imposing castles or rock faces for backdrop. At other times, they just fall and fall, onto flora in psychedelic colours.

In his Earth life, Adam worked in HR, where he was paid to be as faceless as possible, behind a nameplate that bore two pronouns, and learnt to talk the language of "how not to hurt feelings even when firing someone", and dialogue as the means of conflict resolution. Of course, this must clash with his new macho life in Eternia.

Masters of the Universe is smart about playing up the contrasts, particularly a sequence where Adam dreams of encountering Skeletor in different scenarios on Earth, including in pinstripes at work.

Among the many minor characters who are sketched out nicely is Roboto (Kristen Wiig), a warrior robot now turned into a helper robot, who has a mouth as much as a punch. However, *Masters of the Universe* is too eager to rush into fights, with no coherence about where and to what effect the battles are being waged — just that they are.

When the Sword won't help Skeletor as he holds it up and declares the magic words "I have the power", Evil-Lyn advises him to try again: "Once more, with feeling."

This is once more — you can't shake off that feeling.

Old Wine in Old Bottle

Shubhra Gupta

ONE MAN, two women, and two babies. Ooh, that sounds like an interesting premise, right? And with that seasoned master of fast-paced comedies, David Dhawan back in the saddle, this could well be the frothy summer comedy we've all been thirsting for, right?

Right. And wrong. Amongst the current line-up of male stars, there's hardly anyone who can play a feckless youth, recklessly planting his seed here and there, as energetically as Varun Dhawan. Jas is a wedding photographer, wooing two lovely ladies — Baani (Mrunal Thakur) and Preet (Pooja Hegde), respectively.

With BFF Maniesh Paul in tow, Jas is kept busy shuttling between India and the UK, beaches and castles, lawns and hospitals, as both women celebrate their bumps, and the prospective-daddy-o jumps through hoops to keep them separate and unaware of each other.

Other characters keep popping up to deliver their lines and disappear: as befits the supporting cast in a Dhawan film, their job is to not ask why. Jimmy Sheirgill, as Preet's strict brother, gushing over a dancer (Mouni Roy) who is pulled out of nowhere, keeps a straight face while delivering the most inane lines. Bit parts are divided between old partner-in-crime Chunky Pandey, the newly resurgent Rakesh Bedi and the omnipresent Johnny Lever, and others, and it's all same-old.

Keeping in mind Dhawan Senior's tra-



HAI JAWANI TOH ISHQ HONA HAI

★★★★

DIRECTOR: David Dhawan

CAST: Varun Dhawan, Mrunal Thakur, Pooja Hegde, Maniesh Paul, Jimmy Sheirgill, Mouni Roy, Chunky Pandey, Rakesh Bedi, Ayesha Raza Mirza

jectory, we don't really mind that the plot is wafer-thin. Who cares about a meaty storyline when all you need is for your cast to be careering around streets in lime-green cars, when not donning scanty beach-wear, and playing musical beds? What emerges, all too soon, is a slew of distinctly creaky, dated situations, which worked well enough in the '90s, and which should have been buried deep soon after.

What worked for a flagrantly politically incorrect time when the team of David Dhawan-Govinda-Kader Khan-Shakti Kapoor skilfully skated through the thin ice of vulgarity and hilarity comes off as plain cringe now: what do you say of a 'hero' who turns his twice-impending fatherhood into a 'Who's Your Daddy' joke, giving himself a clean pass, while setting himself up for a third go-around?

Just like the plot, the laughs are wafer-thin.

This Sisterhood Lacks Spark

Shubhra Gupta

CAN YOU really, truly ruin a perfectly interesting ensemble and the kernel of an idea that could have blown up into a fully feminist fun film, by not knowing quite how to build on it?

Maa Behen, bearing a title which cheekily wants to subvert that familiar invective prevalent in much of North India, in whose fictional town this film is set, gets lost in flabby, confused writing. And yet again, you wonder how films which squander their potential, and a great cast — apart from Madhuri Dixit-Triptii Dimri-Dharna Durga, this has the terrific Geetanjali Kulkarni and Shardul Bhardwaj among others — keep rolling out.

Remember these names from the famous *Nirmaad*? *Ma Rekha* (Madhuri Dixit) with her two wildly different daughters, Jaya (Triptii Dimri) and Sushma (Dharna Durga), is the fulcrum, around which revolve patriarchal fathers-in-law who can't make tea for themselves, entitled brothers-in-law who



demand fresh *rotis* hot off the tawa, careless husbands (Shardul Bhardwaj) who double up as licentious *jejas* flirting with uncaring *saalis*, and sundry other men who are either clueless or indifferent.

The setting of a *mohalla* where everyone else's business is not new, but when Rekha, resplendent in her sleeveless *cholis* comes riding in behind newly-acquired husband (Jatin Sarna), you

sit up. A bulked up neighbour (Ravi Kishan), who lives across the street with his long-suffering wife (Geetanjali Kulkarni) and two adult kids, is suspiciously disinterested in the new arrival.

A bloody body in a kitchen. A *laapata* gent. Wedding festivities underway. The hint of a re-kindled romance. The addiction to making reels. A small town and its cruel judgemental whispers. And a woman who

•STREAMING WATCHLIST



Brown

ZEE5

BROWN is a neo-noir psychological crime thriller set against the haunting beauty and moral chaos of Kolkata. At its centre is Rita

Brown (played by Karisma Kapoor), once the city's finest cop, now a disgraced, alcoholic officer haunted by the past. When a series of brutal murders shocks the city, beginning with the daughter of an influential businessman, Rita is reluctantly pulled back into the system. Teaming up with a grieving junior officer, Inspector Arjun (Surya Sharma), Rita is drawn into an investigation in a city that has grown more corrupt, more fractured, and far more dangerous than she remembers.



The Pyramid Scheme S1

PRIME VIDEO

THE PYRAMID Scheme Season 1 follows Goldy, an ambitious young man from Haridwar who gets drawn into a pyramid marketing business that promises quick wealth and an easy path to success. As he climbs the ranks, his growing ambition begins to put both his future and the trust of his close-knit family at risk. Directed by Ashish R Shukla and Shreyansh Pandey, and produced by The Viral Fever, the series stars Paramvir Singh Cheema, Ranvir Shorey, Shekhar Suman, and Anjan Srivastav in pivotal roles. *The Pyramid Scheme* Season 1 will stream in Hindi on June 5.



Primate

PRIME VIDEO

PRIMATE FOLLOWS a young woman who returns home to Hawaii for a college break, only to discover that her family's beloved pet chimpanzee has been

infected with a violent strain of rabies. As the island paradise descends into terror, she must fight to survive a threat she once trusted. Directed by Johannes Roberts and produced by Walter Hamada and John Hodges, the film stars Johnny Sequoyah and Troy Kotsur in lead roles. Produced by Paramount Pictures, *Primate* will stream on Prime Video on June 6.

Dhurandhar: The Revenge

JIOHOTSTAR

WRITTEN AND directed by Aditya Dhar, the spy action thriller is a sequel to the 2025 film *Dhurandhar* and serves as the concluding chapter of the duology. undercover RAW agent Jaskirat Singh Ranghi (Ranveer Singh) returns after infiltrating Karachi's notorious Lyari underworld under the alias Hamza Ali Mazari. Fuelled by a personal quest for revenge and the trauma of the IC-814 hijacking, Jaskirat systematically takes apart terrorist networks, confronts ISI operatives, and ultimately comes face to face with the enigmatic mastermind known as Bade Sahab. ALAKA SAHANI



MAA BEHEN

★★★★

DIRECTOR: Suresh Triveni

CAST: Madhuri Dixit, Triptii Dimri, Dharna Durga, Paresh Rawal, Ravi Kishan, Geetanjali Kulkarni, Arunoday Singh, Shardul Bhardwaj, **STREAMING ON:** Netflix

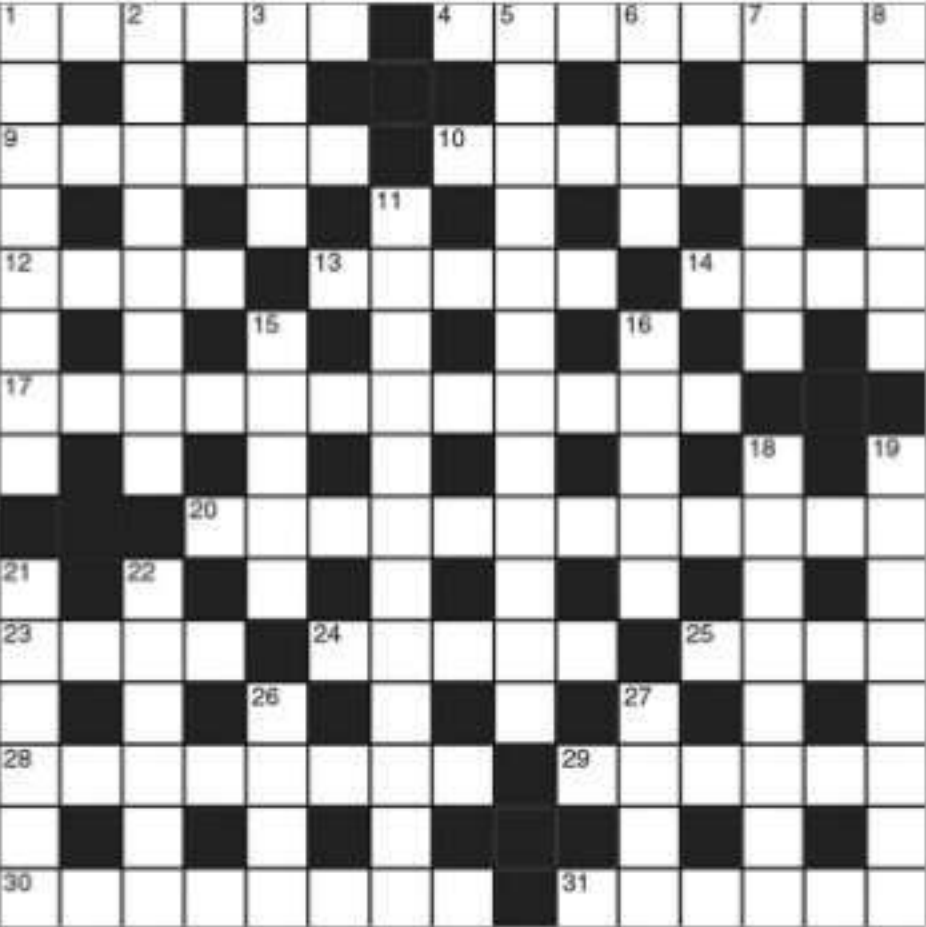
wears her sleeveless blouses with pride. So many ideas jostling for space, but so few landing; hard to believe that this comes from the director of *Tumhari Sullu* and *Jalsa*.

This had the potential to be a cracker *Manohar Kahaniya bhaabhi-ghar-par-hain*-style comedy, its darker edges being used to show men their place. And who better than Madhuri, whose fine comic bone Hindi cinema has never exploited fully, to front a spicy, pulpy flick which could have revealed the real *choli-ke-peechee* woman, fully and completely herself.

But it takes almost till the last quarter for the actual film to kick in, during which Dimri gets a breakout scene in which she dresses down her useless spouse (Bhardwaj is a hoot). Dharna shows just how talented she is in the brief flashes she gets, but, like the rest of the cast, is wasted in playing a type rather than a character.

Someone will make a film that will give Madhuri, ripe for a role in which she can play to her strengths, her due. Sadly, *Maa Behen* is not that film.

CROSSWORD



ACROSS
1 Strain — a trifle unexpected? (6)
4 Group together able to contain return of disorder (8)
9 Disregard one note and not another (6)
10 Overhead scales? (8)
12 Initially girls possess a frock (4)
13 Commanded by junior (5)
14 An image I'd behold in retrospect (4)
17 A hamper that's packed for Easter for example? (7,5)
20 Dramatic confidence? (5,7)
23 Ornithological specimens found in some museums (4)
24 Jumbo jet propeller? (5)
25 Responsibility gives us no turning back at the outset (4)
28 Heroic Greek units holding an elevated position (8)
29 In a European it is courteous (6)
30 Arrests drunkard in retreat - or drunkards (8)
31 Soft illumination leads to engagement (6)

DOWN
1 Honest and willing implies being easy prey (4,4)
2 Broadcasting band gives a lingering farewell (4,4)
3 Get out of doing something (4)
5 Joined issue (7,5)
6 Limits one's ambitions (4)
7 Borderland springs (6)
8 Wrap up and put the sheep to bed? (6)
11 Item of wear that's never worn out (12)
15 Possibly beat a retreat (5)
16 Moving creates a commotion (5)
18 Nine-inch ruler an ill-behaved child may ask for (8)
19 Mental view of a possible customer (8)
21 Meal is about over (6)
22 First film shots of stampedes (6)
26 Strike upsets close friends (4)
27 Trotsky turned up for the festival (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6007 ACROSS: 1 Asses, 4 Essayed, 8 Lei, 9 Utterance, 10 Affable, 11 Ether, 13 Knight, 15 Snorer, 18 Inter, 19 Ringlet, 21 Fascinate, 23 Got, 24 Resumed, 25 Shred **DOWN:** 1 All talk, 2 Skinfint, 3 Squib, 4 Either, 5 Surgeon, 6 Yon, 7 Drear, 12 Horologer, 14 Heroism, 16 Rotated, 17 Errand, 18 Infer, 20 Needs, 22 SOS

JUMBLLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Then stirs the feeling infinite, so felt In solitude, where we are _____, - Lord Byron (5,5)

DVAEE

●●●●●

PYAOS

●●●●●

ACEOLT

●●●●●

BALEEN

●●●●●

SOLUTIONS: Evade, Soapy, Locate, Enable alone. - Lord Byron

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL
4s **INSTRUCTIONS**
To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6341

				3	2
8	3	6			
5		7			9
1			4	5	
	2		5	9	
9	2				3
7			1	4	
				2	6
6	8				3

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6340

1	6	7	4	8	3	9	2	5
4	3	8	2	5	9	7	6	1
2	9	5	1	6	7	4	3	8
5	7	1	8	3	4	6	9	2
6	8	9	7	2	5	3	1	4
3	2	4	6	9	1	5	8	7
7	5	2	3	1	6	8	4	9
8	4	6	9	7	2	1	5	3
9	1	3	5	4	8	2	7	6

ROYAL STARS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Today, there is a Moon alert all day. The day is whatever you will make of it. It's a great day for the arts, socialising and enjoying the outdoors. Restrict spending to food and gas. Tonight: Privacy.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): You're high-viz today. You have no control over what people seem to know about your personal life. Be aware that there is a Moon alert all day. Restrict spending to food and gas. Tonight: Friendships.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Today you're eager to explore new ideas and see new places. You will also enjoy learning new things. Be aware that there is that Moon alert all day, so restrict your spending to food and gas. Tonight: You're admired.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Today you might be focused on shared property and financial matters. Nevertheless, be aware that there is a Moon alert all day. Restrict spending to food and gas. Postpone important decisions. Don't sign contracts. Tonight: Explore and learn.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Today the Moon is opposite to your sign, which means you have to go more than halfway when dealing with others. Be cooperative. There is a Moon alert all day. Restrict spending to food and gas. Be smart. Tonight: Check your finances.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): You make a great impression on others now because the Sun is high in your chart. You also have a strong desire to travel. Today, however, your focus is on pets, personal health and working. Moon alert is in effect all day. Tonight: Listen and cooperate.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): This is a wonderful day for artists. Be as productive as possible. It's also a great day to have fun. There is a Moon alert all day, restrict spending to food and gas. Tonight: Get better organised.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Home and family are your primary focus today. You might want to relax among familiar surroundings. Be patient with partners, spouses and close friends. There is a Moon alert today. Restrict spending to food and gas. Tonight: Socialise.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): You need to talk to others today. You'll also be pleased if you can learn something new today because your mind is curious. There is a Moon alert all day today. Tonight: Relax.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Financial matters might be a concern for you today. Many of you also might be contemplating some purchases. However, please be aware that there is a Moon alert in effect all day. Restrict your spending to food and gas. Tonight: Discussions.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): The Moon is in your sign today, which gives you an advantage over all the other signs. Nevertheless, today there is a Moon alert all day. Restrict spending. Postpone important decisions. But, enjoy socialising with others. Tonight: Check your possessions.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Enjoy relaxing at home today because you need some peace and quiet. Nevertheless, sports events, fun activities with kids and romantic outings might also appeal. Be aware that there is a Moon alert all day. Restrict spending to food and gas. Tonight: You win.

KERALA WATER AUTHORITY e-Tender Notice

Tender No: KWA/HO/SP-01/2026-27/ALUM

Supply and delivery of Alum Grade IV to various Division Offices of Kerala Water Authority on Running Contract Basis for the year 2026-27 **EMD** : Rs. 19,07,751 **Tender fee** : Rs. 25,000 **Last Date for submitting Tender** : 08-06-2026 03:00:pm **Phone** : 04712738348 **Website** : www.kwa.kerala.gov.in

Chief Engineer (HRD&GL) Jalabhavan Thiruvananthapuram

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.PC/84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Sandeep, S/o Chotu Ram R/o H.No. A 65, Shyam Vihar Phase-1, Najafgarh, New Delhi** Also at Village Jatas (94) CR Marg, District Mahendergarh (HR) has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.338/2018 u/s 498A/406 IPC, P.S. Najafgarh, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sandeep** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sandeep** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sandeep of FIR No.338/2018 u/s 498A/406 IPC, P.S. Najafgarh, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **07.07.2026**.

By Order,
Ms. Ebbani Aggarwal
Ld. Judicial Magistrate First Class (Mahila Court No.03)
DP/7479/DW/2026 Room No.312, South-West District, Dwarka, New Delhi

H.P. FOREST DEPARTMENT WILDLIFE DIVISION, KULLU

E-AUCTION NOTICE

E-Auction on behalf of Biodiversity Conservation Society (BiODCS), Shamshi will be held on 23.06.2026 for the following properties of Biodiversity Conservation Society (BiODCS), Shamshi situated at Van Vihar Siyal Bihal, Manali for a period of one year from the date of award of tender/auction that can be extended further for two more years on year-to-year basis.

“Ticket Window of Van Vihar Siyal Bihal, Manali HP

The detailed terms and conditions are available on the official website of Forest Department (www.hpforest.nic.in), e-auction India Portal (eauction.gov.in) and can also be obtained from the office of DFO WL Kullu on any working day. The e-auction shall be conducted on 23.06.2026 from 11:00 am to 3:00 PM through online mode on the same day. The interested bidders, in their own interest are requested to inspect the sites/Ticket Window before bidding. The auction inviting authority reserves the right to accept or reject the e- auction without assigning reason.

Executive Officer BioDes Cum
Divisional Forest Officer,
Wildlife Division Kullu, HP.

No. 0308/2026-2027/HP

Rajasthan State Mines & Minerals Limited

Date - 04/06/2026

Detailed Notice Inviting Tender

NIT No. & Date	Description of Work
e-Tender No. RSMM/CO/GGM (Cont) Cont-09/2026-27 dated 03.06.2026 UBN: MML2627WSOB00051	Supply of ROM Gypsum from Larawala Gypsum Mines at Tehsil- Bajju, District-Bikaner for Consumers/ Traders. contract value Rs. 222.00 lacs, EMD in Rs. 4.44 Lacs, Tender Fees Rs. 4720/-
e-Tender No. RSMM/CO/GGM (Cont) Cont-09/2026-27 dated 03.06.2026 UBN: MML2627WSOB00052	Supply of ROM Gypsum from Dhani Abdullawali Gypsum Mines, Tehsil-Bajju, District-Bikaner for Consumers/Traders, contract value Rs. 444.00 lacs, EMD in Rs. 8.88 Lacs, Tender Fees Rs. 4720/-

Other terms & conditions have been given in detailed tender for which please visit us at our website www.rsmm.com or www.sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in or eprocc.rajjasthan.gov.in or Sr. Manager (Contract) on above address.
Raj.Samwdd/C/26/4254 **DGM (P&A)**

NORTHERN RAILWAY OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

No. 128-W/260/Tender Notice/ 17-26-27/W-IV Date: 05.06.2026

The Divisional Engineer/IV, Northern Railway, Delhi Division for and on behalf of President of India invites E-Tender on prescribed form for the following work.

Invitation of tender through E-Tendering (E-Procurement Systems)

1 Name of work with its location	Delhi-Bathinda-TSR(P)-59.600 Tkm in the jurisdiction of DENIV/DLI. (NIT-17-26-27-W-IV)
2 Approx cost of work	Rs. 8,07,50,113.05/-
3 Earnest money	Rs. 16,15,000/-
4 Date and Starting time for filling e-tender is Date - 16.06.2026 at 15:00 hrs. & Tender opening time is Date - 30.06.2026 at 15:00 hrs.	
5 Website particulars, published e-tender, location notice etc. complete details of tender can be seen and web site where the tender form can be downloaded	Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in

NORTHERN RAILWAY Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement System

Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

S. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
01	77265185	NUT & BOLT CMS CROSSING	3400 SET	25.06.2026
02	09262536	SPRING PLANK FOR CASNUB 22 HS BOGIE	1137 NOS	29.06.2026
03	77265186	NUT & BOLT CMS CROSSING	2400 SET	29.06.2026
04	19261981	SET OF COMMUTATOR SWITCH ASSEMBLY COMPLETE	9 NOS	06.07.2026
05	07250149B	SECONDARY VERTICAL DAMPER FOR LHB NAC	2739 NOS	13.07.2026
06	07260203	FLEXBALL CABLE - LONG WITH END CONNECTION	202 NOS	23.07.2026

Note:- 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No manual offer will be entertained.

Tender Notice No.: 17/2026-2027 Dated: 05.06.2026 1927/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

H.P. FOREST DEPARTMENT WILDLIFE DIVISION, KULLU

E-AUCTION NOTICE

E-Auction for outsourcing the services of ticket window on behalf of Biodiversity Conservation Society (BiODCS), Shamshi will be held on 20.06.2026 for the following properties of Biodiversity Conservation Society (BiODCS), Shamshi situated at Van Vihar Dhungrri, Manali for a period of one year from the date of award of tender/auction that can be extended further for two more years on year-to-year basis.

“Ticket Window of Van Vihar Dhungrri, Manali HP

The detailed terms and conditions are available on the official website of Forest Department (www.hpforest.nic.in), e-auction India Portal (eauction.gov.in) and can also be obtained from the office of DFO WL Kullu on any working day. The e-auction shall be conducted on 20.06.2026 from 11:00 am to 3:00 PM through online mode on the same day. The interested bidders, in their own interest are requested to inspect the sites/Ticket Window before bidding. The auction inviting authority reserves the right to accept or reject the e- auction without assigning reason.

Executive Officer BiodCS Cum
Divisional Forest Officer,
Wildlife Division Kullu, HP.

No. 0307/2026-2027/HP

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Deepak @ Tuti S/o Ramesh R/o D-3, Vijay Vihar Phase-II, Delhi** also at Jhuggi No. 360, Indra Camp, Sec-3, Rohini, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 480/20 U/s 25 ARMS ACT, PS North Rohini, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Deepak @ Tuti** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Deepak @ Tuti** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Deepak @ Tuti** in **FIR No. 480/20 U/s 25 ARMS ACT, PS North Rohini, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **31.08.2026**.

By order
Ms. Aakansha
Judicial Magistrate First Class
North-West, Court No. 107, 1st Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/7409/RD/2026

SOUTH EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI)

Sub.: Expression of Interest (EOI) for Engagement of Professional Housekeeping Agencies for Better On Board Housekeeping Services (OBHS) in Coaching Trains over South East Central Railway.

On behalf of President of India PCME/SECR invites EOI to empanel competent and experienced agencies for providing enhanced and high-quality On-Board Housekeeping Services as per the policy guidelines on "Reforms for Better On-Board Services" and Technical Evaluation Criteria.

- EOI may be submitted in sealed envelope using prescribed format, along with complete details of technical offer and relevant documents. The EOI proposals should be submitted in the Box available in Dy. CME/Chg. & WS/SECR, First Floor, Mech, Wing, Old GM Building, Bilaspur 495004 (C.G.) during office hours from Monday to Friday.
- EOI offer and document can be downloaded from the website: <http://seccr.indianrailways.gov.in>
- Last Date & time of EOI documents submission: **Upto 15:00 Hours On 25.06.2026.**
- EOI Bid will open at: **15.30 Hours of 25.06.2026**

CPR/10/174 Principal chief Mechanical Engineer/ Bilaspur

South East Central Railway @seccr

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY (Railway Recruitment Cell)

5th Floor, 'C'-Block, Maurya Lok Complex, Dak Bungalow Road, Patna-800001

Ref: Notification No. ECR/HRD/Rec/Scouts & Guides Quota/2026-27 dated 04.06.2026

Indicative Notice No. 01/2026-27 dated: 04/06/2026

Detailed Notification for Recruitment in Level-1 & Level-2 against Scouts & Guides Quota for the year 2026-27 over ECR & RWP/Bela has already been uploaded at RRC/ECR's official website: www.ecr.indianrailways.gov.in > Hajipur H.Q. > RRC/Patna on 04.06.2026 vide notification No. ECR/HRD/Rec/Scouts & Guides Quota/2026-27. Willing candidates are advised to visit RRC/ECR's official website as mentioned above for further details and filling up online application. (Chairman)

Railway Recruitment Cell
PRI/0359/RRC/Patna/PERS/UL/Employment Notice/26-27/48 East Central Railway, Patna

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Rohit S/o Lala R/o House No. 136, Gali No. 6, Chanchal Park, Ranhola, New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence **FIR No. 50/2026 u/s 304(2)(3)(5) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita at P.S. Dwarka North, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Rohit** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Rohit** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding **u/s 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita** has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Rohit** accused of **FIR No. 50/2026 u/s 304(2)(3)(5) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita at P.S. Dwarka North, New Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on **20.07.2026**.

By Order: **Shri Rahul Katare,**
Judicial Magistrate First Class-06,
South-West District, Court No 514,
Dwarka Courts, New Delhi.

DP/7519/DW/2026

नीलामी सूचना

सर्व साधारण को सूचित किया जाता है कि दिनांक 12.06.2025 को जिला कारागार रोहतक के बंदियों द्वारा बचाई गई रोटियों सब्जी तथा दाल को उठाने के लिए ठेके पर देने हेतु ई आवशन के माध्यम से बोली करवाई जाएगी जिसके लिए आप अपना आवेदन eauction.gov.in पर जाकर कर दिनांक 05.06.2026 से दिनांक 10.06.2026 तक कर सकते है। टैंडर के सम्बंध मे कोई भी बोली दाता ई आवशन पर जाकर उपरोक्त टैंडर को एक वर्ष 15.06.2026 से 14.06.2027 तक ले सकते है।

टैंडर की शर्तें निम्नलिखित है।

- स्वीकृत ठेकेदार को बची हुई रोटियो व दाल सब्जी सप्ताह में दो बार जरूर उठानी होगी।
- स्वीकृत ठेकेदार की अवधि एक वर्ष के लिए होगी।
- नीलामी मे भाग लेने के लिए बोलीदाता को 50000 (पचास हजार रुपये) धरोहर राशि जमा करवानी होगी।
- अधीक्षक जिला कारागार रोहतक के पास बोली स्वीकृत एवं अस्वीकृत करने का अधिकार होगा व इस कार्य में उत्पन्न किसी भी प्रकार के विवाद का निपटारा स्थानीय न्यायालय मे होगा।
- ठेकेदार जेल के अन्दर किसी भी बंदी से किसी प्रकार का लेनदेन या व्यवहार नही करेगा और ना ही किसी प्रकार का ऐसा कार्य करेगा जो जेल नियमो के विरुद्ध हो। ऐसा करने पर उसे नियमो के अनुसार दण्डित किया जा सकता है।
- रोटी व दाल सब्जी उठाने के लिए स्वीकृत ठेकेदार को अपने वाहन का प्रयोग करना पड़ेगा।
- यदि स्वीकृत ठेकेदार उपरोक्त शर्तों को तोड़ता है तो इसकी धरोहर राशि जब्त करके ठेके को समाप्त कर दिया जाएगा।

No. 45926/HR



JUNE 11-JULY 19
48 TEAMS, 16 CITIES, 3 COUNTRIES

The 2026 FIFA World Cup, spread across the United States, Mexico, and Canada, is the biggest the sport has ever staged. There are the personalities — the players and powerbrokers who have shaped the four years since Qatar. There is the geography — Mexico and the United States have hosted this tournament before — and the nostalgia — of what happened on those pitches. And in this edition, there are some things happening for the first time.

HAND OF GOD

GOAL OF THE CENTURY, THE GRUDGE OF A LIFETIME

Sriram Veera

STEVE HODGE kept the shirt for 35 years.

He hadn't meant to be part of any of it. In the 51st minute of a World Cup quarter-final in Mexico City, he had tried to clear a ball, got it badly wrong, and looped it back towards his own goalkeeper. What followed - in less than a second, in the space that mistake created - would follow him for the rest of his life. After the final whistle he found Maradona in the tunnel and asked to swap shirts. He kept it for twenty years, loaned it to a museum, then held on a little longer. In 2022, he sold it at Sotheby's for £7.1 million. World record for sports memorabilia.

That is what one second of football made of itself.

June 22, 1986. The Azteca Stadium, Mexico City. 114,000 people inside. Four years since the Falklands War ended with Argentina humiliated, 600 soldiers dead, Las Malvinas still British. Maradona had told the press beforehand it was only about football. He knew that wasn't true. So did everyone on the pitch.

Peter Shilton - nearly 20 centimetres taller than the man running alongside him - came forward to punch the looping ball clear. Maradona raised his left fist and pushed it into the net. Referee Ali Bin Nasser awarded the goal. Shilton turned and chased him. The England players swarmed. Linesman Bogdan Dochey kept his flag down.

His teammate Sergio Batista got to him first. "You knocked it in with your hand, right? Did you use your hand?" Maradona's answer, as he wrote in Touched by God, was immediate: "Shut the f*** up and keep on celebrating." He was terrified. The TV replays were so conclusive he thought they might disallow the goal at half-time. He kept celebrating anyway.

At the post-match press conference, a journalist asked how he scored it.

"A little with the head of Maradona," he said. "And a little with the hand of God."

On Argentine television in 2005 he finally said what everyone knew: "As a kid in Florito I would score goals with my hand all the time. And I did the same thing in front of a hundred thousand people. But no one saw it."



His teammate Sergio Batista got to him first. "You knocked it in with your hand, right? Did you use your hand?"

What Shilton felt, and never stopped feeling, is worth understanding precisely. "People say I should have cleared the ball anyway and that I let a smaller man out-jump me," he told the Daily Mail. "That's rubbish." The part that never healed was not the goal. It was the silence after. "He never once said he had cheated. Instead, he used his 'Hand of God' line. That wasn't right. He had greatness in him but sadly no sportsmanship."

Shilton never spoke to Maradona again. When Asif Kapadia's documentary premiered



Diego Maradona lifts the 1986 trophy, widely considered the greatest performance by a single player at a World Cup. REUTERS/FILE

in 2019, he refused to attend.

Gary Lineker, at the other end of the pitch, told a FIFA documentary: "I don't have rage in me. I like Diego. He cheated us, but I've forgiven him." Then, on the second goal: "I felt like applauding. It was impossible to score such a beautiful goal."

The referee and his lines-

man spent the rest of their lives blaming each other.

Bin Nasser's account never changed. "The two players were facing me from behind. I was obliged to give the goal," he told Spanish

sports portal AS in 2022. Dochey, the Bulgarian whose flag stayed down throughout, reached a different conclusion

Gary Lineker, at the other end of the pitch, said: "I don't have rage in me. I like Diego. He cheated us, but I've forgiven him."

before he died in 2017. "Diego Maradona has ruined my life. He is a brilliant footballer but a small man. The goal scarred me for life. I was accused when I was not guilty."

Bin Nasser visited Maradona in Tunisia in 2015. Maradona called him his eternal friend. Then sold the match ball for £2 million.

Two men. One second. Combined: over £9 million at auction. Dochey got nothing. He had refused to meet Maradona. He said there was nothing to discuss.

Four minutes after the

hand, Maradona picked the ball up and beat five England players across 60 metres, scoring what would be voted the Goal of the Century. Argentine commentator Victor Hugo Morales sobbed into his microphone: "Cosmic kite, what planet are you from that you can leave so many Englishmen in your wake? Thank you God! For football! For Maradona! For these tears!"

Lineker, at the other end again, felt like applauding.

Maradona described the ball dropping to him in Yo Soy El Diego: "It floated down to me like a little balloon. Oh boy, what a treat." "It was the goal you dream of as a kid. Whenever I see it again, I can't believe I managed it. Not because I scored it, but because it seems a goal like that just isn't possible."

Former Argentine footballer Roberto Perfumo once said what many felt but few admitted: "In 1986, winning that game against England was enough. Winning the World Cup was secondary for us."

"Somehow we blamed the English players for everything that had happened, for everything that the Argentinian people had suffered. We were defending our flag, the dead kids, the survivors," Maradona wrote. In Kapadia's documentary he called it a beautiful feeling, a type of symbolic revenge against the English for las Malvinas. On his television show La Noche del 10 he told his audience that those who steal from a thief get a hundred years of forgiveness.

Shilton found the politicisation as upsetting as the goal itself.

On his 59th birthday, on Argentine radio, a journalist asked Maradona whether VAR would have ruled it out. "I promise the English I wouldn't score with my left hand. I'd do it with my right."

In Yo Soy El Diego, he wrote about what that afternoon made of him. "That goal became part of soccer history. There are still 10-year-old kids out there today with 'Maradona' on their backs. And that kind of insanity can only be explained by one goal."

He stopped.

"Or maybe two." The 2026 World Cup returns to Mexico. The Azteca still stands. Steve Hodge's drawer is empty now.

Feeling stressed? FIFA has 'sensory rooms' for the anxious

Shivani Naik

● A 2024 Nigeria vs South Africa AFCON match resulted in a cardiac arrest of a fan, after a penalty was awarded against Nigeria, which spiked his cortisol levels.

● A study by the New England Journal of Medicine found that in Germany, during the 2006 World Cup they hosted, "the incidence of cardiac emergencies was 2.66 times that during the control period."

● BBC reported in an Oxford University study that tested saliva from Brazilian fans during their historic 7-1 loss to Germany at the 2014 World Cup that levels of the hormone cortisol rocketed during the home defeat in the semi-final.

It isn't exactly new that watching football can prove to be dangerous, as it increases blood pressure and strain on the heart. Diehard fans can cop the worst of it, if they are enmeshed too deep into the sentiment of identifying with a team, and go further than that to acutely feel a sense of doom concentrated in 90 minutes (or 120 minutes + penalties at worse), should results not go their way. Sudden negative turnarounds, or even something as basic as a delay in reaching your stadium seat, can also prove stressful.

But this condition tends to be felt even more acutely for those with sensory processing needs. Underlying cardiac conditions, or even diagnosed anxiety sufferers, can find the in-stadia experience debilitating. This forced FIFA to come up with sensory rooms at each of the venues for fans with sensory needs. These rooms seek to mitigate sudden triggers that make the stadium feel like it's closing in.

While football remains an adrenaline-spike, not just for those playing but also those watching, sometimes the in-stadia cacophony and high intensity can get too much. A piece of research indicates that around 5% to 16.5% of people experience sensory processing needs - hypersensitivity and hyposensitivity. Anything from an edgy emotional investment in a team's fortunes to sudden distress due to the jumpy crowd, cramped bucket seating, persistent cheers and general noise and constant movement - any of these can lead to a feeling of being overwhelmed.

These sensory rooms are built keeping in view the needs of those who can suffer a sensory overload. Those vulnerable could be individuals with autism, post-traumatic stress dis-



A dejected fan after Brazil lost the 2014 semi at home. REUTERS

order, dementia, anxiety and other conditions which can get triggered and worse, go unseen in the whole frenzy by those around. The sensory rooms are designed to provide calming, supportive environments, a quiet oasis within the buzz of the match crowd, as per FIFA.

The Room

Once fans enter the precincts of any of the 16 stadia across Mexico, USA, Canada, every ticket holder will have access to a sensory room. One thing they promise is silence amidst the din. FIFA notes that these rooms will feature dimmed lighting, reduced noise, comfortable seating, tactile resources and Hisense televisions presenting calming visual content.

Think of those screen fillers in waiting rooms - like calm lakes, blooming flowers, gentle streams, mountains, sunrises, starry skies. It chimes into the tagline of "ensuring no one is left on the sidelines."

Besides the venue itself, sensory rooms are also planned in the Stadium Fan Experience area as part of the expanded footprint, FIFA says, adding that at eight stadia, both options will be available every minute on match days.

Also for the first time, clear sensory bags can be accessed at Fan Info points throughout the tournament for fans to use inside the stadiums, to be subsequently returned. These will contain noise-cancelling headphones, fidget tools and visual cue cards so they can communicate without having to speak.

Trained venue staff of FIFA will also assist fans with sensory needs and other accessibility needs. FIFA has introduced live sign language interpretation for all matches, broadcasts for which will be available for fans inside the stadium and watching elsewhere. Haptic boards, which are interactive tactile surfaces will be made available to the visually challenged fans at select stadia, while all matches will go out with audio-descriptive commentary.

{ 22 >>> 26 }

'Carlo, the redeemer': Can Brazil's first foreign coach in 100 years bring back glory?

Sandip G

A PANTOMIME meme, a bunch of football fans, and an old student awaited Carlo Ancelotti, when he landed in Rio de Janeiro's Galeao airport last year, in a private jet arranged by Brazil's football federation. The fans, in the wee hours flashing a poster, "Don Carlo, you are the man!, made him emotional. "I was moved," he told *O Globo* in an interview later. The student was the Milan and Real Madrid playmaker, Kaka, with whom he shares a deep bond, nourished by spirituality and football.

In the car to the hotel, security personnel showed him the meme, of him sulking near the touchline, a clip from a game during his Milan days, with the lines from Radiohead's song *No Surprises* bellowing in the background: "A job that slowly kills you..." In the six months or so, he saw hundreds of memes and reels with him as the central character. Some were happy ones, like him puffing a giant

cigar with Rodrygo, Vinicius Junior, Eder Militao (who were all part of the original picture shot after Real Madrid nailed the treble in 2024) with a photo-shopped image of Barcelona striker Raphinha and Neymar beside them. Brazil's football federation projected his acquisition as a coup, even though the dispensation was in a mess and faced suspension threat from FIFA. Some retired stalwarts called him "Carlo, the Redeemer!" Some criticised the federation for overlooking the local coachingspread, including his Milan favourite Cafu - Ancelotti is Brazil's first foreign coach since 1925. "He is an outstanding coach. But the coach of Brazil has to be someone who understands the culture and values, someone who talks our language," he said.

In the next six months, he was talking in Portuguese. When a group of federation employees tried to communicate with him in bits-and-pieces Italian and Spanish, he told them: "I should be the one who is

speaking in Portuguese!" He hired a Portuguese teacher and attended five classes a week. Even on a Sunday after he unfailingly attended the mass. He climbed the 2000-feet Corcovado, the granite mount, to reach the feet of Christ, the Redeemer. He met the local rector for a special blessing, who gave him a rosary.

He files a caveat, though. He loves Brazilian wine and food, which he restricts to once a day because he fears putting on weight. The pack of doubters turned into a herd of believers. A local television even carried out a survey, where it claimed that 43 percent of Brazilians liked, and only 20 disliked him.

The greatest team in the world gets the greatest manager of the world. This was the popular public rhetoric when he took over a team in shambles, drifting towards mediocrity after a forgettable



Carlo Ancelotti is hoping to replicate his all-time great success in club coaching with the Selecao.

COPA and an unflattering World Cup qualifying campaign. Brazil's federation has been wooing him since 2023, when he was managing Real Madrid, but it was not until May 2025 that they eventually landed him to "reinstate where Brazil once were," according to president Ednaldo Rodrigues. Ancelotti was measured in his words. He called Brazil "the strongest national team," yet emphasised that "we don't have a Pele, or Romario or Ronaldo, but we have a shared responsibility." He knew the challenges involved, not least that he was coaching a national team for the first time in his three decades of managing Europe's elite clubs.

His job, he reiterated, is to "get the best out of what we have." It's a platitude, but contains the soul of his managing style, and what he has been doing since he transitioned from a high-class defensive midfielder with AC Milan's dream team to a cuddly grandfatherly coach who forges an in-

tense personal relationship with players. He harnesses the players' ego to incredible performances, pampers some, rebukes some others, insists on rules to some, relaxes for others. He has managed the best of four different decades, and all the legendary names he had coached, from Zinedine Zidane and Ronaldo, to Gareth Bale and Vinicius Junior swear that he is the best to have coached them. Paolo Maldini once called him an unparalleled comedian. He is undogmatic, and bends tactics to suit his men. With Brazil, who has only played 10 games under him, winning six, he has shifted from 4-3-3 and 4-2-4. The front-four formation, he considers, "is the best model with the players we have."

The bold approach was conceived to hide Brazil's unusual full-back weakness and an imbalanced midfield equation that required reliance on ageing hands (rather legs) Casemiro and Fabinho. The forward-line is spoilt for choice, even without the injured Rodrygo and Este-

vao, or even if the recalled Neymar doesn't regain optimal fitness. The midfield has experience and bark, the defence is manned by the exemplary pair of Gabriel and Marquinhos. It has often deployed a double midfield pivot (Casemiro and Bruno Guimaraes) to bolster the defence, covering up for their relatively lightweight first-choice fullbacks. The talisman is undoubtedly Vinicius Junior, whose best spell in Madrid came under Ancelotti. With the Selecao, he has positioned him centrally, in a free role, where he can use his supreme creativity and finishing skills.

It's not merely glory that inspires Ancelotti. But the vibes, the feeling of being in a World Cup, just the kick of managing the game at the highest level, without worrying about the result. He has won the dressing room and fans. Now, it's about the only piece of silverware missing in his enormous shelf of trophies. Somewhere, a cigar is waiting to be lit. Like in the good meme.

Zverev inches closer to maiden Grand Slam, faces Cobolli

Reuters
Paris, June 5

ALEXANDER ZVEREV moved to within touching distance of a long-coveted maiden Grand Slam title, as the German fought past 26th seed Jakub Mensik 7-5 6-2 3-6 6-3 on Friday to reach the French Open final again. The 29-year-old, who has lost three major finals, including one at Roland Garros two years ago, has been sharp throughout in Paris this time and faces Flavio Cobolli after the other Italian Matteo Arnaldi withdrew due to illness.

"I knew that it would be my toughest challenge. I managed it and I won, so I'm happy," said Zverev, who became only the fifth active player to reach multiple Roland Garros title clashes. "It's amazing the way he (Mensik) played these last two weeks, he beat so many unbelievable players. He started playing amazing in the third set, stepping up his level, but this is a Grand Slam with best-of-five-set matches.

"Things happen and your opponents will play better. You have to deal with it. I hope to play another great match on Sunday." A tight opening set on a sun-kissed Court Philippe Chatrier tilted Zverev's way when he struck a backhand crosscourt winner in the 11th game to bring up a break point, and he nudged ahead with a delicate shot that Mensik sent into the net. The world number three sent down a powerful ace to pocket the first set and asserted himself with an early break at the start of the second set, as the 20-year-old Mensik's level briefly dipped in his maiden Grand Slam semi-final.

Flavio Cobolli reached the French Open final after his semi-final opponent, fellow Italian Matteo Arnaldi, withdrew from the match on Friday due to a virus.

PREVIEW: ONE-OFF TEST

India's transition journey faces another Test against Afghanistan

As Afg grab the rare opportunity to probe India's dented home ledger, the hosts have been handed an even rarer window to reassess their capabilities

Lalith Kalidas
New Chandigarh, June 5

A LOCAL Punjab pacer who bowled in the Afghanistan nets at the New PCA Stadium on Thursday was treated to a surprise during his stint. "Inka Test squad bilkul alag hai (their Test team is quite different)," he said with evident admiration.

For a young Test nation -- just eight years old -- the diverse options are noteworthy. Even with a horde of their white-ball superstars not around, there is promise in Hashmatullah Shahidi's camp. But limitations of having only played a collective 12 Tests sometimes show up in the form of a standard Indian bowler in the nets. "I bowled Rahmanullah Gurbaz twice in the nets," the young seamer said, detailing his experience to a bowling partner.

India, meanwhile, can ill afford even a trace of such complacency in the gruelling New Chandigarh heat. Even with only a week's turnaround from the IPL season, preparations at their latest Test venue were far from relaxed.

Head coach Gautam Gambhir on Friday insisted that Shubman Gill's men had already crossed a major transitional hurdle in England last year. But the 0-2 home surrender to South Africa last November still stung the backroom staff. The defeat underscored the preparations required for a fledgling Test unit and management.

"The one thing we have realised is that we need to start preparing better in red ball cricket. That was something which was lacking against the West Indies and also against South Africa [last year], that we have got to do going forward," Gambhir told reporters on match eve.

As Afghanistan grab the rare opportunity to probe India's dented home ledger, the hosts have been handed an even rarer window to reassess their capabilities mid-way through a World Test Championship (WTC) cycle. Getting the sub-continental game back on track will be imperative as an August tour to Sri Lanka and a home Border-Gavaskar Trophy in early 2027 loom on the WTC calendar.

Next big spinner

Activities in Mullanpur suggest India have identified several key areas that need attention. Continuity at No. 3, a strategic repurposing at five and a need to unearth battle-hardened spinners seem high on the agenda.

In Ravindra Jadeja's absence, a quest to seal his potential successor will be explored with Manav Suthar or Harsh Dubey. One of them is set for a debut, with the decision likely to shape future selections. While the former churns out wickets with a repeatable action, the latter's pronounced drift and wily utilisation of the crease offer Jadeja-like traits. Gambhir, however, remained



Indian batter KL Rahul practices on the eve of the Test in New Chandigarh. KAMLESHWAR SINGH

tight-lipped, stressing that the finer points between the two will define selection on match day and beyond.

"You don't only see that they are two left-handers, but you also see the release points, what someone gets off the wicket, the trajectories and who is probably more suited for red ball cricket. This probably is the only Test where we can think of looking at someone who could be our fourth spinner. When we go to Sri Lanka, we might have to try a fourth spinner as well," he said.

After seven men walked through the revolving door in the last two years, the management has favoured Sai Sudharsan as the favourite to plug the number three gap despite his mixed 2025 initiation. Shadow-batting barefoot on the open strip before play, Sudharsan firmly positioned himself for his seventh outing over the re-

turning Devdutt Padikkal.

"It's not about giving someone five Tests and someone else one Test match. If we give someone a fair run, we will give the other guy a fair run as well whenever he gets the opportunity. But at the moment, I think we've got to give Sai a fair run," the head coach said.

The most closely watched recalibration on match day will involve Rishabh Pant. Captain in India's previous Test in Guwahati last year, the glaring ramifications of his impetuous batting in the same match have paved the way for his demotion with a clear directive.

Starting his 50th Test, India's highest six-hitter -- just six short of a landmark 100 maximums -- will have to take fresh guard without being the vice-captain. While his daredevilry continues to be appreciated, his aptitude to assess situ-

ations has yet to be ascertained.

Throughout his batting session at the secondary facility on Thursday, Pant held his shape through vertical shots and a compact defence, while an eagle-eyed Gambhir observed from behind the net.

"We will expect him to be the way he is. We aren't telling him to curb his natural game. But in international cricket, it's very important to read the situation and play your shots accordingly," said Gambhir.

With several players seeking to establish themselves, India's assignment is not entirely different from Afghanistan's challenge. At another unfamiliar home venue, Gill's side enter the Test with as many questions to answer as opportunities to seize.

INDIA V AFGHANISTAN TEST:
Live on Star Sports Network & JioHotstar; 9:30 am

Norway Chess: Gukesh, Carlsen fight for pride

Amit Kamath
Oslo, June 5

WHAT A difference 12 months can make. A year after India's D Gukesh and Magnus Carlsen found themselves in a final-day race to win Norway Chess 2025, the world champion and the world no 1 again found themselves in a final round scramble for position.

Only this time, when Gukesh faced Carlsen on Friday in the final round of Norway Chess 2026 at Oslo's Deichman Bjørvika, they were looking to avoid last spot in the standings while R Praggnanandhaa, Wesley So and Alireza Firouzja jockeyed for the top spot.

It has been a bruising tournament for both Gukesh and Carlsen, with the former winning just one of his nine classical games while the Norwegian has won two. Both players have lost four classical games each in Norway Chess. Despite a performance rating of 2669 in his first nine games, Carlsen lost 21 rating points. Gukesh, with a performance rating of 2636 at this tournament, lost 12 rating points.

Ahead of the final round, they were the only ones in the six-player field to have dropped rating points.

Heading into the final day, Carlsen was on 10 points while Gukesh had eight, which means that the Indian could only escape last spot by defeating Carlsen in the classical section.

Contrasting results

Both of them came into Norway Chess on the back of contrasting results. The world champion has not won a single tournament since winning the elusive title and has looked out of form. During this year's Norway Chess, he has spoken about feeling "happier and much sharper", even if the results do not reflect that.

His coach, Grzegorz Gajewski, believes that despite the

20-year-old not being at his A game recently, all he needs is one performance-boosting sequence of results for him to become the Gukesh of 2024 when he swept all in front of him, including the Candidates and the World Championship.

Gajewski says there is a lot of work happening in the background, but the nature of chess is such that the results of all the work show when you least expect it. For now, Gajewski believes that what's important with Gukesh is the "level of resilience" he has been showing, by playing aggressive, provocative chess game after game despite the results not going his way.

"Obviously, his classical results were very disappointing, for both of us. Even if you look at his recent results from the rapid and blitz event of the Grand Chess Tour in Warsaw, it was not mindblowing. But he kept a level. People understand that he achieved a certain level. People thought that he was overperforming for a 17-year-old, and after that, he's been fairly underperforming. It's just a matter of time for him," said Gajewski, who has been with Gukesh since 2023.

At the other end, the world no 1 from Norway has found a hot streak across different formats, winning the World Rapid Championship, the World Blitz Championship, the FIDE Freestyle World Championship, the Speed Chess Championship by Chess.com and the TePe Sileman Tournament.

"I think his form has been good in that sense. I think he said it himself; maybe he played even better when he was younger. But I still think he plays pretty well," Carlsen's long-time coach Peter Heine Nielsen had told *The Indian Express* in an interaction last week about Carlsen's form and his gameplay.

(The writer is in Oslo at the invitation of Norway Chess)

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